

The Aranea Queen Campaign

The Rebirth of Leira
The Trouble-series

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Introduction

About this module

The Aranea Queen Campaign is designed for a party of 4-6 1st level PCs, a good balance of character classes is advised. It takes place in the Nether Mountains in the Silver Marches region of the Western Heartlands in Faerun using the Forgotten Realms setting. When the campaign ends the PCs should be at 10th level.

All encounters can be easily modified to suit larger or smaller parties. Encounters range from easy to deadly and players should be advised that not all encounters need to be solved with violence.

When a dwarf from a local mine is found dead, the PCs are sent to investigate. Once at the mine the PCs discover that something terrible has happened and need to find a way to make things right again. That will take them on a quest in the Nether Mountains where they get the chance to see a dead goddess being reborn.

This book is meant for Dungeon Masters and refers to the Player's Handbook, Dungeon Master's Guide, Volo's Guide to Monsters, Storm King's Thunder and Monster Manual. Spells and items are described in the Player's Handbook, magic items can be found in the Dungeon Master's Guide and stat-blocks for monsters and villains are contained in the Monsters Manual unless otherwise noted.

RECENT DEVELOPMENTS

Long before the Spellplague the aranea city Laz'Shadamar blossomed under the rule of queen Zax E'alatha. In the Year of the Cauldron, 1378 DR, the Blood of Morueme, a clan of blue half-dragon hobgoblins that lived in the castle of Doomspire in the Nether Mountains, discovered the city and raided it in hope of enslaving the shapeshifting arachnids. The real reason behind the attack was the Morueme's leader's desire to get her hands on a Queen Egg and dig through its treasures and powerful magic.

Queen E'alatha, chosen of the goddess Leira, dispatched a small retinue of aranea sorcerers, priests and wizards, with a queen egg, an artifact sacred to the survival of the aranea race, as a contingency should the raiders manage to breach the city's defenses. The party hid the egg and cast powerful defensive spells on the artifact and the room containing it.

The Blood of Morueme and their army bore down on the city and quickly managed to breach the defensive illusions and enchantments. Many araneas were murdered and enslaved that day, and queen E'alatha watched in horror as the blue skinned hobgoblins ravaged through the city, house by house. She summoned her royal court and the surviving aranea to her palace and decided that it was a better fate for her people to die by her hand, than fall into the hands



of the Blood of Morueme, hoping that since the Aranea egg was save, her kin would survive. When the raiders finally managed brake through the palace walls all they found was hundreds of dead araneas, many already rising as undead. Queen E'alatha was nowhere to be found.

Few weeks ago, a dwarven clan, the Ironboots, discovered the Aranea egg room, not far from their mine underneath the Nether Mountains, not far from the small village Deadsnows. They broke into the room and removed the egg, unleashing the powerful defensive spells upon themselves. The Burnt Hand Clan, a group of kobolds under the rule of the red dragon Alizarinathrax, attacked the dwarves and managed to overrun them and took many dwarves captive, thinking that the dwarves would be great source of food for the dragon. The kobolds also ransacked the mine and among other things took the egg.

In Doomspire the Aranea slaves sense that the Aranea Egg was no longer stored in the room, felt its call and grew unrestful. The hobgoblin masters, the blue dragons of Doomspire, send out half-dragon sorcerers to find the egg.

Adventure overview

CHAPTER 1-3

Torbin Ironboot, elder of the Ironboot clan, is discovered dead in Deadsnows. Rubert Anon, cleric of Lathander, asks the PCs to inform the clan of their elder's death. The mine is in the Nether Mountains and the town has had a good relationship with the dwarf clan ever since the town was reformed. The trip takes a couple of days but once there the PCs discover something terrible has happened.

The mine is empty and there are obvious signs of struggle. The main hallway, leading down into the mining area is sealed off, closed with all manner of debris and overturned furniture. Once the PCs go deeper into the mine they find that the dwarves had opened a strange chamber, one with a pedestal with a nest for something. The nest used to store an Aranea

Queen Egg, artifact left by the Aranea, in time of dire need.

The dwarves discovered the chamber and removed the queen egg, waking the guardians. The guardians, after battling the dwarf clan, try to summon the elders of the Aranea clan. A local clan of kobolds, divided by internal bickering between the leader and his son, Kax, made the most of the opportunity when it discovered that the dwarves where gone and looted the mine and enslaved the remaining dwarves. The PCs need to find the kobolds and discover what happened to the egg and the dwarves.

CHAPTER 4-6

The Aranea Egg is in Deadsnows and no one seems to know what it is. The PCs are asked by Rubert Anon, a cleric of Lathander living in Deadsnows, to figure out what this thing is and why it was secured in the strange room in the Ironboot Mine. Since the village's library was destroyed in the Spellplague and hasn't been restored the PCs are advised to find Rolinda Fenabar, leader of the dwarves is the Fenabar Hold of Dugmaren, in the Icespear Valley.

The Aranea Egg is of importance to many different parties. The druids of Emerald Enclave seek it, the Blood of Morueme seeks it, after all, this is a powerful artifact.

The PCs investigation leads them to the ruined underground city of Laz'Shadamar, where they can discover what happened all these years ago and the sad fate of the aranea who lived there. What they discover there can have a major impact on the divine sphere of the Realms. Discovering the Hidden Temple and removing the shadow that rests upon it, along with bringing the Aranea Egg back to Laz'Shadamar, will affect the rise of a goddess, who many believe to be dead.

CHAPTER 7-9

The PCs trek through the Nether Mountains in search of the infamous and fortified village Doomspire, where the Blood of Morueme lives and hold the Aranea captive. Enroute the evil red dragon, Alizarinathrax, who had carved out her own little



fiefdom in the mountains not far from the village Deadsnow, attacks the PCs, eager for vengeance. The dragon wants to see the PCs burn for their part of freeing the Ironboot clan from the Burnt Hand Clan, the dragon's kobold slaves. After dealing with the dragon the PCs meet an old friend, Ol'Tom, a local druid, who brings them a message from Deadsnows and tells them more about Doomspire.

After finding the village the PCs need to find a way to enter it and find the Aranea Queen. They need to be subtle, resourceful and find ways to disrupt the hobgoblin community enough to make sure that the Aranea slaves can escape without being re-captured or slaughtered.

They need to protect the Aranea from hobgoblin war party, led by a half-dragon hobgoblin sorcerer, sent to bring the Aranea slaves back. Once they manage to get back to Laz'Shadamar they find that a druid from a nearby gnome settlement and part of the Emeral Enclave, is waiting for them, eager to claim the Aranea Queen Egg as his. If the PCs manage to beat the druid, they can witness when the Aranea return to their ancestral home and the Lady of the Mist, Leira, rise again.

The Aranea Queen Egg

Wondrous item, artifact (needs attunement)

The Aranea is a secretive race. Not many have known these arachnid shapeshifters and that's the way the Aranea like it. Long time ago the leaders of the Aranea received three Queen Eggs as a gift from goddess Leira, one for each of the great Aranea clans. The Queen Eggs were meant for the rulers, both as a symbol of power and office, but also as means to maintain and make sure that the race's secrets and age old wisdom was passed to next generations.

One of these eggs was kept in Laz'Shadamar. When Queen E'alatha learnt about the impending attack of the Blood of Morueme, she made sure that the Queen Egg was hidden and kept safe under powerful protective spells. Little is known about where the other two Queen Eggs are today. Unbeknownst to E'alatha the goddess Leira also hid a part of her

divine spark in the egg, foreseeing that someday she might need it again.

The Queen Egg allows each owner to store part of her knowledge or essence in it, each egg is therefore a trove of information. The egg will resent any attempt to coax information from it and will not surrender easily to anyone not Aranea. Those who try to bend the Queen Egg under their will might find themselves become enslaved by the egg.

Each Queen egg is a rough white crystal orb, seeming almost like unworked gemstone, only few inches in diameter. When used prismatic colors swirl inside it and shadows play over the surface.

While attuned to a Queen Egg, you can use an action to peer into the eggs depths and speak its command word. You must then make a successful DC 15 Charisma Check. On a successful check, you control the egg as long as you remain attuned to it. On a failed check, you become charmed by the egg as long as you remain attuned to it.

While you are charmed by the egg, you can't voluntarily end your attunement to it. The egg casts Geas on you at will (save DC 18), which refrains you from doing harm to Aranea. Each egg has its own desires, which all include the survival of the Aranea race.

PROPERTIES

While attuned to the Queen Egg you gain proficiency in History.

While attuned to the Queen Egg your Intelligence score increases by 2.

While attuned to the Queen Egg you become vulnerable to fire.

Spells

The Queen Egg has 5 charges and regains 1d4+1 expended charges daily at midnight. If you control the Egg you can use an action and expend 1 or more charges to cast one of the following spells (Save DC 18) from it: Alter self (1 charge), Mirror image (1 charge), Hypnotic pattern (2 charges) and Major image (2 charges). You can also use the Egg to cast Detect magic without using any charges.



Well of Ages

While you control the Queen Egg you can use an action to reach into the accumulated wisdom of the Queen Egg. In the following round you have advantage on any Intelligence skill check.

Symbol of Power

The Queen Egg is a symbol of power for the Aranea. Anyone presenting the Queen Egg has an advantage on any Charisma based checks involving interaction with Aranea. You can also use an action to cast Mass Suggestion as 18th level caster, but this only works on Aranea.

Destroying a Queen Egg

The Egg appears as a crystal stone, but is extremely hard and impervious to most damage. A disintegrate spell or a hit from a +3 or better magic weapon is sufficient to destroy the egg, however.

Social Collapse Rules

Doomspire is a large village, where over 500 hobgoblins and about as many slaves live under the strict order and rule of their clan leaders. Defeating the clan is not an easy feat and it will take much more than might and magic. The PCs need to be clever, even devious at times, and use the constant power struggle within the hobgoblin tribe to their advantage.

The Social Collapse Rules presented here are to help the players visualize and understand the impact they can have on the hobgoblin society. Feel free to edit and add to them. The rules secondary goal is to give the players freedom to find their own way in freeing the Aranea slaves.

In order to make the hobgoblin strict order crumble and create enough diversion for the Aranea to flee, the PCs need to collect 8 social collapse points (SCP), see the table below. But time is also a factor, for every 24 hours that pass they lose 1 SCP. Two hours after the PCs have gathered 8 SCP the society collapses, the five hobgoblin warlords and their commanders start brutally fighting among themselves, leaving the slaves mostly unattended. The more SCPs the PCs have, greater the fighting and easier it is for the Aranea to escape.

See the table for examples of actions taken that give SCP. Feel free to add more actions to it or edit it so it suits your group's playing style the best. Collapsing the hobgoblins society should take more than might and magic, the PCs need to be clever, cunning and understand what makes the hobgoblins tick. Reward clever thinking, but remember the hobgoblins are not stupid, e.g. if the granary is burned down, they will post guards at other places where they store their food.

Few weeks ago the half-dragon hobgoblin Sha'Xala was sent out on a mission to retrieve the Aranea Queen Egg. The hobgoblins felt a disturbance in the Aranea slaves and Roraurim divined that the Aranea Queen Egg was no longer stored where he couldn't sense it, though he failed to scry its exact location. Sha'Xala, a competent sorcerer, was sent to investigate and has been trying to find the PCs, with no luck so far. Six days after the PCs enter Doomspire Sha'Xala returns to Doomspire, convinced that the Egg is now in the village and fears what trouble it might cause among the slaves.

If the PCs are still in Doomspire on the morning of the sixth day, and the warlords are still on good terms, and Ardo is still acting-ruler of the village, a warning horn will sound. The war parties will go from house to house, searching for the egg, rounding up slaves and through brutal display of force and strength make sure that the slaves are demoralised, fearing for their lives. All SCP earned are halved and it becomes much harder to convince the slave leaders to revolt, the village will be on high alert (raise all DCs concerning the SCPs by 3) and partols will walk the streets with regular intervals.

SOCIAL COLLAPSE POINT VALUE

Examples of actions, feel free to add to this list.

1 point

- Setting houses on fire.
- Poisoning water.
- Destroying food supply.
- Freeing the bulls or worgs from their pen.
- Framing a sub-commander for something he didn't do.



- Convincing one war party that some of the other war parties have talked ill of them.

2 points

- Defiling a shrine.
- Convince/Intimidate/Persuade the goblin tribes to revolt.
- Turn the Librarian against the hobgoblins.
- If the village is set on high alert.

3 points

- Killing a warlord.
- Getting two warlords to fight each other.
- Getting two war parties to fight each other.
- Killing Ardo'Uloan, the Son of Morueme.

4 points

- Killing a blue dragon member of the Morueme.



Chapter 1: In Deadsnows

Dawnlord in distress

The PCs are on their way to Deadsnows following the Fork Road. It's late Mirtul, grass turning green and rivers, once clad with ice are whitewashed and hard to cross. As the hot day passes the PCs draw nearer to Deadsnows. If one or more PC has a **Passive Perception 13** or higher they hear a spell boom up the road, the sound of battle and shrill screams. Read or paraphrase the following, if they PCs decide to investigate.

A cart has been turned over in a fork of the road. Several small creatures surround the cart and send volleys of pebbles over it, screaming with delight. A few of them move forward with crude daggers and clubs. A lone man stands beside the wagon, holding a golden symbol high. He calls forth a rosy-hued shimmering light around himself. Blood stains his face. The attackers will soon overrun him.

With successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Religion) check** they recognize the cleric as a priest of Lathander. His name is Rubert Anon (see appendix), who is returning from Sundabar. Rubert is a local priest and lives in Deadsnows. If the PCs help him he will be

thankful and talk highly of the PCs in Deadsnows. Rubert will fight to defend his cart.

He's armed with a quarterstaff and has used Shield of faith to bolster his defense. He has already used sacred flame and cure wounds. If the PCs enter the fight he will use bless but save the remaining spell slots for healing.

The attackers are 6 **red scaled kobolds** (see MM p. 195), a small group led by **Kax** (see appendix, also see VGM p. 165), son of Roqua, leader of the Burnt Hand Clan. Each kobold has burn marks on the left hand. If half of the kobolds are slain the rest flees. The kobolds try to use their slings as much as they can but once in melee they use their pack tactics. Their goal is to loot the cart and two kobolds will use their actions to do so. Kax urges his kobolds on speaking Draconic, eager to impress his draconic master and taking his father's place as clan's speaker. Kax is the first to flee the scene.

Kax is a despicable little creature and will use every opportunity to belittle the PCs. He leads from the rear but is easily recognizable by his red cloak, studded leather armor, eye patch and squeaky voice. His warriors are fearless while he's there.



If the PCs intervene the kobolds fight for three rounds. If they manage to bring down a hero and if they have not looted the cart they fight on for another two rounds. If they see that the PCs are putting up a good fight, Kax calls his warriors back and flees, Kax doesn't participate in the encounter in any other manner. If the kobolds have managed to loot the cart they leave. If the PCs try to talk to the kobolds they are only interested in getting their hands on the treasure the PCs and Rubert have. If the PCs capture a kobold and interrogate it, the kobold says that Kax led the raiding party and the goal was to collect treasure for Alizarinathrax, the red dragon living deep in the Nether Mountains and the kobold clan pays homage to.

Once the kobolds have been left Rubert thanks the PCs. If they managed to thwart Kax's plan to loot the cart, Rubert is all the more grateful. In the cart, he has a small box containing 350 gold pieces, a support from the Lathander church in Sundabar for the new church in Deadsnows. Rubert offers to heal the PCs' wounds, if there are any. He invites the PCs to accompany him the last few miles to Deadsnows. Rubert informs the PCs that kobolds have been a nuisance since last summer and the town's militia and rangers have tried to keep them down, but there have been reports of the kobolds attacking both travelers and small caravans.

Sunlight sensitivity and Kobolds

The kobolds attack in broad daylight. If you have access to Volo's Guide to Monsters you could allow the kobolds to use Pack Tactics, to counter-effect their Sunlight Sensitivity. However, this encounter is not meant to be very dangerous.

Traveling through Icespear valley

The Icespear Valley is a peaceful place. It rests between the Nether Mountains and the steep lower mountainsides are covered with fir and pine woods. The woods are scarce the higher you get, and the mountain tops are covered with ice and snow.

Many farms dot the valley, though most of them rest near the village. Sheep and cattle graze in the valley, guarded by sheep dogs and sleepy teenagers.

The Icespear River is swollen and whitewashed, due to snow melting high in the mountains. The days are hot but as soon as the sun sets the cold creeps in, a nasty reminder that the summer hasn't taken completely over.

In the northern part of the Valley stand the ruins of Hospice of Marthammor Duin. Formerly an abbot dedicated to the dwarven deity it stands now as a dark reminder of the effect the Spellplague had on the Icespear Valley.

Caravans and traveling merchants make their stop in Deadsnow while traveling the Fork Road between Ascore and Sundabar. Militia from Deadsnows occasionally traverse the road from Deadsnow to Fork Road and with the help of locals try to keep the path free of danger.

A dead dwarf in the gates

As the PCs draw nearer to Deadsnows they spot a village being rebuilt. There are both new houses, houses rebuilt and old houses either crumbled or about to. The walls surrounding the town have been hastily rebuilt and are in the process of being strengthened by a crew led by a dwarven stonemason.

Dusk is falling and the warm lights of Deadsnows, the small village in Icespear valley, look welcoming and warm. As the sun sets a frigid wind picks up, rustling the trees by the road. When you come closer to the village you see that it's being rebuilt, many houses are new, wooden frames on stone foundation, three stories high with steep roofs. White smoke rises from many chimneys. The wooden walls are hastily assembled but the gates look sturdy.

Rubert Anon can fill the PCs on the town's history and its build up (see Appendix). He was urged to move to Deadsnows by his mentor in Dagger Falls and bring the gospel of Lathander and partake in the rebirth of the village. Rubert has converted many villagers and has with the help of the congregation managed to build a small church, situated where the old Morning Watchtower used to stand. He invites the PCs to pay him a visit before they leave Deadsnows.



As the group enter the village they see that there's something happening in the south gates. Concerned and curious villagers are walking over there.

The wooden gates of Deadsnows are closed. On either side of the gate are stone pillars, the one on your left is carved with dwarven runes, the writing on the one to your right says: Well met, traveler! Rest your bones, rest your weary feet. Rest your sword and leave in peace. Rubert Anon calls out: "Lo, guards! Rubert Anon, second speaker, returns." After a short while the gates are opened by a flustered guard. Rubert greets the man and claims that you are his guests.

As you enter Deadsnows you see that the other guards are looking towards the south gate, straining to see what's going on there and seemingly too busy to pay you any notice. People are gathering there.

Rubert decides to investigate this further. If the PCs decide to join him, read or paraphrase the text below. If the PCs feel weary and in need of a warm bath and cozy bed it shouldn't take them long to find The Rose and Hammer, the only house in the village that survived the Spellplague.

The villagers have gathered in the South gate. Rubert pushes his way through, coming to an abrupt stop. An old, white haired dwarf lies beside one of the carved gate poles, clutching a dire wound in his side. Rubert starts praying to his god but the dwarf grabs his hands and opens his eyes. He draws the cleric closer and whispers something in his ear. The people there strain to hear what he has to say.

With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs hear what the old dwarf says to Rubert. The old dwarf says: Don't let them have it.

The dwarf passes away not long after this. He's too weak to answer any questions and refuses to receive healing from Rubert, who only eases the dwarf's pain. After the dwarf's death Rubert arranges that the body will be carried to his temple and he proclaims that he will be singing over the body in the morning.

The PCs can easily learn that the dwarf's name was Torbin Ironboot, a ledge keeper of the Ironboot clan from a mine nearby. Rubert excuses himself but asks the PCs to find him in the morning in the temple. He tells the PCs to stay at The Rose and Hammer and where to find the inn.

Deadsnows

Village, population 230

Deadsnows was until recently little more than a ghost town. Now it thrives again, and travelers and caravans are making a stop there, bringing coin and product.

HISTORY

Originally a keep for a human lord who desired his own kingdom, his dream was shattered before it had ever really started. He died in the Battle of Deadsnows, a minor skirmish with some of the countless orc raiders that continually plagued his designs and the battle which gave the place its name. Two religious groups, Dwarves of Marthammor Duin and Humans of Lathander eventually settled here, building impressive temples to each of their respective gods.

In Eleint, 1372 DR, during the winter melt a hunter was filling his waterskin at swollen river 3 miles from the village when he noticed the water contained tiny golden flecks. He returned and began to prospect, discovering to his joy that there was indeed gold to be found. Word spread around the village which then got out, and within a couple of months, 300 dwarves, elves, humans and halflings had flocked to the village, either looking to mine the gold themselves or hawk their wares to said miners. A few also arrived for more nefarious ends, to sell illegal items or to steal.

This sudden influx of people taxed the village to its limit and it looked like it would continue to do so until the gold ran out. However, the Spellplague destroyed the buildings and fields of the village, forcing the survivors to flee.

In 1486 DR rumors of Deadsnows being rebuilt started circling in the Silver Marches. Many hopeful entrepreneurs and adventurers made their way to the old, abandoned village in the next months. The first winter was hard but the coming spring the villagers saw that a few dwarf clans found their way to Deadsnows and started mining in the Icespear Valley and nearby valleys. Once again Deadsnow prospers.



LEADERSHIP

Deadsnow is led by a council of elders. Since the population is still small the elders are mostly people that have been handpicked and asked to sit on the council. The council meets as often as is needed and makes decisions on pressing issues. Now, in 1489 DR, there are five council members, each representing a small part of either the town's population or some part of its social or economy.

The council is led by Diliana Viveros (see appendix A) and has the title Speaker. Diliana is a Cormyrian, she was among the first settlers along with her husband, Garos, but he didn't make it through the first winter. Diliana speaks for the council and takes care of the everyday business. She organizes the militia, but every able man and woman is supposed to serve one day of every tenday. She is respected in the community and thought of as fair and just.

The council also includes Rubert Anon, Thodvar Nun, Coral Brittlebeard and Ol' Tom. Rubert represent the divine and religious part. Thodvar Nun speaks for the farmers, Coral is the spokesperson of the dwarven community and Ol'Tom speaks for the Emerald Enclave and sits on the council on their behalf.

DEMOGRAPHICS

Deadsnows population is mostly humans and dwarves. There are a few halflings and half-elves there as well, but elves and half-orcs are few. Other races are seldom seen.

ECONOMICS

Deadsnows is an agricultural village based on barter and trade. The dwarf clans bring their ore and metal into town where the craftsmen work it into products. Adventurers should have no trouble buying common items, but uncommon and rarer items are harder to come by.

Key to Deadsnows

1. VILLAGE GATES

The gates are usually guarded by a pair of guards.

Both are part of the town's militia and armed with halberds, short swords and shields, wearing leather armor. The gates are wooden and closed after sunset and barred. Only a councilmember can overrule this. Stone pillars are on either side of the gates, one carved with dwarven runes, the other in common. The pillars say: Well met, traveler! Rest your bones, rest your weary feet. Rest your sword and leave in peace. The guards remind visitors and travelers to stay their weapons while in the Icespear Valley and that the use of magic is frowned upon.

2. THE ROSE AND HAMMER

Deadsnow's only inn is The Rose and Hammer. It was the only building that survived the Spellplague. Harad Havsum (see appendix A) took over the inn, which needed a lot of rebuilding. The inn is cozy and welcoming. It's a three-story building, stone foundation and a cellar below. The upper floors are mostly bedrooms, the 2nd floor is used for guests but the 3rd floor is used by Harad and his staff.

The common room isn't as large as the big inns in Silverymoon and Waterdeep, but it can easily house 30 people. There's a moderately sized bar in one end and a fireplace in the other. Round tables are set around the support beams and therefor can't be moved. There's a head of a stag above the fireplace, a trophy Harad claims he collected in the Vordron Woods. There's always a fire burning in the fireplace and at nights a large chandelier is lit.

The windows all look over the nearby marketplace. There's always a faint smell of cooking in the common room, since the kitchen is in next room.

The rooms are comfortable but Spartan. Guests can choose between a shared room, where there are two beds and a nightstand. At the end of each bed there's a trunk, which can be locked, but the inn doesn't provide locks. There are two single rooms, both have a bed and a nightstand along with a cabinet and a trunk. The shared rooms are 3 sp per night which includes an oatmeal breakfast. The single rooms are 5 sp per night and includes oatmeal breakfast. Harad also allows poorer travelers to spend the night in his stable for a meager 5 cp but that doesn't include breakfast.



3. HOPE'S REBIRTH, TEMPLE OF LATHANDER

The temple is being rebuilt and is far from being ready. Its four main walls are up but the main hall is empty. A large window faces the morning sun and beneath it stands a small dais with a modest altar. The roof isn't finished but is being worked upon. The temple is built from local wood and even now one can see where the locals have etched their initials in the wood planks. Rubert explains that the villagers believe it brings them good fortune and Lathander's blessing.

What looks like a small ramshackle hut beside the temple is in fact Rubert's quarters. He uses only a portion of what funds he manages to raise for the temple for himself. His clothes are washed by people in the congregation and he accepts what food he's given. He has a bedroll, a few books, his holy symbol and his travelling clothes. In a locked chest he stores his chainmail and a Morningstar.

4. BRITTLEBEARD'S SMITHY

Coral Brittlebeard's smithy is a little more than a

huge forge and a massive anvil. The smithy is a one-story house, a sturdy building that reminds one of a small fort. The walls are made of thick stone, the windows fortified with iron and the door ironbound and massive.

Smoke billows from the chimney and the heavy sound of hammer falling on anvil can be heard from dawn till sundown. The smithy itself is filled with all manners of tools and if one looks closely one can spot a few weapons, axes, picks and warhammers in particular. There's also bucket full of horseshoes of all sizes.

Coral sells most simple weapons made of metal at the price given in PHB. He can also mend and fix armors and weapons. He also sells many simple metal items, such as crowbar, spades and shovels etc.

5. EVERT'S SHOP

Evert and his wife Una run the local shop in a house that they're still building. The third floor is not ready yet. The shop is on the ground floor and is a wondrous place, where both mundane items



imported from neighboring cities and local exotics can be found. The smell of many different and exotic spices fills the air and linger about outside the shop when the weather is still.

Hidden in the doorpost is a small carved mark, a simple harp (**Wisdom (Perception) DC 15 check**). The locals gossip that Evert gets strange and foreign visitors after sundown and that lights are often seen in their windows long after midnight.

The shop sells all kinds of mundane equipment at standard PHB rates. For a fair price, he can also appraise and even identify magical items for the PCs, as long as the PCs have a reputation of being good and trustworthy.

6. SHERIFF'S HOUSE

Sheriff Olaf's house stands not far from the north gate. Olaf, who lives alone, uses the first floor as an office and one room as a holding cell. He prides himself in the fact that he has never been forced to use it, though it has been used a few times for those who have either no other place to go to or have drunk too much.

Just outside the Sheriff's house there's a board where villagers post ads and all kinds of posters hang. There are also posts from Sheriff Olaf, where villagers and visitors are urged to not use arcane and harmful magic within the village. Wizards and sorcerers are also supposed to let Olaf know of their arrival.

If locals or travelers revert to violence, especially if they draw weapons, Olaf and whoever is on militia duty will soon arrive and either settle the dispute or step in and take the fighting parties to the Sheriff's house. Olaf usually just expels visitors from the village and makes them pay a hefty debt. If locals are involved he tries to settle the dispute.

7. MARKETSQUARE

Every weekday during summer the locals and travelling merchants set up their stalls and sell their products. The stalls are colorful, where the PCs can buy fruits, bread, meat and all sorts of local crafts. Prices range from fair to ludicrous but both merchants and locals are used to haggling.

In a small stall the PCs can find Madame Loorou. The Madame is a traveling fortune teller and the PCs can enter the tent for the small fee of 5 sp. The fortune teller uses a non-magical crystal ball to divine the customer's future but every fortune telling is vague and it doesn't take long to figure out that Loorou is more of an entertainer than a real diviner. She uses simple tricks and tries to read her guests (she has Insight +7).

There's a well in the northern part of the square and often people gather there to gossip. Spending time there one can learn a lot about the locals.

8. OLD ICESPEAR MANOR

The old manor is more or less in ruins. It was the largest building in the village before the Spellplague struck. The ruined walls still bear marks of the plague. The roof has fallen in and it's hazardous to enter the ruins.

Under the manor is a cellar and the locals say that sometimes during the darkest winter nights they hear voices and strange sounds coming from there. Until now no one has ventured into the cellar and Sheriff Olaf has declared that no one is to enter the ruins. The council hasn't decided what to do with it.

9. VIVEROS' BAKERY

When Dilana Viveros isn't acting as a speaker of the town council she can be found in her small bakery. Her house stands in not far from the east wall. It isn't large or especially noteworthy, standing two-story high with a steep roof. One would be hard pressed to guess that it houses actually a quite good bakery, for Viveros is in fact a really good baker.

When she's baking, a sweet smell entices both old and young alike to enter her small foyer, where her daughter, Annabel, serves customer. Breads, Danish and sweets line the walls and many villagers visit the bakery almost daily. Dilana also brews the ale that Harad sells in the Rose and Hammer. For a few silver pieces the PCs can stock up on good traveler's bread.

10. THODVAR'S FARM

Thodvar's farm is easily recognized, for it's the only one that has a small windmill. The farm is in decent



shape and it's obvious that he runs a good and organized farm. Thodvar also grinds all the grain that the farmers in Icespear Valley harvest each fall.

The farm is on one floor and made of stone with thatch roof. Thodvar and his sons have erected a four-foot high stone wall around their land. It's obviously not meant to hold people at bay, but serves its purpose well, since Thodvar also keeps sheep and cattle.

When visiting the farm, the first thing the PCs should be aware of are his many dogs. Thodvar prides himself in his dogs and many farmers in the valley have dog raised by Thodvar, which are both excellent guard dogs and good sheep dogs.

Rumors and hearsay

These rumors can be easily learned from staying in Deadsnows for a short period of time. The PCs can talk to locals, spend some time in the market square or in the Rose and hammer. The villagers are eager to inform their guests about their neighbors and learn more about the newcomers.

Ol'Tom

People in the Deadsnow respect the old druid but the respect is mixed with awe and fear. Children are even sometimes chastised saying that if they don't behave Ol'Tom will take them away. The villagers often wonder where the old man lives and how comes he knows so much about them. There are even those that believe that Ol'Tom used to live in Deadsnows before the plague.

THE TREASURE OF THE ICESPEAR MANOR

Before the Spellplague the Icespear family, led by Arletha Icespear, used to live in the manor but they were never known to be especially rich, since their richness was mostly tied up in lands and houses.

When the Spellplague struck most of it came worthless and so Arletha Icespear and her family fled along with other villagers. But still villagers speak of a lost treasure, hidden in a secret chamber in the cellar. But no one dares to enter the cellar due to the strange nighttime sounds and sightings reported by villagers and travelers alike (see chapter 4).

BROTHERHOOD OF THE MOON

A small band of adventurers called the Brotherhood of the Moon used Deadsnows as a base of operations before the Spellplague struck. Unfortunately, they didn't have time to gather their treasure before leaving town, which caused many treasure hunters to search for it in the ruins. One of them, an orc called Histarack, discovered it and had the rumors spread that said that the town was a pocket of Spellplague energy, which aroused the interest of Order of the Blue fire, which in turn sent envoys to reveal the hoax for what it was. The treasure however disappeared and hasn't been found ever since.

THE HOSPICE OF MARTHAMMOR DUIN

When the Spellplague struck and the villagers fled no monk was seen leaving the old abbey that stands in the mouth of the valley. Now the abbey is in ruins, though many dwarves still pay a visit to the place and the shrine of Marthammor. No one knows what happened to Observer Kerilla Gemstar and her monks, but many believe that underneath the abbey is an entrance to the Underdark and following the Spellplague the Hospice was overrun by some foul aberrations from below.

RED DRAGON SIGHTED!

Lately many travelers have reported seeing a red dragon soaring above the Nether Mountains. The council knows about this, but the villagers are concerned that it isn't acting on it. If a red dragon has laired in the mountains it could prove a great threat to both villagers and travelers alike.

An invitation to an adventure

When the PCs wake up, they receive a note from Rubert Anon, where he asks them to see him in Hope's Rebirth as soon as possible. The note doesn't say anything why the cleric wants to see the PCs. Walking from The Rose and Hammer takes the PCs through the town which gives them an excellent chance to learn more about the town and even get to know some of the villagers.

The day is warm, and the villagers go about their



business lightly dressed and with a smile on their face. Hope's Rebirth is bathed in the morning light and it's easy to imagine how magnificent it will look once finished. A large window faces the sun and once decorated with colored glass the church hall will be a testament to Lathander's glory. As you enter the church you see where Rubert Anon stands by the altar and speaks with a woman in red dress. Her hair is graying but her blue eyes are as sharp as the open sky.

Rubert greets the PCs with warmth and introduces Diliانا Viveros. He asks them how their stay at the Rose and hammer was and makes small talk before turning to the matter at hand. He tells the PCs that the dwarf that died in the southern gate was Thorbin Ironboot, an elder of the Ironboot clan, which has a mine high in the Nether Mountains.

Rubert and Dilianna have their concerns about the Ironboots. The elders of the clan haven't left the mine since opening it three years ago and the fact that Thorbin found his way to the village more dead than alive, only to die with this cryptic message: Don't let them have it. Viveros fears that something has ill befallen the clan and the council wants to know if there's something wrong and if so, what has happened, though of course they hope that everything is alright.

"We can't pay you much, but you will have our gratitude," says Viveros and Rubert nods his head. "We can pay you 20 gp each but that's all we can afford." Rubert smiles. "I also have two vials of healing potion I'm willing to give you if you do this for us."

Once the PCs have given their answer Dilianna excuses herself and exits the church. If the PCs refuse to do this Rubert tries to convince them to help them. If the PCs have agreed to go to the Ironboot mine Rubert can answer any question the PCs might have about the Ironboot clan (see below). Once the PCs have gotten all the answers they need he bids them farewell and reminds them that if something has happened and the PCs think they can help the clan, that the council would be even more grateful, for the relations with the Ironboots is valued in Deadsnows.

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Where can we find the Ironboot mine?

You'll have to walk there. The mine is in mt. Arnetha and it's about a day's walk over there. It's southeast of here, deep in the Nether Mountains. The entrance is visible from the path, so you shouldn't have any trouble finding it if you follow the path leading east, when you exit Deadsnows through the South gate.

What do you know about the mine?

The Ironboot clan came three years ago and opened the mine. They have been working there ever since, hammering day and night. They've brought their metals to Coral and sold it to merchants in the market square. I've never been to the mine, but Coral has. He can probably help you and tell you more of the mine. I've heard that the dwarves have managed to carve out a good mine there, they struck a nice vein of iron not long after they came here, so they've probably made a fortune.

Who was Thorbin?

Thorbin Ironfoot was an elder in the clan, serving as a ledge keeper. I've only met him once, he came here to arrange a deal with Coral. He struck me as serious and stoic. He always wore a holy symbol of Dugmaren Brightmantle.

Do you know what could've killed him?

No, but his wounds were serious. The cuts were deep and clean. My guess is that he must've been cut with something very sharp. He had more cuts, but none as deep the ones in his side. In fact, it's amazing that the old dwarf managed to get here, he must've been quite fortuitous. Or stubborn. You know dwarves, if they set their mind to something...

What do you think he was referring to when he said: Don't let them have it? Who are they and what is it?

That's the thousand gold pieces question and what we need to find out. Whatever it was or is, it's something that he gave his life to warn us about.

If the PCs have other questions about the mine or the events Rubert doesn't know the answers and refers to



Coral Brittlebeard, the dwarven blacksmith. He also says that Ol'Tom knows the surrounding lands quite well and it could be helpful talking to him. Thodvar is also used to go hunting in the mountains along with his sons and dogs, so he could be of some help.

TALKING TO CORAL BRITTLEBEARD

If the PCs decide to investigate the clan further and talk to Coral Brittlebeard they find him in foul mood. Thorbin Ironboot was Coral's friend and he's both mourning his friend and eager to find whoever murdered the old dwarf. He's not too keen on having non-dwarves going to the Ironboot Mine.

To convince him of helping them, the PCs need to pass a **DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check**, non-dwarves have a disadvantage on the roll. If the PCs speak to Coral in Dwarven they can roll a **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** to understand that he's both angry and full of sorrow for his friend. The DC is 15 if they only speak Common with Coral. If the PCs manage to convince Coral to help them he answers their questions as best as he can.

What do you know about the Ironboot mine?

The mine is well crafted and much better than your average human mine. A dwarf's mine is also a home. The living halls are not far from the entrances, but the mine itself is deeper in the mountain.

If you enter the main entrance you should pass Moradin's halls soon. There you'll find Dorna, the clan's cleric. She's grim and unwavering, but fair. Treat her with respect and she'll show you the same.

Beyond the halls is the Ledger room, where Thorbin watched over the clan's ledgers and planned the mining with Durna and Isarn, the clan leader. His room is beyond the Ledger room. Isarn is usually down in the mine, managing the work. The clan's living quarters, smelting room, anvils and kilns are below these halls. The mine is accessible through the smelting room.

Is there more than one entrance?

Yes, it's a dwarven mine! There's always more than one entrance. I've only seen the main entrance, but of course there's another one.

Can you draw us a map?

Yes, I can.

What do you think has happened?

I honestly don't know but I hope you find out. Thorbin wouldn't leave his ledgers unless the situation was dire.

What do you know about the clan's history before they came here?

I know that they came from Citadel Adbar and still had some relations there. I believe the clan decided to move to improve their standing, or at least that's what I've heard.

Are there other dwarf clans or mines around Deadsnows?

Yes, the Fenabars are west of here, a small clan and recent addition to the valley's population but the Gunlaugsons have been mining the Nether Mountains since 1380 DR, I think. They're south of Deadsnows.

Coral knows that the Ironboot clan came from Citadel Adbar and left the dwarfhold hoping to carve out their own place in the Nether Mountains. There were around 30 dwarves living in the mine. He hopes that the PCs will find out what happened and says if they return to him with news of the clan he will be grateful. If the PCs return to him and tell him what they've found out, he will thank them and offer them 10% discount.

TALKING TO THODVAR

The PCs can find Thodvar at his farm. Thodvar is wary of strangers and isn't all too keen on talking to whoever passes by his farm. The PCs need to pass a **DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check** to convince Thodvar to speak with them. If they mention that Rubert Anon sent them, they will have advantage of the roll.

He has never been at the mine itself, but he knows the route well enough. He warns the PCs that this is the time when the bears have younglings and he knows that there's a bear cave not far from the path, where the Trout stream comes into the Icespear. He



urges the PCs to be careful, since mother bears can be protective.

What equipment do we need?

I think that a normal traveler's kit should suffice. A rope, some food packs, good clothes and decent boots is all you need to get there. If you leave late in the day, you might need to camp over a night.

Do you know where the entrance is?

Yes, it's visible from the path. I've also seen Ironboot dwarves in the Shadow gorge, which is a little more east than the entrance. I don't know what they were doing there, but I've seen them more than once.

If the PCs want buy a dog, Thodvar is more than eager to both talk about and sell his fine breed of dogs.

SPEAKING TO OTHER VILLAGERS

Other villagers don't know more about the Ironfoot clan than these other three persons. No one has had unpleasant experience with the dwarves though most villagers can tell the PCs stories about the gruff and haughty nature of the clan, yet no one has ever been treated unfairly or swindled. The villagers all know Dorna and speak highly of her, she has been a valued adviser in building the town walls.

If the villagers are asked about what they think has happened to the Thorbin Ironfoot they quickly blame it on the kobold raids that have been happening frequently lately.

Enroute to Ironboot mine

Once the PCs have made all preparations they need and gathered what information they need. If the PCs choose to leave after noon they will either trek in the dark or pass the night outdoors, since walking to the Ironboot mine takes around 8-10 hours. A good part of the way is uphill and arduous task. If the PCs decide to leave after noon allow them to make **DC 5 Wisdom (Survival) check** to figure out that they would need to spend a night under the stars.

The first few miles are easy enough; the path lies in the foothills and passes between fir and pine trees.

Every now and then a stag or other game is spotted but the first few hours are uneventful. Once the path starts to climb the walk gets harder and especially for encumbered PCs.

There's no need for random encounters, unless the PCs spend the night in the mountains. The trail is often travelled and watched over by the both the people in Deadsnows and the local dwarf clans.

When the PCs see where Trout Stream merges with Icespear River they meet Ol' Tom. The druid is worried and warns the PCs that an angry mother bear is on the loose. One of her cubs is missing.

You've been climbing the steep path for hours and the task is proving to be harder than you expected. Fur and pine trees cover the mountain sides, blocking for most parts your view of the surroundings. Suddenly you hear someone whistle a tune higher up on the path. Before long a white-haired man in brown and green robe appears. Once he sees you, he stops and looks at each of you in turn.

"Well met, travelers," he says in deep baritone voice, "well met indeed." He holds a modest wooden staff and leans forward on it, as if to get a better look at you.

If the PCs introduce themselves, he in turn tells them his name is Thomas, but most folk in Deadsnows refer to him as Ol' Tom, which is as good as name as any. He asks the PCs what brings them to these parts of Nether Mountains. The PCs can make a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** to learn that Ol' Tom is trying to find out if the PCs are there to hunt or otherwise harm the animals in this part of the mountains.

If there's a barbarian, ranger, a druid or anyone proficient in nature, survival or animal handling in the group he asks the PCs to help him. If the group has a druid, he will speak to that person in druidic.

"I'm in a bit of pickle," he says. "A mother bear lost one of her cubs and she's going rampant. I need to make sure that she doesn't come to harm. If you could please help me find her cub, I would be very grateful."

If there aren't any PCs that are proficient in these



skills or look like they don't, Ol' Tom only warns the PCs that there might an angry mother bear up the road and asks the PCs to take care not coming in between her and her cubs.

FINDING THE CUB

Ol' Tom tells the PCs that he suspects that the cub has probably gone down the mountain side, since that's where its mother usually feeds. He asks the PCs to bring the cub back to this place if they find it and whistle loudly.

Once the PCs are off the path they need to pass a **DC 5 Wisdom (Survival) check** to make sure that they don't get lost in the fir woods. To find the cub they can either search for tracks left by the cub or actively search for it. Both are **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check**. If a PC proficient in Nature first passes a DC 10 check the PCs have an advantage on the roll.

A little brown cub stands by a large fallen tree and digs into the ground, with bees buzzing around its head. It's seemingly oblivious to your approach.

The cub has found a small beehive and is gorging on the sweet honey. The PCs can make a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Animal handling) check** to get the cub to follow them. There are other ways to get the cub: award the players for both ingenuity and clever ideas. If the PCs decide to use physical force to overbear the bear or make too much of a racket the noise will attract **3 wolves** (See MM p. 341) who join the fight eager to get a piece of meat.

Once the PCs have captured the cub finding their way back to path is easy, if they have passed the earlier Wisdom (Survival) check. If they failed the check the PCs need to pass a **DC 10 Wisdom (Survival) check** to find their way back on the path.

Ol' Tom responds quickly once they whistle. He appears on the path above them after a few minutes. When he sees the cub, he smiles and thanks the PCs. Once the druid has the cub he gives the PCs a small pouch containing 12 goodberries.

If the PCs decide to attack the cub and try to overbear it, then it will fight furiously. It's curious about the PCs but once they show hostility it becomes afraid

Black Bear cub

CR 1/4

Small beast, unaligned

Armor class: 11 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 13 (2d8+4)

Speed 30 ft, climb 20 ft

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13 (+1)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	2 (-4)	13 (+1)	7 (-2)

Skills: Perception +3

Senses: passive perception 13

Languages: –

Challenge: 1/4 (50 xp)

Keen Smell. The bear has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell.

Actions

Bite. Melee weapon attack: +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d4+1) piercing damage.

Claws. Melee weapon attack: +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6+1) slashing damage.

and will fight dearly for its life. The cub favors its claws and will use them as long as it can.

Rewards

Award normal XP for defeated foes. Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Keeping the kobolds from looting Rubert's cart, 50 XP.
- Getting to know Deadsnows and its citizens, 25 XP.
- Learning about the side entrance from Coral Brittlebeard or Thodvar, 50 XP.
- Returning the black bear cub to Ol' Tom unharmed, 25 XP.

If you are using the Milestone rule the PCs should be leveled up to 2nd level after completing this chapter.



Chapter 2: Ironboot Mine

Approaching the mine

It's easy to spot the mine from the path. It rises above the tree line and below, in a small valley, the black main entrance stands out in the green foliage. Even from where the group stands it's obvious that the entrance has collapsed.

As the path rises to its highest point you finally see over the tree line. Below you is a small valley, where a small but foaming creek finds its way to the mouth of the valley. You can see where the mine is in the middle of the valley, its black entrance a stark contrast in the green foliage of the surroundings.

If the PCs pass a DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check, they can see that the mine entrance has collapsed. As they draw closer and investigate the entrance, if the PCs make a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check** to discover that the entrance has been collapsed intentionally. Dwarven PCs have an advantage on the roll due to their Stonecunning feature. The PCs can also make a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (History) check** to know that dwarven mines tend to have more than one entrance, if they haven't learned that already from Coral and Thodvar.

If the PCs decide to search for another entrance

they need to make a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check**. If the PCs have talked to Thodvar and know about Shadow Gorge, from where the small creek flows, they have an advantage on the roll. Each roll means that the PCs have searched for two hours. The side entrance is hidden from view and securely locked. The dwarves also placed a trap that needs to be disabled before the door can be unlocked.

After an intensive search, you finally spot the side entrance, hidden behind a fallen tree and a large grey boulder. It's craftily built and blends perfectly with the cliff.

The PCs need to find a way past the trap and to unlock the door. If one of the PCs has a Passive Perception 15 or higher they automatically spot the trap. If not, they can search for traps if they make DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check. If the PCs spot the trap they still need to disarm it. To do so they must pass a **DC 10 Dexterity check**. If they fail with 5 or more, they set the trap off. Once they've dealt with the trap they can unlock the door, if they make a successful **DC 10 Dexterity check**.

The trap is simple, a needle is fired at the intruder and an alarm goes off in the mine, which was intended to alert the dwarves.



Poison Needle Trap

CR ½

Mechanical trap

When the trap is triggered a small needle extends 3 inches straight out from the lock. A creature within range takes 1 piercing damage and 6 (1D10) Poison damage and must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or be poisoned for 1 hour.

Ironboot Mine

The Ironboot mine is relatively new but the clan has already carved deep into the mountain in the three years that have passed since they arrived. The mine is on two levels, the upper level is used by the ruling class and used for ceremonies and meetings.

The lower level is where the clan's living quarters are and the mine itself. Since the clan opened the Aranea Egg Room the Burnt Hand Clan has managed to enter the mine and loot what they have found, amongst the treasure the Queen egg.

MINE FEATURES

The mine is well built and it's easy to find one's way, if there's someone among the PCs who reads dwarven. The corridors are marked with simple dwarven runes. Though most of the PCs have probably never been in a dwarven mine the mine itself isn't what's most troubling. The eerie silence, the sulphur smell, the dried bloodstains and the mines desolation should both frighten and interest the PCs. The overwhelming dread and feeling that something terrible has happened is prevalent and tangible as soon as the PCs step through the door.

The side entrance leads into the Smelting hall. From there the PCs can either enter the mine itself, the living quarters or go up to the main halls.

HALLWAYS AND ROOMS

All hallways are 10 ft. tall and 10 ft. wide. Unless otherwise noted all rooms are 10 ft. tall. All walls are of even and polished stone. The mine itself is rougher and the stone walls unworked.

DOORS

All doors are wooden and can be barred from the inside. A door locked this way can be broken down with a successful **DC 15 Strength check**. Unless otherwise noted all doors are unlocked and easy to open.

FLOORS

Unless otherwise noted the floors are even and worked stone.

VISIBILITY AND LIGHTS

There are light globes hanging on walls with 60 ft. interval in the hallways. The globes follow the same rules as torches. The rooms have both globes and braziers that can be lit.

Lower level

1. SMELTING HALL

The first room the group enters is the Smelting hall, where large anvils, kilns and 2 great furnaces stand. There's unworked stone and ore in carts and tools lying around. The whole area is in disarray and obvious that it was deserted in haste.

The hall beyond the door is dark and silent. You push on and finally reach a large room. Large kilns, two great furnaces and number of rune encrusted anvils bear a silent witness of the work that was done here. Hammers, bellows and other blacksmithing tools lie scattered on the floor. A dark hallway leads deeper into the mountain, where another opening is obviously the mine. A few carts stand there, full of unworked stone. A wooden staircase strengthened with iron bindings leads to the upper level.

Beside the staircase is an elevator, large enough for a single cart. The furnaces and kilns are cold, but it should be easy enough to get them burning again. There's both coal, shovels and tindertwigs beside the furnaces. If the PCs make a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check**, they discover a dry blood stain beside one of the three rune-encrusted anvils.



If any of the PCs have a Passive Perception 15 or higher they hear a shuffling of feet coming from same hallway that the PCs used to get there. A small group of kobolds led by Kax discovered the open door and decided to have look inside, in hope of finding some treasure for their red dragon queen.

Kax doesn't want to confront the PCs, at least not yet. He orders his kobolds to wait in the darkened hallway until the PCs move up to the upper level.

If the PCs don't have that high Passive Perception, they still feel like someone is watching them.

2. LIVING QUARTERS

The living quarters are several rooms that are all in similar state, in places have doors been broken down, in other parts are scorched blast marks.

The rooms are almost all personal quarters of the clan members and going through them should feel like they're going through the personal stuff of someone else.

The clan's living quarters are simple yet comfortable. Each room is similar in size, though they differ in almost all other aspect. The beds, the sheets, the clothes, each room has their own character. Many doors have been broken down, in a couple of places are visible blast marks.

Searching the living quarters shouldn't take long. If the PCs make a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check** their search reveals a few coins (2 gp, 31 sp, 10 cp) and pouch containing a small piece of emerald worth 20 gp's. If the PCs are actively looking for signs of what could have happened to the dwarves and make a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check**, they spot faint drag marks on the floor. If the PCs make a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Survival) check**, they figure out that it seems that at least some of the dwarves were dragged towards the elevator in the smelting hall.

3. MINE

The mine is of typical dwarven design (any dwarf with the stonecunning trait can see that). There are tracks in the floor and globes of light with 60' inter-

Young Carrion Crawler

CR 2

Medium Monstrosity, unaligned

Armor Class 13 (natural armor)

Hit Points 37 (4d10+12)

Speed 30 ft, climb 30 ft

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	13 (+1)	16 (+3)	1 (-5)	12 (+1)	5 (-3)

Skills Perception +3

Senses Darkvision 60 ft., passive perception 13

Languages -

Challenge 2 (450 xp)

Keen Smell. The Carrion Crawler has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on smell.

Spider climb. The Carrion Crawler can climb difficult surfaces, including upside down on ceilings, without needing to make an ability check.

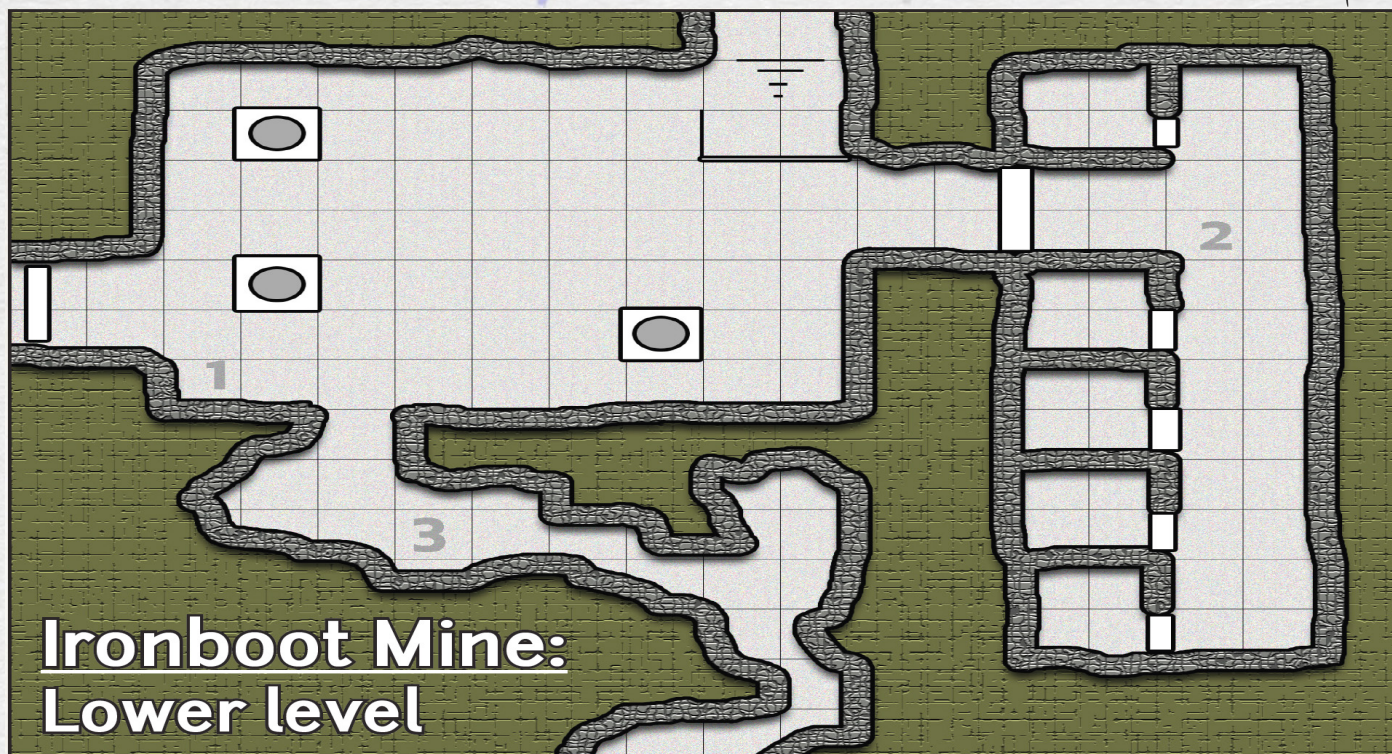
Actions

Multiattack. The Carrion Crawler makes two attacks, one with its tentacles and one with its Bite.

Tentacle. Melee weapon attack: +7 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 3 (1d4+1) poison damage, DC 13 Constitution saving throw or be poisoned for 1 minute. Until the poison ends the target is paralyzed. The target can repeat the saving throw at the end of each its turns, ending the poison on itself on success.

Bite. Melee weapon attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 6 (2d4+1) piercing damage.

vals, giving light to 10' around themselves. The rock is worked and the mine itself is a testament to the Ironboot's craftsmanship. It's easy to find the exit to where the mine opens into a large and deep cave, the opening is in the cave wall and it's a sheer 400' drop down from the mine opening. The cave leads down into the Underdark. There are steps hewn into the cliff, leading down from the dark and to an opening, the PCs see the steps with a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check**. Getting down isn't hard, the PCs get there with a successful **DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check**, using rope yields advantage. If the PCs fail their check with more than 5 they lose their grip and start to fall. Let the falling hero do a **DC 10 Dexterity saving throw**. If the hero makes the save it manages to grab a hold onto something. If not, it's a long fall.



A trail of blood is on the cliff and the mine floor by the opening, leading down into the dark opening below the mine, PCs with a Passive Perception 13 spot it.

A young carrion crawler has found its way up from the Underdark, having caught the scent of blood and carrion in the Ironboot Mine. As soon as it spots the PCs it attacks. If the PCs have taken measures to use stealth they have a chance of surprising the carrion crawler. If the PCs are not moving as silently as they can, the carrion crawler knows they're coming and hides.

If the PCs have Passive Perception 14 they are not surprised in the first round. The Carrion Crawler attacks the first PC's eager to make a kill. It will fight furiously and defend its newly gained territory to the death.

What is below?

If your player wish to investigate where the cave leads, let them. Though this adventure doesn't describe the deep cave in detail, your players might find more adventure there.

4. ARANEA EGG ROOM

Where the steps start in the cliff is another opening.

The walls are uneven and alien, the floor laid with obsidian octagon tiles, strange purple glow emits from below the tiles. At the end of the hall is a stone door, which has been broken down. Beyond is a weird room, an Aranea Queen Egg room, where the Aranea clan from Laz'Shadamar hid their queen egg before the Blood of Morueme attacked, storing the egg in a place of temporal stasis. Now, the seals have been broken and the egg of extreme value to the clan.

The egg room is extensively decorated, with imagery from the Aranea clan's history, the shapechangers' history and many powerful arcane runes. Many sacrifices lie scattered on the floor, most of them are in clay urns or leather sacks. In the middle of the room is a pedestal, decorated with spidery looking imagery and ancient arcane runes.

You follow the strange corridor towards the doorway. Beyond the door is a strange and alien room. The walls are decorated with symbols of spiders and humans alike, foreign-looking symbols and images. On the floor lie clay urns and leather sacks scattered around, many have been opened. In the other end an octagonal pedestal stands with purple cloth on top, decorated with ancient glyphs and runes.

If the PCs decide to investigate the pedestal, there's



a lot that can be learned from it. Studying the pedestal itself and the cloth one can see that something oval has rested upon it with a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check**. Investigating the glyphs can reveal that they contained powerful divination, abjuration and conjuring magic with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check**. But the runes are of a more religious kind, the PCs can see that there is some connection to both Eilistraee and Mystra with a successful **DC 20 Wisdom (Religion) check**. However, something seems not quite right in the runes. The Aranea placed them to deceive readers, hiding the fact they venerate Leira.

If the PCs want to know how old the pedestal or the runes they discover with **DC 10 Intelligence (History) check** that both are pre-Spellplague, but post-Times of Troubles.

If the PCs investigate the sacks and the other sacrificial items they discover quickly that someone has been here before and ransacked the room. A **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check** reveals that probably two groups have entered room. The dust on the floor shows both heavy booted footprints and a few made by small, clawed feet. Under a leather sack there's a red scale, the PCs know that the scale belonged to a kobold with a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Nature) check**. The walls have pictures that are pre-Spellplague and show strange crossbreed of humans and spiders, using spells and other arcane mysteries. With a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Arcana) check** the PCs can learn that the pictures portray the Aranea. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (History) check** the PCs know that the paintings were created pre-Spellplague but after the Times of Troubles since they portray a reference to both Cyric and Kelemvor.

The Ironboot clan opened the egg room and investigated it, discovering the egg on the pedestal. Once they removed the egg from the room the guardians were summoned into being and they attacked the clan. Once Kax discovered that the mine was left unguarded he led an expedition of his most trusted warriors and looted the place, taking into captivity those dwarves that were still alive. He's eager to find more treasure to bring his dragon

overlord, though he's smart enough not to put himself in harm's way.

Message from the Aranea

As the PCs are leaving the Egg Room an image shimmers into being. Each PC hears the message in his own language, i.e. elven characters hear the message in elven, Halfling characters in Lurien etc. The image portrays a figure dressed in a dark robe, with eight black eyes with a red tinge to them visible under the hood.

As you're exiting the room you feel a strange sensation that sends shivers down your spine, the release of arcane energy. Suddenly a large black robed figure shimmers into being before you. Its face is mostly hidden by shadow, though you can see eight small black eyes with a red tinge to them stare down at you. "The Queen has been taken. Woe upon those who break the seals. Woe upon those who disturb her majesty's rest. Woe upon you!" The robbed figure points a long, claw like finger at you. Purple luminescence surrounds the finger and streaks out towards you. The light dissipates before reaching you. Then the image fades and disappears.

This is a programmed illusion left by the Aranea, a PC proficient in Arcana knows this with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check**. It appears to everyone who leave the chamber without uttering: 'Her majesty rests' in Undercommon. It was left by the Aranea as a last effort to keep would-be robbers away.

Upper level

The Upper level of the Ironboot Mine is used by the clan's leaders and elders. It is also the part that the clan uses to receive visitors so it's lavish and made to impress. The hallways are wide and well lit. All doors are sturdy, made of wood but can be broken down with a successful **DC 20 Strength check**. The floor is tiled.

5. CLAN ROOM

Isarn Ironboot, the clan's leader, used this room to conference with his council and to receive visitors.



In the middle of the room is a huge table, wherein the clan's crest has been carved. As many as eight dwarves can sit by the table in good wooden chairs. Isarn's seat has high back and a wooden frame picturing the clan's crest and Isarn's favorite weapon, heavy warpick, is carved into the top piece. The walls are decorated with paintings, but it's also obvious that weapons and shields hung on the wall but have been removed.

Exquisite wooden chairs lie scattered about the floor in this decorated room. In the middle stands a huge wooden table with the Ironboot crest carved into it. Dwarven art hangs on the walls.

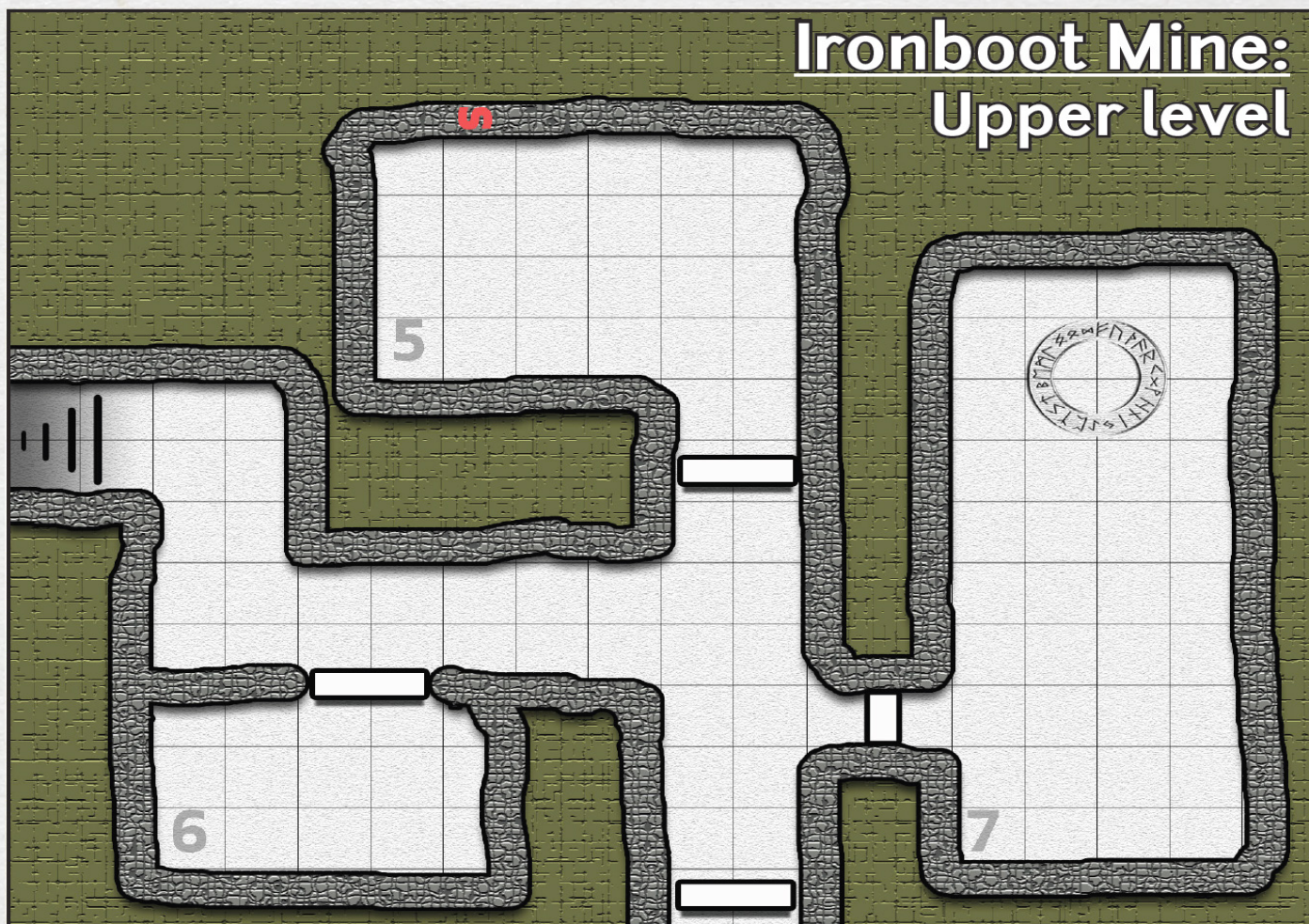
If the PCs investigate the room they discover with a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation)** check that there were weapons and shields also hanging on the walls, but they have been removed. If the PCs investigate Isarn's chair a **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs will spot a small latch

under the seat, indicating a secret compartment. If the PCs try to open it they find it locked, but it can be opened with a successful **DC 10 Dexterity** check. The secret compartment holds a *Potion of Bear's Endurance*, a ruby worth 100 gp's and a *Dagger +1*.

There's a secret door behind Isarn's chair but it's well hidden. If the PCs declare that they are actively searching for secret doors they can find it with a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation)** check. If the kobolds have started the fire (see below) it's easier to find the secret door due to draft, the door can then be found with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check. The door leads to a rough and unworked unlit tunnel, the exit hidden by large boulders and trees in a small ravine east of the main entrance.

6. LEDGER ROOM

Thorbin Ironboot oversaw ledgers, manuscripts, scrolls and books. The walls of this room are lined





with bookshelves, scroll cases, maps and all manners of books. In the middle of the room is a large desk littered with scrolls and all sorts of papers. A large candlestick lies on the floor. The annals of the Ironboot clan rests upon a pedestal, a heavy tome wrought in brass and leather.

You enter a small library. Bookshelves line the walls, heavy ledgers, scrolls and books bound in leather, wood and even stone in every shelf. In the middle of the room a large desk stands, papers, maps and scrolls cover every inch of it. A heavy tome rests upon a simple pedestal, it's wrought in leather and brass with the Ironfoot crest. A large candlestick lies on the floor.

A short investigation of the room with a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check uncovers a couple of useful scrolls, one containing the spell Invisibility and the other one the divine spells Divine favor and Shield other.

If the PCs decide to read the annals of the Ironboot clan the book is locked with a pretty good lock, one that can be unlocked with a successful **DC 15 Dexterity check**. If the PCs manage to open the lock, show them handout #1. Its latest entry shows how the miners opened to Aranea egg room. Despite Dorna's warnings Isarn decided to remove the egg and the sacrifices from the room, claiming it as a part of the Ironboot treasure. After the guardians had crippled the clan's defenses the kobolds attacked through the main gate, led by Kax. Many dwarves where enslaved, those who died in the attack where taken by the kobolds as fodder for their dragon overlord.

7. MORADIN'S HALLS

Moradin's Halls is the religious center of the Ironboot mine. At one end is an altar devoted to Moradin, which the Ironboots see as their patron deity, but the Halls also include a shrine devoted to Dugmaren Brighmantle, Marthammor Duin and Dumathoin, the PCs can recognize the shrines with a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Religion) check**. Usually Dorna and her apprentice, Reamar, would be within the halls but now this area is empty just as the rest of the mine. The altar resembles a great anvil and lying

upon the altar is a golden ceremonial hammer, with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence check** the PCs know that the hammer is worth at least 500 gp's, even more when sold to dwarves. Not far from the entrance is a dried pool of blood, the kobolds found Reamar there and he put up a fight defending the Halls. The kobolds, frighten by the anvils protector, left the halls after defeating Reamar and looting the shrines.

You open heavy brass doors and enter a large hall. A great anvil stands in one end, heavily decorated with dwarven runes. Three shrines are in the other end, seemingly dedicated to other dwarven deities. Wooden benches line the walls which are decorated with picturesque tapestry. The floor is mosaic and shows Moradin's holy symbol. A part of it is covered by dried blood.

Earth elemental

CR 2

Small Elemental, neutral

Armor class 14 (natural armor)

Hit Points 33 (3d10+12)

Speed 30 ft., burrow 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	8 (-1)	16 (+3)	5 (-3)	8 (-1)	5 (-3)

Damage Vulnerabilities thunder

Damage resistances bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical weapons

Damage immunities poison

Condition immunities exhaustion, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, unconscious

Senses Darkvision 60 ft., tremorsense 60 ft., passive perception 13

Languages Terran

Challenge 2 (600 xp)

Earth Glide. The elemental can burrow through nonmagical, unworked earth and stone. While doing so, the elemental doesn't disturb the material it moves through.

Actions

Multiattack. The elemental makes two slam attacks.

Slam. Melee weapon attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8+3) bludgeon damage.



If the PCs investigate the blood they find out with a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Medicine) check** that someone must've been gravely wounded there a few days ago. Upon a closer inspection, the PCs can discover a subtle blast mark with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check**, left by the spell *Sacred flame* cast by Reamar. There's also a small red scale in the blast mark.

If the PCs investigate the altar they quickly find the golden ceremonial hammer, which radiates magical aura, Conjunction. If they take the hammer without saying: 'Moradin bless my hand' in dwarven, the hammers protector, a small earth elemental, is summoned into place.

If the PCs investigate the shrines they discover that they have been looted.

FIRE!

After the PCs have spent time on the upper floor Kax decides to wait no longer. He urges his warriors forward and sets fire to the wooden staircase and jams the elevator. The PCs are in dire straits and will need to get out as fast as possible, so they won't suffocate. The PCs have the chance to discover the fire in time, making sure they can escape with little or no harm. After the PCs have had the chance to investigate two of the rooms on the upper floor the kobolds have had enough time to get a fire started, smoke starts building up and the PCs have a chance of smelling something burning. If the PCs make a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception – Smell) check** or if they have a Passive Perception 15 they pick up the smell. If they don't pass the check allow them another **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception – Smell) check** after 10 rounds. After another 10 rounds lower the DC once more. The longer it takes for the PCs to discover the danger they're in, more the deadly the situation becomes.

Once the PCs reach the staircase read or paraphrase the following, if the PCs made the 1st Wisdom (Perception) check.

The wooden staircase is on fire! You see a few kobolds cheering and chuckling with glee as the

red and orange flames reach higher and higher. Smoke is building up, making it hard to breathe and see. A kobold, clad in a fancy leather armor and bearing a feather headpiece, jams a pick into the elevator winch, grinning once it's properly stuck.

They have 3 rounds before the smoke gets to thick, if they wish to attack the kobolds. Once they've made their presence known Kax heroically calls the kobolds back and tells them to exit the mine. Only half of the staircase is burning, making it easier to get down. Running through the fire should only take 1 round, making it dangerous but not fatal.

If the PCs made the 2nd Wisdom (Perception) check read or paraphrase the following.

The wooden staircase is on fire. Smoke billows up towards you, making your eyes water and it's hard to breathe. A pick is stuck in the elevator winch.

The PCs are in a great danger and need to get out as fast as possible, $\frac{3}{4}$ of the staircase is burning, making it dangerous to run through the fire.

If the PCs made the third or fourth Wisdom (Perception) check, read or paraphrase the following.

The wooden staircase is a raging inferno. Black and thick smoke blinds you, making your eyes water and your breath laborious.

Breathing is hard, making the situation even more dangerous, the PCs have a disadvantage on all rolls if they don't make a successful **DC 10 Constitution save** due to coughing. While the PCs are in the fire they need to make the test every round unless they decide to hold their breath (see page 183 in PHB).

Moving through the fire is very dangerous, possible deadly. Moving through the fire the PCs move at $\frac{1}{4}$ their movement rate due to treacherous footing, moving blindly and going down a burning staircase. For each round in the fire the PCs take 1d6 damage (Fire), if they make a successful **DC 15 Dexterity saving throw** they only take half damage.

The staircase is 40 feet high. The wooden frame can be climbed with a successful **DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check**, with the damage taken for going



into the fire. Due to being climbing the PCs have a disadvantage on the dexterity save. The walls are scalable and can be climbed with a successful **DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check**. Using rope and climbing gear offers advantage on the roll.

Designer's notes

This is a deadly encounter. Award the players for clever thinking, no one likes to have their character killed in a fire. Use this encounter first and foremost to show how devious and evil Kax is.

Once Kax has set fire to the staircase he exits the mine and waits there for the PCs. A kobold runner comes from the Burnt hand clan lair and tells Kax that the clan has some problem with the dwarves and that Kax is needed. He orders a handful of trusted warriors to watch over the entrance and let no one out alive.

Leaving the mine

When the PCs leave the mine, they discover that Kax has posted sentries by the door, signed with the task to watch the Mine side entrance and make sure that no one leaves and lives to tell the tale. He's eager to make sure that everything of value in the mine is found and brought to his dragon lord, Alizarinathrax.

The sentries, **4 kobolds** (see MM p. 195) and **1 guard drake** (see VGM p. 158), wait hiding not far from the entrance, led by Snarl, Kax's second in command. If they spot the PCs exiting, the kobolds send the drake to attack the PCs if they look hurt or vulnerable. If the PCs look like they're ready to take on whatever threat the kobolds flee with the drake and let Kax know that the PCs escaped.

If the PCs exit the mine before the Kax sets fire to the staircase they can overhear Kax talk to Snarl, with a successful **DC 10 Dexterity (Stealth) check** in the side entrance doorway. If they understand draconic, Kax says: "We will kill them and keep searching the place. Her majesty is ever hungry. There must be something more in there. Perhaps something more in that deep cave."

If the PCs exit the mine without finding the Aranea

egg room, they can overhear the same conversation.

Kobold Ambush!

Snarl (Winged kobold, see MM p. 195) is waiting for the PCs in the canyon where the side entrance is and has set up an ambush, eager to take on the PCs while they are vulnerable after the fire. He is accompanied by 3 kobolds and 1 guard drake. As soon as the PCs emerge from the dark door he orders his warriors to attack. If the PCs declare that they are on alert they can make a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check** to hear the kobolds whisper and not become surprised. If the PCs have a Passive Perception 15 they also notice the kobolds.

You exit the mine coughing and covered in soot. It's a relief to finally draw a breath of fresh air. Just as you're catching your breath a shrill war cry echoes in the canyon.

The kobolds use their slings in round 1, then let the rage drake loose and enter melee lead on by Snarl. If the PCs manage to defeat half of the kobolds the rest tries to flee and escape. The main objective of the kobolds is to try and capture the PCs, to bring to their dragon overlord as sacrifices.

If the kobolds manage to defeat the PCs they tie them up and bring them back to their lair as prisoners.

Conclusion

The PCs have now discovered what happened to the Ironboot Clan, and maybe even shared their fate and have become slaves of the Burnt Hand Clan.

If they haven't been enslaved, they can return to Deadsnows and collect their payment from Viveros and Rubert Anon. The town's council will try to encourage the PCs to save the remaining dwarves.

If the PCs have been enslaved by the kobolds, they need to find a way to escape. The Burnt Hand Clan is divided by political bickering between Kax and his father, Roqua. Kax hopes to take over the clan and believes that he has the approval of his dragon overlord, Alizarinathrax. He has many followers among the warriors of the clan, but the clan's shaman, Yappa, doesn't think that Kax is ready to



lead the clan. The clan lives in cave system below the dragon's den.

Rewards

Award normal XP for defeated foes. Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Finding the Aranea Egg room, 100 XP
- Surviving the fire, 150 XP
- Discovering that the kobolds have enslaved the surviving members of the Ironboot clan, 100 XP.
- Finding the Ironboot Annals, 50 XP

If you are using the Milestone rule, the PC's should have reached 3rd level after completing this chapter.



Chapter 3: Kobold Lair

Interlude

If the PCs managed to defeat Snarl and his warriors, they need to decide what to do. They can track the kobolds back to their lair or return to Deadsnows. Tracking the kobolds isn't that hard, since they brought drakes with them. With a three, consecutive successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Survival) check** they can find the lair, which is east and lies hidden high in a mountain side. If a check is failed the track is lost and needs to be found again with **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check**.

If the PCs decide to go back to Deadsnows and talk to Rubert Anon, he's concerned about the dwarves held captive by the kobolds. He urges the PCs to free the dwarves. If the PCs talk to Viveros as well, to collect their payment, she pays them what was agreed upon and also appeals to the PCs to save the dwarves. She says that the Ironboot clan is a just and good friend of Deadsnows and she feels terrible knowing that they have been enslaved by the kobolds. If the PCs wish to seek help from the other clans the Gunlaugsons are more than willing but the Fenabars don't see this as their problem.

If the PCs wish to investigate where the raids have taken place in order to get a lead on where the kobold lair is they can discover with a successful **DC 10 Charisma (Diplomacy) check** from both the travelling merchants and locals that the raid have all occurred eastward from Deadsnows on Fork Road between Deadsnows and Ascorp. Thodvar can also be of some help, he has seen some kobold tracks in a valley not far from the Ironboot mine, a couple of days hard walk from Deadsnows.

Searching the Nether Mountains takes a long time and without any leads will prove fruitless. Spending the night in Deadsnow calls for random encounters. Roll a D6 for every two hours spent outside in the night, once every hour if the PCs are on the move. On a roll of 6 a random encounter occurs. Reward the PCs if they have taken measures to protect themselves or for clever thinking, e.g. spending the night in the Ironboot Mine.

If the PCs were defeated by the kobolds they are tied up and brought to the kobold lair to be served as sacrifices to their dragon overlord. The PCs wake up in area 13.



Approaching the lair

The lair is actually well hidden, and the kobolds have made efforts to make sure that any attacker should have a hard time entering the lair unseen.

You enter a short valley, high in the Nether mountains, surrounded by steep and barren cliffs. The wind howls and the cold crawls up your skin, like thousand small spiders. A crude spear holding a rotten gnoll head has been thrust into the ground, a wicked warning to all trespassers.

3 kobolds watch over the path to the valley and warn the clan if any intruders are spotted. The sentries lie hiding in the rocks and cliffs above the path. If the PCs are searching for kobolds they see the kobolds with a **successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check**. If the PCs are actively looking out for sentries they notice the kobolds as one of the kobolds starts to run back to the lair, if any of the PCs have a **Passive Perception 15**. PCs that do not spot the running kobold are surprised when the remaining kobolds spring a boulder trap, meant to fall on unsuspecting wanderers that stop to inspect the gnoll's head.

The kobolds wait out of sight until the PCs come close enough the gnoll head, before setting the boulders loose. Once the trap has been sprung they use slings. The kobolds are in half cover and on higher ground, 20 ft. higher than the PCs. If the PCs fight back and manage to bring down one of the kobolds the other one tries to flee.

If any of the sentries make it back to the lair the clan is on alert (see below). If the PCs manage to overcome the sentries and decide to interrogate them the kobolds only speak draconic. But they know where the dwarves are being held and what treasure where brought before the dragon (the kobolds always speak of her majesty) after raiding the Ironboot mine. They describe all sorts of metal weapons and armor, but also gold and the strange sparkly stone (which is the Aranea Queen egg). The kobolds can also inform the PCs about the bickering and political fighting between Kax and Roqua. All this can be learned with a **successful DC 13 Charisma (Intimidation) check**.

Boulder Trap cr 1

Mechanical trap

When the trap is triggered, it releases boulders of various sizes, which fall on the PCs. With a successful DC 10 Dexterity save the PCs manage to dive into safety. The boulders cause 2d6 bludgeoning dmg, half damage on successful save.

Lair of the Burnt Hand Clan

The Burnt Hand Clan found this cave system in mt. Oeraefa few years ago and settled there, the caves suited the kobolds perfectly, for the mountain was a dead volcano but there was still geothermal heat there and deep in the cave system was a fresh water spring. Before long Alizarinathrax, a young red dragon, discovered the clan and enslaved it. The dragon claimed a large cavern as it's lair and had the clan bring meat and treasure.

Lately Kax has been desperately trying to get on the dragon's good side, hoping that the dragon will eventually kill and eat his father, Roqua. Alizarinathrax on the other hand has no intention of spoiling her fun watching the endless bickering and struggle for power between the two factions in the clan.

Kax and his warriors brought the treasure from the Ironboot clan to Alizarinathrax, though the dragon did not sense the arcane power of the egg, which Kax hid in his cave. If the PCs have been captured by the clan their equipment is brought to the dragon's treasure hoard.

Despite the political situation of the clan, it is quite organized if the lair comes under an attack. The warriors take a stand in area 2 and defend the lair to the death. Once the alarm is raised the clan quickly gathers and set all their traps, making it hard even for most veteran adventurers to breach the lair's defenses (see Alarm).

LAIR FEATURES

The lair is in a natural cave system, one left by lava. The walls are rough and unworked, hot water trickles



through many holes and the air is musky and hot. In many places fungi grows and due to lack of proper ventilation the lair smells horrible, which means that the PCs have a disadvantage on any Wisdom (Perception) checks.

HALLWAYS AND ROOMS

All hallways are natural caves, making both footing in some places treacherous and even dangerous. Unless otherwise noted most caves are 7 ft. tall, which means that all weapons that rely on good space, e.g. longbow, are at a disadvantage.

DOORS

Most doors are makeshift, made of wood and scraps and easy to break down with a successful **DC 10 Strength** check.

FLOORS

Unless otherwise noted the floor is uneven and rough, in some rooms even hard to cross due to stalagmites, fungi and even litter from the kobolds.

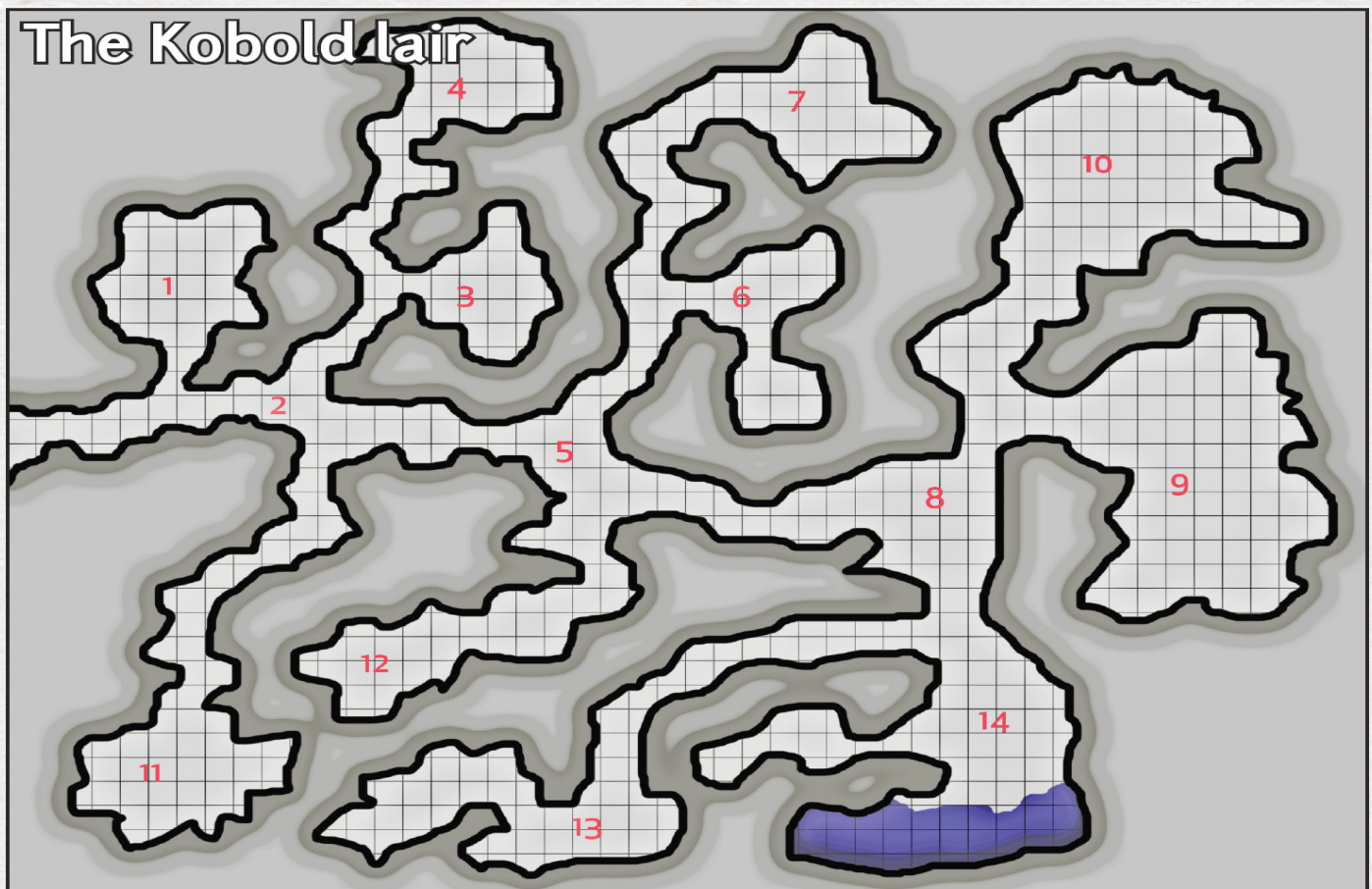
VISIBILITY AND LIGHTS

The kobolds don't pay much mind to making sure that all rooms are lit. There's phosphoric fungi in many rooms and in some there are fireplaces which the kobolds use to cook food. Otherwise the lair is dark.

ALARM!

If the alarm is raised Kax organizes his best warriors and makes a stand in area 2. If the defenses have been breached he's smart enough to choose his battles where it suits his warriors the most, e.g. he'd choose to fight few adventurers where his warriors can overwhelm and surround the PCs. If the attacking group is a large one, he finds a spot where the attackers numbers work against them.

If at any time the PCs use explosives or spells that cause loud noises inside the lair the alarm is raised. If any number of kobolds is discovered dead the alarm is raised (one dead kobold does not raise suspicion). If the kobolds discover that the dwarves have escaped the alarm is raised.





If Kax or Roqua think that the attackers are a bigger threat than the clan can handle they quickly let Alizarinathrax know and try to goat and herd the attackers into the dragon's lair.

Entrance

The lair entrance is nothing more than a small opening in the side of mt. Oeraefa. The PCs can climb up to the entrance with a successful **DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check**. A hemp rope has been fastened in the cliff beside the entrance and if the PCs haven't raised the alarm using the rope gives the PCs advantage on reaching the entrance. If the alarm has been raised the rope has been removed.

The entrance is on a small ledge, which is just large enough to hold two kobolds. The clan believes that the lair is hidden well enough so there aren't any sentries on the ledge itself. Kax and Roqua both agree on that posting the sentries by the boulder trap is enough defense.

There's a small but simple trap in the entrance. A string has been crossed over the entrance just above the floor, the string is connected to a small bell in area 1. If the bell goes off, the alarm is raised and the kobolds organize their defense. With a **successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the string is spotted. Bypassing the trap is simple, the PCs just need to step over the string.

Designer's notes

The kobolds' leaders are clever and even though they are fighting over who should lead the clan they both know that when the lair comes under an attack they need to work together. If the PCs are discovered and pose a threat or the alarm is raised Roqua and Kax quickly summon their warriors and attack, using their knowledge of the lair to the extreme and, if needed, herd the PCs into the dragon's den. Therefore the kobolds should be roleplayed taking this into account. The clan is well versed in how they should react to intruders, they use their pack tactics to the extreme and the PCs need to show much caution and they may need to fall back once or twice before succeeding.

1. Guard room

The kobolds use this side cave as a room for guards and warriors. A small fireplace is in the middle of the cave and a few nests around it, where the kobolds have pushed aside stones and even some laid down blankets. In the far end, there's a crude shrine dedicated to Alizarinathrax and Kurtulmak. With a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Religion) check** the PCs recognize the kobold deity.

At any given time, there are 8 kobolds and 1 winged kobold in this room. 2 of them stand near in the side cave entrance, where they can see the lair entrance, though most of the time the guards rely on the alarm trap. At any given time, at least half of the guards is sleeping. If the PCs attack the guards, the winged kobold commands the guards to defend the lair while it raises the alarm. The winged kobold then tries to reach room 2, where he can sound the gong (see room 2). The kobolds will defend the lair to the death, with a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs discern that the kobolds fear something far more than the PCs, which is the wrath of the dragon.

2. Crossroads

The kobolds have built a crude wall, made of thornweed, wood and rocks. There's a small crawlway in it, with a successful **DC 10 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check** the PCs can reach the other side of the wall. It takes time to breach the wall or break through it, since it's not constructed in any organized manner. With three consecutive **DC 10 Strength checks** the PCs can reach the other side of the wall, if they wish to break through it. The material in the wall is highly flammable, so setting fire to the wall will destroy it in matter of minutes.

If the alarm has been raised the kobolds usually make their first stand in this area of the lair. The kobolds close the crawlway with a boulder. On the other side of the wall is a bronze gong, a trinket that Alizarinathrax gave to the kobolds. If the gong is sounded Roqua, Kax and their warriors will enter the area in 5 rounds.

Beyond the wall the cave splits in three different branches. At any given time, there's a 25% chance that



there's a kobold in this area. If the PCs are spotted the kobold dives for the gong and tries to sound the alarm.

3. Kurtulmak's cave

This is a surprisingly worked cave. The kobolds have evened the floor and build an altar to their evil deity in one end. There the clan's shamans conduct services on honor of Kurtulmak.

The floor is unnatural and even in this side cave. Some sort of altar is in one end and a gnome skull rests upon it along with a crude and barbaric scepter.

Yappa, the clan's Scale Sorcerer (see appendix and VGM p. 167), spends her time in this area along with **3 kobolds**. As soon as she becomes aware of the PCs she sends one of the kobolds to area 2 to sound the gong. She invokes the power of Kurtulmak and uses spells to slow down or stop the PCs, for she wishes to have them captured and offered as sacrifices to Alizarinathrax. If there are any gnomes in the party she will become enraged and attack that PC head on with lethal spells, screaming the hateful litanies of Kurtulmak at the top of her lungs.

With a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Religion) check** the PCs discover that the altar is devoted to Kurtulmak, the evil kobold deity. If the PCs decide to investigate the altar they discover a hidden compartment in it with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check**. It holds a small green vial (*Potion of Invisibility*) that Yappa stole from the dragon hoard. There's also 7 cp's and rotting gnome finger, with a bronze ring worth 10 gp's, both donations from the clan members.

4. Roqua's harem

A surprisingly sturdy door shuts this cave off. The door is locked and trapped. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs discover a crafty trap, one intended to mark whoever tries to enter the harem. The trap sprays natural glue over the hands of the burglar. Unless whoever is picking the lock makes a **DC 15 Dexterity save** her fingers are glued together, which means that the burglar

has disadvantage to all Dexterity checks relying the use of hands. This also means that spells that require intricate somatic components are impossible to cast. With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity check** the trap can be disarmed. The lock can be picked with a successful **DC 10 Dexterity check**. The door can also be kicked in with a successful **DC 20 Strength check**.

In this desolate cave dwell around two dozen female kobold. These are the females that Roqua has claimed for himself. Most of the kobolds have neither clothes nor tools. They are oppressed and with a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs discern that the kobolds both loathe and despise the situation they're in.

Once you manage to pick the lock the door opens. On the other side is a foul smelling and hot cave. More than dozen female kobold faces turn in your direction, a few more are still downcast, but all are sullen and fearful. Their backs are scarred, and none have any clothes nor tools of any sort.

If the PCs speak draconic they can persuade the female kobolds to speak with them, with a successful **DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check**. The oldest female, Deka, speaks for the kobolds in the cave. She can inform the PCs that the kobolds in the cave are Roqua's harem. The leader of the clan claims the wives and even daughters of those that have done something to offend the old leader or the dragon. Deka can also be persuaded to tell the PCs where they can find the dwarves or even to draw them a crude map of the lair. But she wants something in return, she wants the PCs to remove Roqua from the lair, though she'd prefer him being murdered.

The female kobolds are defenseless, they have no weapons and make no move to defend themselves if they are attacked. Slaying the helpless females is an evil act.

There's a 10% chance that **Roqua** (see appendix and VGM p. 165) is in the Harem at any given moment. He usually visits the Harem once a day and whips and abuses the females. He is usually followed by **5 kobolds**, his most trusted guards.



5. Guard station

The cave opens, and many caves are visible. At any given time, there are **6 kobolds** positioned here as guards by Roqua and 2 winged kobolds from Kax's side of the clan. The two groups warily eye each other and with a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs can tell that there's an uneasy truce between the two groups, something that can be easily used to the PCs advantage.

6. Kobold den

In these two caves, many kobolds following Roqua make their living. There are many small fireplaces and the floor has been mostly cleared of rubble and rocks. If the any of the PCs has more than Passive Perception 15 they hear many kobolds talking, snoring and going about their business, before they enter the cave. There are about 30 kobolds living there and amongst them the PCs can find 13 cp's, 7 sp's and 3 gp's.

7. Roqua's cave

Roqua has made his den comfortable in kobold standards, he has a blanket, a pillow and has even pillled some stones so that they form a throne. He stores his riches in a hidden alcove in the far end of the cave, which can be found with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check**. Roqua's treasure consists of leather bag with 30 cp's, 23 sp's and 34 gp's, a small bloodstone worth 50 gp's and a magical amulet he stole from Alizarinathrax. If the PCs identify the amulet, it's an Amulet of Proof against detection and location. There's no trap on the secret alcove but Roqua counts his coins almost daily, so he will notice it soon enough if someone takes his treasure. If the PCs manage to remove the treasure without killing Roqua there's a 5% chance that he discovers in the first 2 hours (adding 2% for every hour that passes) and if he does, he sounds the alarm.

You enter a lavishly decorated chamber. Half a rug lies on the cave floor, moldy blanket lies in the far end beside a fireplace, where an iron kettle, broken porcelain disk and a wooden fork

can be seen. Three stones have been laid together, forming a throne, suiting a kobold king.

There's a 50% chance that Roqua is here. He has his most trusted guards with him all the time, for he fears more than anything that the time for Kax to strike against him is coming near. If Roqua is not here, only 2 kobolds guard this room. If Roqua is here, he sneers once he spots the PCs and asks in accented common if they have been sent by his despicable excuse for a son. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs know that Roqua is stressful. If they decide to play this situation they can, using different social skills. They can also attack Roqua and his guards. Roqua calls immediately for help from the kobold warriors in the den (area 6).

With a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) check** the PCs can threaten Roqua and make him grovel in fear. On the other hand, Roqua is used to grovel before beings far superior than him and he is quite an actor. He can turn things his way, even though making it look like he's begging for mercy. If the PCs use this tactic Roqua will beg and whine, saying that his son is the one to blame, he is just an old kobold trying to make sure that his tribe gets by. No matter what the PCs bring up Roqua blames Kax. If the PCs bring up the dwarves he blames Kax and says that the dwarves are being held in area 9, the dragon's den, and he's more than ready to show them where. The PCs need to see through Roqua's deception with a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Insight) check** or walk straight into a very deadly encounter with a red dragon.

If the PCs treat Roqua with respect he's at first bit taken back, but quickly recovers and sees the PCs arrival a chance to strike back at Kax. He will offer the PCs 500 gp's if they kill Kax, using his knack for deceptions. If the PCs agree he will draw them a map and tell them where to find Kax. If the PCs bring up the dwarves he will gladly exchange them for Kax's head, having no intention of keeping that promise. If the PCs accept and return with Kax's head, he will tell them that his gold is stored in area 9 and lead the PCs there.

With a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Deception)**



check the PCs can play the role of hired assassins. He will curse them and order his guards to attack these whimpering dogs'. He will call for help from the kobold den before entering the melee himself. With a successful **DC 10 Charisma (Persuasion) check** the PCs can get Roqua to believe that they have nothing to do with Kax. He will order his guards to be ready but hold a moment. He uses the opportunity to ask the PCs what their business is in the clan's lair and if the PCs mention the dwarves, he will offer to let the PCs have them in exchange for Kax's head, though Roqua has no intention on fulfilling his end of the agreement. If the PCs return with Kax's head Roqua will cheer and lead the PCs to area 9.

If the PCs were captured in chapter 2 and have escaped on their own, Roqua doesn't recognize them, since he had nothing to do with their capture. He will believe that they were sent by Kax.

8. Alizarinathrax's shrine

A large shrine dominates this chamber dedicated to her majesty the red dragon Alizarinathrax. The kobolds have carved a crude looking totem from wood and shows the dragon in almost divine manner. Both Kax and Roqua conducts services for the dragon where they demand tribute and donations from every kobold in the clan. Many kobolds also honor the dragon outside the services and often one can find food and carved idols donated by the kobolds by the shrine.

There aren't any guards there, for the kobolds believe that the dragon oversees the shrine and its magic protects it. But the members of the clan often visit the shrine with religious devotion. Therefore there's a 25% chance at any given time that a kobold is by the shrine. If it spots the PCs it will try and make for the dragon den to sound the alarm.

9. Alizarinathrax's den

The dragon's den (**Young Red Dragon** see MM p. 98) is deep in the cave system and is in the center of the mt Oeraefa caldera. It's steaming hot in there and the steam reduces visibility to 10 ft.

High in the ceiling is an opening through which the dragon can enter and leave at will. The dragon's hoard lies in the center of the cave and there's 75% chance at any given time that the dragon is resting in her den atop her treasure. The dragon, arrogant as it is, truly believes that no one in Nether Mountains can rival her power and, in her lair, she feels especially powerful, the kobold clan fueling her arrogance. If the kobolds have lured adventurers or would-be attackers into her den, she likes to play and show off her immense power.

As you climb down to the wide corridor from the chamber dedicated to the dragon the air turns hotter and steamier. Suddenly the corridor opens and all you see is white mist.

If the dragon is there, with a **Passive Perception 15** the PCs hear something large breathing in the chamber. Heavy sulfuric odor hangs in the air and the oppressing feeling of being in the presence of some greater being is overwhelming.

If the PCs decide to investigate the chamber they need to beat the dragon's Passive Perception. If the dragon notices the PCs it will play with the PCs, using intimidation and deception.

Not far from the entrance to the dragon's den is a brass gong, something that the kobolds use to sound the alarm and wake up the dragon in time of need.

10. Storage room

The clan gathers all their mundane items and non-currency in a large chamber. They have attacked and looted scores of caravans of late and their storage is packed with all manner of crates, barrels, bags and caskets filled with food, spices, minerals etc. One would need at least three or four wagons to bring all in the storage room back to Deadsnows.

A simple trap is in the corridor leading to the storage room. A small tripwire crosses the cave just above the floor. Springing the trap releases burning hot steam which fills the corridor. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigate) check** the tripwire can be spotted. With a successful **DC 10 Dexterity check** the PCs can disable the trap.



If the PCs were kidnapped and woke up in the kobold's holding chamber (see area 13), all their mundane and non-weapon equipment is there. What currency and magical items they had have been added to the dragon's hoard.

Searching the storage room takes a long time, each Intelligence (Investigation) check takes 20 minutes. There are a few items of note. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs find a Potion of Healing hidden in one of the caskets. With a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs spot a hidden compartment in the bottom of one barrel, containing a scroll with the spell *Fireball* scribed at 6th level and a *Wand of Magic Missile* (22 charges), caster level 1.

Steam Trap

CR 2

Mechanical trap

Springing this trap releases a 15 ft. cone of hot steam from the cave floor. With a **successful DC 15 Dexterity save** the PCs manage to throw themselves back, taking only half damage. The steam causes 3d6 fire damage.

11. Kobold den

The kobolds that follow Kax's leadership have made their den in this chamber. It's more cramped than the other den and there are about two dozen kobolds there. Otherwise see room #6.

12. Kax's chamber

Kax claimed this chamber as his own. It was formerly used as pen for the drakes and still smells like that. The strong odor is nauseating and quite pungent. Unless the PCs pass a **DC 10 Constitution save** they have a disadvantage on all skill checks. Kax has put up a simple door, closing off the chamber. It is locked and can be opened with a successful **DC 10 Dexterity check**. Since Kax only recently claimed the chamber as his own he hasn't had the opportunity to build his own traps.

You open the door and a pungent stench assaults you, bringing water to your eyes. The chamber is long and only lit by a small fireplace in the middle. Weapons of all sizes lie by the walls along with armor and shields.

There's a 50% chance that Kax is here at any given time. He is usually accompanied by **7 kobolds**. If they notice the PCs they will attack immediately.

If the PCs were captured by Snarl their weapons and armor are all here. Armors made of non-metal material smell horribly and need to be washed. There are about 30 weapons of all sorts, all mundane, and 12 armors light or medium, no heavy armor. The armors are all medium sized.

Kax's guards have both good weapons and good armor. Their AC is 14 and they cause 1d6+2 damage.

Kax has no interest in talking with the PCs, he is convinced that his father has hatched a plan to get rid of him and that the PCs are a part of it.

Kax has a small treasure hidden under a rock. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs can discover a small urn containing 23 gp's, 43 sp's and 12 cp's. In a wooden box by Kax's bedroll lies the Aranea Queen egg. Kax hasn't presented the egg to the dragon, since he's waiting for the right moment. He hopes to donate the egg to Alizarinathrax when he's going to ask her to remove Roqua. The box is crude and obviously made by kobolds. It's both locked and trapped and Kax makes sure that there's always someone guarding it. Upon close inspection, the PCs can discover the trap with a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check**. A make-shift bear trap springs on whoever that doesn't disarm the trap first. The trap can be disarmed with a successful **DC 15 Dexterity check**. The lock is simple and with a successful **DC 10 Dexterity check** it can be unlocked.

Makeshift Bear Trap

CR 2

Mechanical trap

A trap closes over the feet of the victim, restraining it. With a **successful DC 15 Dexterity save** the PCs safely get out of harm's way. The trap causes 2d8 piercing dmg and the target is restrained.

13. Holding chamber

Lately the clan has been taking captives, using them either as sacrifices for their dragon overlord or as slaves. Every slave is stripped, for the kobolds have no sense of nudity, and kept in the side chamber, locked away. The side chamber has no water or toilet,



so the slaves must make do with very little.

With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity check** the locked door can be picked, if no thieves tools are used the PCs have a disadvantage to the roll. With a successful **DC 20 Strength check** the door can be broken down.

The corridor leading to the holding chamber is trapped. A score of ceramic urns are hidden amongst the stalagmites, containing left-overs of a dead gelatinous cube. A small spring-loaded pressure plate releases the urns, so they fall on the target. With a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs spot the pressure plate. With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity check** the trap can be disarmed.

Acid Urn Trap

CR 2

Mechanical trap

A spring-loaded pressure plate releases 6 urns that fall on the victim. With a **successful DC 15 Dexterity save** the PCs roll into safety and take only half damage. The urns, that contain the remains of a gelatinous cube, cause 2d8 acid damage.

If the PCs were captured by the kobolds they are brought here and thrown in the pen with the dwarves. They are naked, just as the dwarves. In the holding chamber they find both Dorna and Isarn of the Ironboot clan, along with 14 other dwarves. Many of the dwarves are injured and their spirit is broken. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs know that the dwarves' morale is low at the moment and they don't believe that help is near or that they can escape.

If the PCs talk to Dorna or Isarn they are not in a very talkative mood, given the circumstances. With a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) check** they convince the dwarven leaders to speak to them. If the PCs speak to Isarn or Dorna in Dwarven the DC is 10.

Dorna is in a higher spirit and with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs see that she's quite upset, though she tries to hide it. She's really angry at Isarn for not listening to her about the Aranea Queen egg room. She blames him for their situation and the pair hasn't talked since they were

captured. She wants to break free and get back to the mine but she hasn't found a way out. If the PCs are in the pen with her and talk about breaking out, she is more than willing to help.

Isarn is downcast and in a bad mood. With a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs discern that his spirit is broken. He blames himself for everything that happened to the clan, he got greedy and didn't listen to the advice of the other clan elders. He is ashamed of himself and doesn't believe that he can lead his clan back out. If the PCs are in the pen with him and talk about breaking out, he simply shrugs and dismisses the PCs ideas as crazy talk.

The other dwarves are not in a good mood and don't feel much like talking. The kobolds have been removing one dwarf at a time and they never return. In fact, the kobolds have been sending the dwarves into the dragon's den, where Alizarinathrax plays with the dwarves before eating them.

There are always **4 kobolds** present in the main chamber, outside the holding chambers itself. The guards spend their time playing dice and don't pay much mind to the prisoners. At most times the guards are bored out of their mind and are either too busy playing, and fighting over the dice, or sleeping to notice if the PCs approach or try to break out. There's a brass gong on the wall opposite the door to the pen, the kobolds use it to sound the alarm if the prisoners escape.

14. Drake pen

Deep in the cave system the kobolds hold their domesticated drakes. They seal off a large cave with a geothermal spring where they keep the drakes. The kobolds use thornweed, wood and rocks to create a barricade. It's easy to set the drakes free by opening the gate. The drakes usually obey their masters but a skillful animal handler could make the drakes angry, before setting them loose in the lair, with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Animal handling) check**.

Conclusion

If the PCs managed to break the dwarves free Dorna



is extremely grateful. The group of dwarves follow the PCs back to Deadsnows, where they discuss and decide whether they return to Ironboot Mine, join either of the two other dwarf clans in Nether Mountains or return to Citadel Adbar.

If the PCs found the Aranea Queen egg they need to identify it and decide what to do with it. The Aranea clan is aware of the fact that the egg has been removed from the stasis chamber and feel its call. The clan, enslaved by the Blood of the Morueme, gets unruly and the hobgoblin start to investigate the matter.

If the PCs made their presence known to Alizarinathrax they've made a very powerful enemy, one that will stop at nothing acting it vengeance upon the PCs for attacking and seriously maiming the kobold clan worshipping the dragon.

If the PCs managed to free the dwarves without taking out either of the kobold's leaders or finding the Aranea Queen egg they will both have a very angry kobold clan on their heels and will probably have to return to the lair, in search of the egg.

Rewards

Award normal XP for defeated foes. Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Finding the Aranea Egg, 200 XP
- Freeing the dwarves, 200 XP
- Killing Kax, 200 XP
- Killing Roqua, 100 XP

If you are using the Milestone rule, the PCs should have reached 4th level after completing this chapter.



Chapter 4: Back in Deadsnows

Dawnlord summons

The PCs have been staying in Deadsnows for the last couple of days. The PC's have been hailed as heroes after being bringing the Ironboot clan back to safety. The town's been quite busy these days, since the dwarves need shelter and food. There has been talk of sending emissaries to Citadel Adbar for aid, but until now the village's elders have not done so. The current leader of the Ironboots, Dorna Ironboot, is busy negotiating with the elders for help. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PC's know that though most villagers are eager to help they are also concerned that the dragon might attack the town to avenge for the kobolds and the loss of the dwarven slaves.

Deadsnows is busy. Everywhere you look humans and dwarves raise tents or hand out food. Yet many of the Ironboot clan need healing and time to recover from their wounds and the hardship suffered at the hands of the kobolds. Your friend Rubert Anon, the Dawnlord's cleric from Sundabar, moves from house to house, tent to tent, in hope of restoring hope in the hearts of

the dwarves. Their lord, Isarn Ironboot, is only a shadow of his former self and now Dorna is acting as the clan's leader.

When the night falls and small, flickering lights appear in the windows, many villagers gather in the common room of The Rose and The Hammer, with grim faces and speaking in hushed tones. You've just found a nice table and Harad brought you the night's first mugs of ale when a young boy with sand colored hair pushes through the crowd, finally seeing you.

"Well met, heroes, and may Lathander's light shine upon you. The dawnlord humbly asks if you could be so kind to find him in Hope's Rebirth. He hopes that you can help him with current situation," the boy, who you recognize as Kern, Rubert's acolyte, says with a bow. The people seated near your table watch and wait your response.

If the PCs decide to ignore Rubert's summons with a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check** they hear the locals whisper their thoughts on why the PCs are ignoring the cleric's plea and most of the whispers aren't flattering, exact phrasing is up to you. If the PCs ignore Rubert's summon



nevertheless, the following day the locals will have turned the PCs a cold shoulder. All Charisma checks involving interactions with the locals are made at a disadvantage the following day.

If the PCs stand up and act on Rubert's summon the locals nod their heads and raise their mugs to salute them, seeing them as heroes and saviors. A voice in the crowd hails the heroes and many give the PCs encouraging pad on the back, saying a Lathandarian blessing: There is always another dawn. All Charisma checks involving interactions with the locals are made at an advantage the following day.

Rubert waits the PCs in the temple's main hall. Dorna is with him. They are talking in hushed tones when the PCs enter the temple but stop talking once they become aware of the PCs. The pair is discussing the Queen Egg and what role it plays in the recent events. If the PCs decide to enter the temple with stealth, with a successful **DC 15 Dexterity (Stealth) check** they might overhear what the pair is discussing. With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs learn that Dorna is expressing her concerns about sending the PCs away, since she fears that the dragon might attack the town.

Selune, trailed by her tears, is high in the dark night sky. You hurry over to the temple of Lathander, Hope's Rebirth, and enter the lit main hall. Before the raised altar, you see two figures talking together, Rubert Anon in his rose-colored robes and Dorna Ironboot, carrying her steel shield emblazoned with Moradin's holy symbol. Once they become aware of you, they turn and greet you.

"Welcome, friends, to the Morninglord's hall," Rubert says, his voice soft.

If the PCs haven't got the Aranea Queen Egg he presents it to them and explains, with Dorna's help, how the Ironboots discovered it in the mine. One of the dwarves managed to save it from the kobolds.

"We don't know where this strange stone came from but it obviously has some significance. Why would someone go through the trouble of casting layers of protection spells and enchantments, if all it is just a stone? No, this is something else," Rubert says.

"Loremaster Torbin, may Moradin keep his blessed soul by his roaring forge, believed so as

well. He warned Isarn and warned him again. This object plays some role, but in what game? And to what end?" Dorna asks, with heavy dwarven accent.

"I'm afraid, my friends, I turn to you again. Can you please help us solve this riddle? What is this and where did it come from? What does it mean and does it pose a threat to us? I'm afraid I can't pay you anything," he glances at Dorna, "our meager funds have grown thin in the last few days. But I can promise you that we will help you in any way we can."

If the PCs accept Dorna advises them to speak to Rolinda Fenabar, cleric of Dugmaren Brightmantle, in the Fenabar Hold not far away from Deadsnows, because maybe the hold's library has some answers. Dorna knows the Fenabar clan venerates Dugmaren Brightmantle and put great pride in their annals and lore-keeping.

If the PCs ask about a local library Rubert explains that there used to be one in the old Icespear Manor, but it is inaccessible, he explains in haste. With a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs discover that there something that Rubert isn't telling them. If they press him, with a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) check** he tells them that he has already tried to reach it but there were undead in the manor's cellar that proved too difficult for him, leaving him scarred and he feels lucky to have escaped.

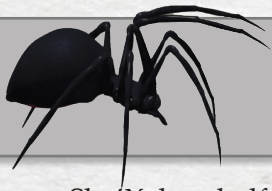
If the PCs try to persuade Rubert or Dorna to pay them for this mission their attempts fail. Paying for food, shelter and healing has proved to be quite expensive and both the temple's coffers and the village's funds are draining fast.

If the PCs decline Rubert's offer the word quickly spreads and the villagers' attitude changes, turns from friendly to indifferent.

Just before the PCs leave Rubert mentions that perhaps it is wise to keep the object secret, since they don't know what it is and who might be after it.

Break-in!

Meanwhile the PCs are talking to Rubert and Dorna



Sha'Xala, a half-dragon hobgoblin agent of the Blood of Morueme, breaks into their room. The Blood of Morueme have seen the change in their aranea slaves and used magic to discern that the egg is no longer warded by powerful spells. Sha'Xala has tracked the egg to Deadsnows and suspects that the PCs have it.

Once the PCs return to The Rose and The Hammer they are greeted by the locals and many ask them what their meeting was all about. Harad Havsum is also curious and offers the PCs free ale, in hope they will tell him what Rubert wanted, with a successful **DC 20 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs get the feeling that there's something more to Harad's friendliness. If the PCs don't mention the Aranea Egg but keep the locals informed that they are there to help and going on mission for Rubert, the crowd is pleased.

Harad on the other hand is not satisfied, he thirsts for more. If the PCs saved the Ironboots from the Burnt Hand Clan, he suspects that the PCs brought more from the kobold lair than they have shown. He knows that Dorna and Rubert have been talking a lot together the last few days and he wants to know what this is all about. Therefore he decided to break into the PCs room, but when he was about to, he saw someone had beaten him to it. This has made him even more curious.

When the PCs return to bed they find their rooms in a complete disorder. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs see that nothing has been stolen. With a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs can see that the locks have been picked. A practiced spellcaster of 3rd level or higher or someone proficient in Arcana feels that there's a faint lingering magical aura in the air. Casting *Detect Magic* reveals that the aura is of the illusion school (left behind by the spell Silence).

If the PCs try to find some clues about the burglar there are a couple of leads left behind. With a successful **DC 16 Intelligence (Investigate) check** the PCs find a small blue dragon scale, with 2 coarse hair sticking to it in one of the PCs room.

Sha'Xala also left a nasty surprise for the PCs. He brought with him a charmed **Mimic** (see MM p. 220), who replaced a cabinet in one of the rooms, and ordered the monster to attack the PCs when they

have fallen asleep. The rooms are 15x15 feet and 10 feet high. The PCs will therefore be unarmored and forced to use small or medium weapons.

You wake up with a startle! The cabinet has sprouted alien pseudopods and a nasty looking mouth with rows of sharp teeth and is attacking you.

PCs sleeping in another room need to make a **Wisdom DC 13 check** to wake up in the first round of combat. The noise will wake them up in the second round.

The noise also wakes other guests and staff. Harad finds the PCs few minutes after the fight and seems really distressed hearing that a mimic attacked the PCs. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom check** the PCs learn that Harad is afraid. The real reason, one he won't easily give away, for his fright is the fact that the Zhentarim have discovered his location and are after him.

The Icespear manor cellar

If the PCs decide to investigate the Icespear Manor cellar in search of the old library, the manor itself is large but uninteresting. The cellar on the other hand holds the Icespear family library, where many interesting books can be found, though no spellsbooks. The Icespears were avid collectors of tomes and manuals about different subjects. With a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (History) check** the PCs know this from studying the Icespear family history.

The cellar is dark and unwelcoming. It has only three rooms and the library takes up most of the cellar. There are a few monsters there, most noticeable is the ghost of Histarack, the orc adventurer who discovered the treasure of the Brotherhood of the Moon. Histarack dwells in the library, eager to get back at any spellcaster, for it was the spells of the Order of the Blue Fire that brought him down.

1. PANTRY

This room was used as a pantry and there are stairs the lead up to the kitchen. **4 giant rats** (see MM p. 327) have made their nest there and eaten what little



was left of food. The rats will defend their nest the best they can, but they won't follow the PCs or attack them unprovoked. If the rat's nest is left alone, they will wait and watch the PCs with interest.

2. CHANGING ROOM

This room was used for outdoor and heavy clothes. The Icespears liked to hunt and had assorted set of different outdoor clothes. The walls are lined with decomposed and rotten fur lined winter coats, ruined leather jackets etc. In one of the coats the PCs can find 3 gp with a successful **DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation)** check.

3. LIBRARY

The Library is large and covered with cobwebs and dust. By the door, the dust isn't as heavy and with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs spot dried blood on the carpet floor. Histarack, the **ghost** (see MM p. 147), is roaming this room and bound to it, unless laid forever to rest. He will attack

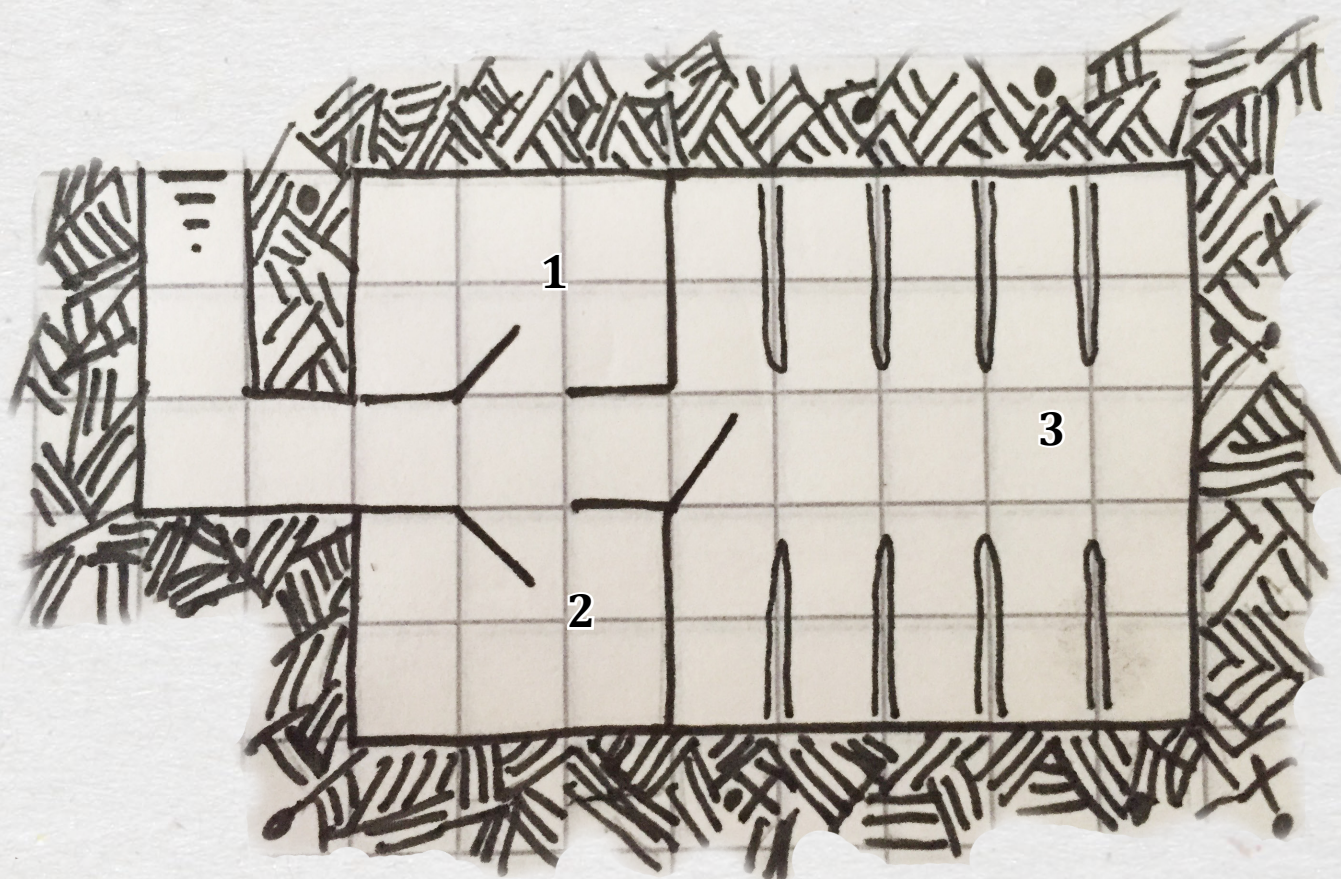
anyone entering the library, screaming that they can't have his treasure. He will focus his attention on any spellcaster and start with arcane spellcaster. He has no treasure, the Order of the Blue Fire removed it from the cellar years ago. The PCs will probably want to search, which they are free to do, allow them a few rolls (Perception and Investigation) if they ask for it.

With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Intelligence)** check the PCs find a tome containing *Laeral's treatise on Shapeshifters*. From it the PCs can learn about Aranea and their affinity with magic (See handout #1).

Enroute to Fenabar Hold

The Fenabar Hold is about four miles further northeast, where the Icespear Valley widens, standing on a cliff overseeing the valley and the Fork Road. When the PCs are ready to leave, read the following:

The sun is shining and the white water of Icespear river gleams like a silvered snake. When you are in





the town gate you can see where the Fenabar Hold stands where the valley opens to the north. The guards nod their head and smile as you leave the town. You can see the bulky form of Deadsnows sergeant, Olaf, further down the road, heading your way. He waves when he sees you.

"Well met and Torm's blessings upon you! Are you leaving already?" he asks.

Olaf is returning from Thodvar Nun, where two of his dogs were found dead. He tells the PCs about this and warns them that some predator might be on the loose. If the PCs decide to investigate with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Nature) check** they discover that the dogs were killed by a bear. With a successful **DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs find tracks leading to the river. With a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Survival) check** the PCs manage to track the bear and discover a confused and bewildered bear, with a sandy hue in his brown pelt, hidden by trees.

The bear is in fact a werebear, a young teen from Deadsnows. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Nature) check** or a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs find out that the behavior of the bear is not natural and there's something more to it. If they manage to calm the werebear the boy finally manages to change form. The PCs recognize him from Deadsnows, it's Kern, Rubert's acolyte. He has just discovered that he's a werebear and is quite startled. He is naked and needs help to get back to Deadsnows. He begs the PCs not to tell anyone, especially not Rubert, he fears that he'll be sent away.

If the PCs don't have horses they can try and buy them from the farmers. There's only one riding horse available and three donkeys or mules (standard prices apply as per PHB).

Where the trail leading to the Fenabar Hold branches from the main road **five hobgoblins** and a **hobgoblin captain** (see MM p. 186) have planned an ambush. Sha'Xala wanted to make sure that no one escaped from Deadsnows with the Queen Egg and therefore had this group watching the road north. The hobgoblins grew bored waiting and decided to raid the Fenabar Hold while they waited and are loaded with treasures from there.

When you can see where the road branches six hooded figures step on the road. Their forms are skewed and strange, it isn't hard to see that they are trying to conceal something. As you draw closer they throw off their cloaks and brandish their weapons, nasty looking axes, crude blades and large morningstars. One of them steps forward and points his axe at you, his head hairless with a large scar running across, his ears pointed and tusks visible.

"Iffen ye knos whas best fer ye, ye hand over yer weapons an' coins. Maybe then we let's ye go unharmed," he says with an evil grin. The rest of the hobgoblin group get into position, seemingly not that interested in parley. You notice that two of the goblinoids sport shields that are emblazoned with the holy symbol of Dugmaren Brightmantle.

If the PCs try to talk their way out of the situation it's quite difficult. With a successful **DC 23 Charisma (Persuasion) check** the hobgoblins might consider leaving the PCs go without a fight. Intimidating the hobgoblins is not as hard. With a successful **DC 20 Charisma (Intimidate) check** the leader of the hobgoblins understands that the PCs are too much for the group and backs off. The hobgoblin group can also be bluffed. With a successful **DC 19 Charisma (Deception) check** the PCs manage to bluff their way past the hobgoblins, who eventually discover the lie and try to waylay the PCs later.

The Captain will use his Leadership ability in the first round, while the other five will attack the martial types first and try to bring them down swiftly. If the PCs manage to kill three hobgoblins the rest flees. If the PCs manage to bring down the captain, the rest of the hobgoblin group flees. If the hobgoblins manage to bring down half of the PCs they demand the rest to surrender. The hobgoblins have a specific purpose and that is to bring everything they find and manage to get their hands on to Sha'Xala.

If the PCs search on the fallen hobgoblin bodies they find a gem encrusted tome with Dugmaren's holy symbol and the two shields, along with usual treasure. The hobgoblins stole these when they raided the Fenabar Hold earlier that day. Rolinda Fenabar will be very glad if the PCs bring these items back to him.



Fenabar Hold in turmoil

When the PCs reach the Fenabar Hold, they find that the temple is in turmoil. The hobgoblins that ambushed the PCs also attacked the Fenabar Hold and stole one of their most valuable possession, Dugmaren's Tome.

When you can see the Fenabar Hold's gate it's clear the not everything is right. The gates are open and crossbow bolts are buried in the wood, blood on the cobblestones and the high windows of the Fenabar Hold building broken. Three bodies of hobgoblins lie by the gate in the courtyard. As you enter the gate graying female shield dwarf meets you. She has a holy symbol in left hand but a Morningstar in the right. She points her weapon at you, her face grim and voice stern.

"Be ye friend or foe?" Three dwarves follow the old one, all armed to the teeth, wearing chain shirts and carrying shields with the holy symbol of Dugmaren Brightmantle.

If the PCs present themselves as friends, the old dwarf relaxes.

"Thank Dugmaren, we had our share of foes today," she explains wearily. "Damn hobgoblins attacked us earlier today and ransacked the temple. They killed poor Dartan and cut Bergarin's hand off, them thrice damned bastards. So, as ye can see we're not fit to entertain many guests now and frankly, I don't think we'd be good host. But, be welcome, weary travelers, and enjoy what little we have to offer. The name is Rolinda Fenabar, xothor in the grace of Dugmaren, and caretaker of this place, though I don't seem to be doing damn good."

If the PCs have the things that the hobgoblins stole from the Fenabar Hold, Rolinda eyes become wet and the dwarves gather around the PCs, celebrating them.

"May the Wanderer bless ye and always watch over yer travels!" Rolinda cries and grabs the tome. She stares at it for a moment, then at you, her blue eyes red with tears. "Come here, ye!" she says and gives each of you a heartfelt embrace. "May ye ever be our friends, for this," she raises the tome, "is the Wanderer's tome and this temple most sacred object." She looks at her fellow dwarves. "Ye see, the Errant Explorer still looks after us."

The PCs earn inspiration for returning the tome to

Rolinda. The PCs are offered to stay the night at the Fenabar Hold and enjoy everything it has to offer. If the PCs ask about the tome Rolinda tells them that the Tome is magical and by uttering a magical word it becomes full of the finest mead.

The library

Once the PCs mention that they would like to talk about the Queen Egg Rolinda invites them to her personal chambers. If the PCs tell her that they're investigating the Egg or show her the crystal stone, she marvels at the beauty of the stone but doesn't recognize it and offers her sincere apologies that she can't be of any help.

If they express their wishes to visit the library Rolinda's face turns dark. With a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs feel that something terrible has happened.

"Ye might not have heard, but the strangest things have been happening in the library of late. Folks left alone in it tend to disappear and I fear that something terrible has made its lair there. Therefor we sealed the library off and no one has entered it for some time now. Ye're welcome to try yer luck, but be warned, for this is no ordinary monster, for we've looked everywhere."

If the PCs inquire further Rolinda tells them that first a dwarf from Citadel Feldbar searching for old texts about clan Stonefist disappeared, then a mage from Silverymoon. Both were left alone to their studies. They found some blood in the library and the second time they found the library in a mess, books and scrolls everywhere.

The library is a mess. Books, manuscripts, scrolls and tomes lie everywhere and the walls have scorch marks. In the middle is an overturned table and four chairs, one broken. The walls are lined with bookshelves, which are protected with heavy leather draperies. Pale light filters through small multi colored windows, high on the walls. Decorated columns line the hall, though one of them has fallen over, covering the nearby bookshelves in dust.

If the PCs decide to enter the library and set up some sort of ambush reward them for cleverness. Ancient **Cloaker** (see MM p. 41) has taken up residence in the library, disguised as a large leather drapey, hanging



over one bookshelf (see X on the map). The Cloaker is a patient predator. Before the PCs enter the library, Rolinda expresses and urges them to refrain from using excessive spells and absolutely no fire.

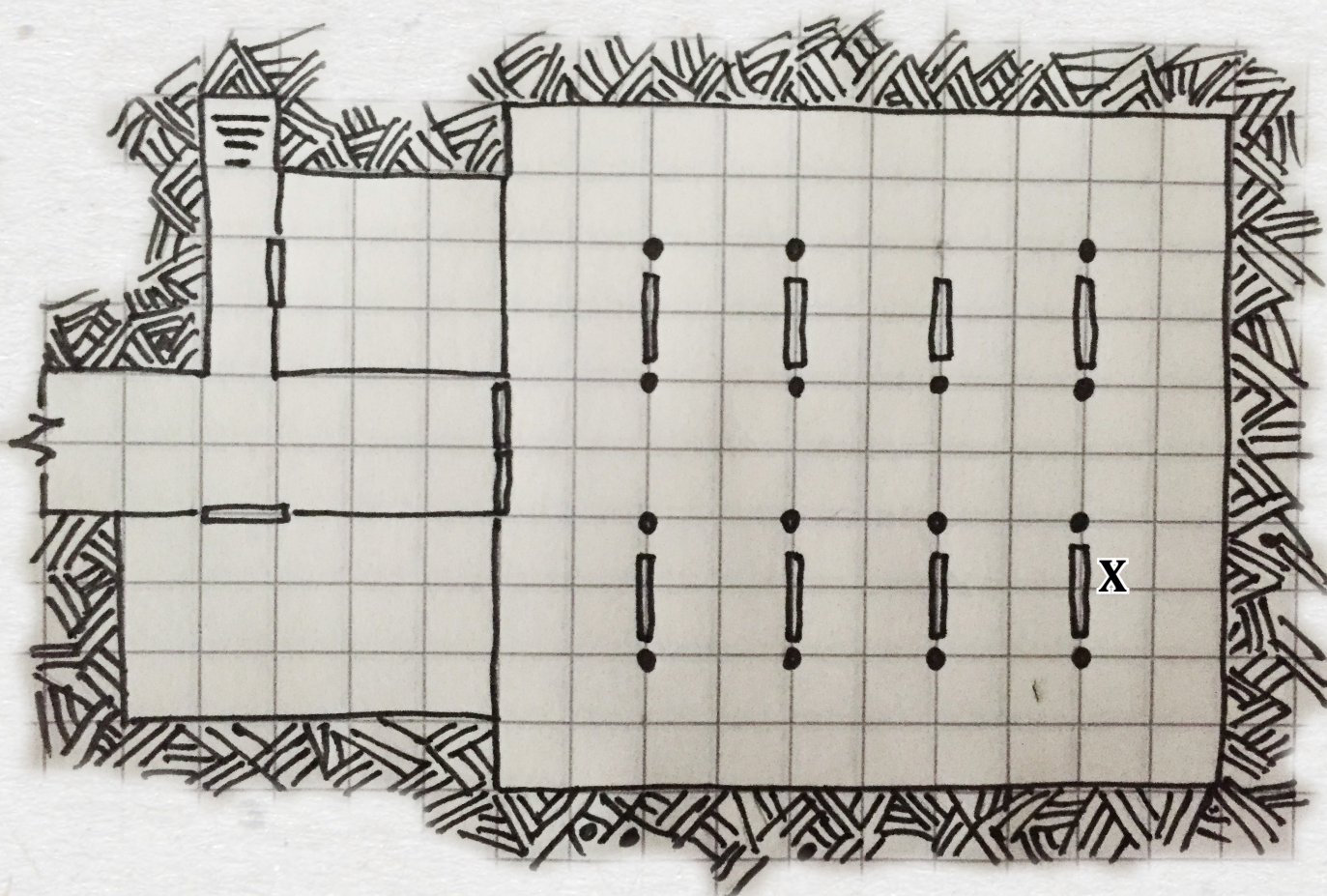
If the PCs manage to either deceive the Cloaker into thinking that someone is alone in the library, either through stealth or by using magic, it will attack. Once it realizes that it has been lured into a trap, it will use its Phantasms action to defend itself. If for some reason the PCs manage to spot the aberration it will try to attach itself to someone it has advantage against. If under half hit points the Cloaker will moan and try to use the confusion frightened PCs will create to escape out of the library.

If PCs manage to kill the Cloaker they can search the library at will. With a three, consecutive successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) checks** the heroes find an old gnomish manuscript, describing the aranea race and their rulers, in that text they find references to the Queen Eggs (see handout #2). The

text describes an aranea city beneath Arn Forest.

If the PCs ask Rolinda she will tell them that he once heard of this place, one hard to find and the entrance to the city hidden somewhere in the forest. She knows that the gnomes in Graevelwood used to trade silk, herbs and potions, which he suspects, considering the PCs discoveries, they got from the aranea. She tells the PCs to speak to clanlord Kurluar Haerlskeel, a fair and just lord. Rolinda knows that the clanhold is on the eastern side of Arn Forest, but it's tricky to find, since the gnomes both use woodcraft and illusions to keep outsiders away.

If the PCs decide to spend some time at the Fenabar Hold they are welcome to. The dwarves bury their dead the next day and start cleaning up the mess the hobgoblin attack left. Rolinda asks the PCs to help, especially in restoring the small chapel devoted to Dugmaren. If the PCs take time to help the dwarves Rolinda will give them token of appreciation, a small coin with Dugmaren's holy symbol, which will





guarantee the PCs entrance and a safe place to rest in any church or temple of the dwarven deity.

There are two other rooms in the hall where the library is, the larger one is used as a study and the smaller one used to be the librarian's quarters, now in disarray. The staircase leads up to the courtyard.

Rewards

Award normal XP for defeated foes. Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Beating the Mimic in unfavorable situation, 200 xp
- Discovering the information about the Aranea in the Icespear Manor cellar, 300 xp
- Helping Kern and getting him safely back to Deadsnows, 100 xp
- Returning the Tome to Rolinda Fenabar, 200 xp
- Discovering the information about the Aranea city and Graevelwood, 300 xp.



Chapter 5: To Arn Forest

Traveling to Arn Forest

The PCs have leads pointing to Arn forest, either to find Laz'Shadamar, the aranea city, or Graevelwood, the rock gnome clanhold. The distance from Deadsnows to the ruins of Ascore (see The Storm King's Thunder for description) is about 80 miles. Travelling at a normal pace means it will take the PCs about 4 days to reach Ascore, if they follow the Fork Road. If the PCs decide to enter Ascore please consult The Storm King's Thunder.

Should they go off the road adjust their pace accordingly and roll for random encounters. Roll once for every day on the weather table and on the wilderness feature/encounter table. With a daily successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check** the PCs find their way east towards Arn Forest. If the check fails their travel is delayed by a day. If the PCs check result is higher than 20 they find a save route, do not roll for random encounters that day. If the PC's check is 5 or lower they fail in finding a good route, roll twice on the random encounters table that day.

Wilderness encounter feature Table

Feel free to change and use these at will. Adjust the ecnounters to both setting and time of day, and take weather into a account, e.g. it's hard to spot a blue dragon flying over in a thick fog.

D20 Roll	Wilderness encounter table
1	Broken Statue
2	Ancient Stone Circle
3	Large Ash Tree
4-5	Half-Elf Ranger
6-7	Blue Dragon Soars Above
8-14	Nothing happens
15	Hunted Goblin
16	Brass Dragon Wyrmling
17	Dead Drow
18	Griffon Riders
19	Dwarven Patrol
20	Graevelwood Rangers



Wilderness encounters

BROKEN STATUE

A statue depicting a dwarven warrior, mostly covered in moss and half-buried in the ground. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (History) check** the PCs date the statue back to the ancient dwarven kingdom Delzoun.

ANCIENT STONE CIRCLE.

Eight stones form a circle. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Religion) check** the PCs recognize the circle as religious site for the druids in the area.

LARGE ASH TREE.

The large tree offers a great spot for rest. Spending time there the PCs might see L'ruei, the **dryad** that lives in the tree. If the PCs befriend her with a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) check**, she can tell them about the flora in the region, granting an advantage on next Intelligence (Nature) check.

HALF-ELF RANGER

Syndua Greenleaf and her hawk companion, Rain, are after a band of orcs and she asks the PCs if they've seen any. She can share information about what to beware in the region, granting advantage on the next Wisdom (Survival) check.

BLUE DRAGON SOARS ABOVE

High above one of the blue dragons from Ascore soars in the sky. If the PCs draw no attention to themselves, the dragon will ignore them. The dragon is high in the sky (over 300 feet) and out of reach for most spells.

HUNTED GOBLIN

Gronda, female **goblin**, comes running, grabs the leading PC, panting and seemingly very scared. **6 orcs** (see MM p.246) are hunting her for sport. She begs the PCs in goblin for help.

BRASS DRAGON WYRMLING.

Tyhlthlizar, a brass dragon wyrmling (see MM p. 106), spots the PCs and having nothing better to do, she decides to tag along. She talks constantly and asks questions like a 4-year-old. She's very curious and loves a good riddle. If the PCs treat her kindly she will tell them about the blue dragons in Ascore and that she came from Anauroch, wanting to see something else than sand and more sand. If there are PCs that speak dwarven or elven she will immediately turn her attention to them and speak their language. If the PCs treat her unkindly or ask her to leave, she scoffs and heads off. Once she realizes that the PCs are headed in Anauroch's direction (after a few hours of constant questioning) she will ask where they are going and ask if they'd like to come with her, exploring the Luruar. If they refuse she bids them farewell.

DEAD DROW

The PCs find the corpse of a male drow, still dressed in its *pwifawi* (though ruined due to the sunlight and many cuts) and two shortswords lying close by. With a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Heal) check** the PCs know that the drow was killed only the night before, yet there's no blood around, which is strange considering the many cuts it suffered.

GRIFFON RIDERS

Torm's gauntlet, a trio consisting of two paladins (Halur and Joel) and a cleric (Kariar), all devoted Torm followers, land their griffons not far from the PCs. They are on their way to Ascore, to looking for Iymrith, the great blue dragon wyrm, that is pulling the strings in The Storm King's thunder. The trio is willing to share their camp and tales of their exploits (which mostly resemble the story line of The Storm King's Thunder).

DWARVEN PATROL FROM CITADEL ADBAR

A patrol of ten dwarven warriors, led by Roland Brittlebeard, Coral's brother. They ask the PCs about their business, but once Roland learns that the PCs



hail from Deadsnows, he will ask about his brother, how he's doing etc., before letting the PCs go about their business. The dwarves will warn the PCs about the Trolls in Arn forest.

GRAEVELWOOD RANGERS

Two rangers, Aren and Mirla, spot the PCs and follow their trail, making sure they stay out of sight. With a **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs see them. If the PCs have spotted the rock gnomes they will leave without saying a word. If the PCs attack the rangers, Aren and Mirla will try to flee. They are only seeing where the group is headed. Please note, that Aren will appear later in the module.

Weather feature table

Feel free to change and use these features at will. Adjust the weather features to both setting and time of day.

D20 roll	Weather feature
1	Storm!
2-3	Rain and wind
4-5	Heavy rain
6-7	Ominous Fog
8-14	Overcast
15-16	Gale and sunny
17-20	Beautiful day

Weather features

STORM!

The day starts overcast but soon the wind picks up and around noon thunder roars in the sky. Lightning flashes and soon a heavy storm hits the region. If the PCs decide to push onwards they need to make a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Survival) check** every two hours to make sure they don't lose their bearing and get lost. The weather slows down the PCs pace.

RAIN AND WIND

Wind blows from the north, bringing cold rain and

biting wind. The PCs can push on through the day but in they spend more than 6 hours outside and not in shelter or protected with waterproof clothes, they need to make a **DC 13 Constitution save** or become ill with cold. All Wisdom checks are made with a disadvantage the following day.

HEAVY RAIN

Creeks become rivers, puddles ponds etc. It's raining cats and dogs, making bows, crossbows and similar weapons mostly useless. It's even difficult holding onto melee weapons. If PCs roll 1 in attack, their weapon slips from their hands. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Survival) check** the PCs can find a dry spot to wait out the downpour, which ends late in the afternoon.

OMINOUS FOG

Strange fog lies heavily upon the region. With a successful **DC 12 Intelligence (Nature) check** the PCs know that fogs like this isn't usual this far from sea. The fog doesn't lift until noon and even after it has lifted and the sun comes out, the nature and wildlife is still.

OVERCAST

The whole day is overcast and warm.

GALE AND SUNNY

The sun is out but a hot, strong gale blowing from the Anauroch seems bent on slowing the PCs down. The hot wind combined with the sunshine can have serious effect on the PCs. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Heal) check** the PCs know that they need to protect their faces. If they don't they can suffer a heatstroke. They need to make a successful **DC 13 Constitution save** or become sickened the following day.

BEAUTIFUL DAY

Warm and still weather.



The Fork Road

The Fork Road is relatively safe and the travel uneventful. The PCs can rest in the The Wildlands Rest inn, roadside in now run by the illuskan Haroin Goldhand and his wife, Carola, and their three teenage daughters, Fiona, Jarly and Haris. The inn is more like a fortress and very well kept, heavily armed guards at the gates which question every guest wishing to stay at the inn. It is expensive to spend the night there (use the wealthy price table) since there aren't any inns for miles.

The Wildland Rest stand where the Fork Road branches. Well maintained paved stone road leads north to Citadel Adbar, but the road also leads east to the ruins of Ascore. The inn resembles a small fortified keep, with high walls, armed guards and built to withstand attacks of even moderate armies. The inn is by many said to be the last bastion of the civilization in the Silver Marches.

If the PCs try to find some information about Graevelwood in the Wildlands Rest they can learn and find different pieces of information. Haroin isn't too keen on talking to the newcomers, since he doesn't know them and doesn't want his guest to feel that their privacy isn't respected by the establishment. Carola on the other hand doesn't mind making a few extra coins by gossiping. If the PCs start talking with her and ask her about Graevelwood, with a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs feel she's willing to talk, if they are willing to slide a few silver coins her way.

Carola knows that Blaiky Mugfyller comes every now and then, usually to meet some shady looking fellow from Everlund. She likes Mugfyller, he pays well and spares no expense. The last time he visited she overheard the pair talking and heard that Blaiky was telling the Everlundian about how to find Graevelwood. For a few silver coins more she tells the PCs that the entrance to the Clanhold is hidden in a rock outcrop in the eastern part of the forest. The outcrop is recognizable by a large stone with rusty iron traces in it. Carola is too eager to earn a few coins that she forgets to warn the PCs about the blue dragons in Ascore.

If the PCs talk to any of the girls they soon learn that they are willing to do almost anything to get away from the Wildlands Rest. They will say anything, proclaiming that they know where to find Graevelwood and say that they know Blaiky Mugfyller. With a successful **DC 11 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs know that the girls are just bored and will probably soon become a liability rather than an asset on the road. They do warn the PCs that there has been talk of blue dragons in the sky above Ascore and not many adventurers brave the old ruins. Haroin also warns the PCs should they tell him where they are going.

In Arn forest

Arn Forest is an area of pine forest and swamps, which has never seen many visitors. Recently a band of trolls have made the forest their home and hunting grounds. The western side of the forest is rainy and marshy, but the eastern side is dry and scrub pines dominate its flora-wise. When the PCs reach the forest, they need to either find a way to either find the entrance to the Aranea city or the Graevelwood clanhold. While the PCs are in the forest roll twice on the random encounter table, but consider all the PCs' actions and add penalties and bonuses to the roll accordingly.

Finding the Laz'Shadamar is hard without any clues to where to find it. With 5 consecutive successful **DC 22 Wisdom (Survival) check** the PCs find the ravine that hides the entrance to the Aranea city, each roll presents a day of searching for clues, tracks and other leads.

On their way through the forest a **troll** (see MM p. 291) ambushes the group. The troll, which has developed a taste for humanoids after eating a couple of rock gnomes from Graevelwood, was charmed by Sha'Xala and ordered to attack anyone coming from Deadsnows.

Dusk has fallen on the woods. Selune has started her climb to sky, though her pale light doesn't easily pierce the forest canopy. The woods are dark and every now and then the normal woodland music takes on another, more primitive tone.



PCs with **Passive Perception 13** or higher hear something large approaching and are not surprised in the first round.

Suddenly a roar tears through the nocturnal sylvan music. Just as your hands reach for the hilt of your weapons a large moss-green bipedal monster bursts forth from behind heavy bushes, its fangs bared and raking at you with its nasty looking and long claws.

Using fire in the middle of the forest can be hazardous. If the PCs use spells that conjure fire or other ways involving fire to deny the troll it's regeneration and they don't take any measures in containing the fire, there's a 25% chance that trees and bushes become enflamed. The troll fights to the death. It carries a loot sack containing a *Serpentine owl*, *Boots of Elvenkind*, *Amulet of Health* (with the Haerlskeel insignia), 23 gp, 33 sp and 1 onyx worth 50 gp. Each of these items and the coins were owned by the Graevelwood rangers that the Troll killed. The amulet was owned by Haerlskeel's son, Garmen, and returning it will win Haerlskeel's favor, though it will also break his heart.

Finding Graevelwood takes a couple of days, once the PCs reach the eastern part of Arn Forest. With 2 successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Survival) checks** the PCs find the rock outcrop with the large stone with the rusty iron traces in it. Spotting the entrance itself is a challenge. With a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs discover the entrance.

In Graevelwood

Graevelwood is a small clanhold, about 150 people live there, mostly rock gnomes (91%), shield dwarves (5%) and lightfoot halflings (4%). The clanhold has been there for years and dates back from long before the Spellplague. It has been ruled by the Haerlskeels, though the clanlords have kept different councils. The current clanlord is Kurluar Haerlskeel and he keeps a council of three elders, Ramal Warmstone, druid of the Forest Father, Benga Kerliaroot, Glitterbright and keeper of Highstone, and Toma Ren, leader of the Graevelwood rangers.

History

Graevelwood was formed over two centuries ago by the Haerlskeels. The rock gnome clan forged their clan hold in the rock outcrop and hid it using illusions and their knowledge of woodcraft. They hunted game in the forest and prospered selling pelts and wooden toys. They formed a good relationship with their neighbors in Laz'Shadamar, and traded silk, potions and other exotic wares from the Underdark. Graevelwood's prosperity was partly due to this trade.

Then disaster struck. The Blood of Morueme saw the aranea as a great source of labor, their arachnid abilites and their affinity with illusions and enchantments would make a great addition to their army, especially in fortifying Castle Doomspire. The hobgoblin army attacked and enslaved the Aranea. Queen E'Alatha called out to Graevelwood for help, but clanlord Mavheran Haerlskeel refused, afraid that it might attract the attention of the hobgoblins.

Graevelwood has become ever more secluded since and all guests are met with suspicion and fear. The current clan leader, Kurluar Haerlskeel, fears that one day their cowardice will be avenged, but he hopes that the clan will get an opportunity to amend for it.

Clanhold features

The Clanhold is old and well built. The gnomes' relationship with Oakenthroner, the shield dwarf family that lives in the clanhold, is good and the dwarves have used their knowledge to fortify and maintain the clanhold.

HALLWAYS AND ROOMS

Unless otherwise noted all hallways are 6 ft. tall and 10 ft. wide. All walls are even and polished stone. All rooms are 8 ft. tall.

DOORS

All doors are wooden and can be barred from the



inside. Locked doors can be broken down with a successful **DC 15 Strength check** or their locks picked with a **DC 18 Dexterity check**.

FLOORS

All floors are paved with even and worked stone.

VISIBILITY AND LIGHT

The gnomes have large braziers in most rooms. In the halls are small oil lamps. All rooms are considered brightly lit.

Key to Graevelwood Clanhold

Feel free to add more rooms to the clanhold, to suit your playing style and player's needs.

1. FOYER

There are four guards in the Foyer and if the PCs take no action to move stealthily they have taken up defensive postures. With a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion) check** the guards relax. They question the PCs about their intent and how they found the entrance. No amount of persuasion, threats or bribes can get the PCs past the guards who send for clanlord Haerlskeel.

The foyer is not large, but well suited to fend off intruders. The hallway is tight, mere 3 feet across so you must squeeze and there's hardly any room to swing a sword. The ceiling is low and you have to crouch to get into the small room, where four, armed gnome guards stand waiting, with their spears hoisted at you.

Once Haerlskeel arrives he also interrogates the PCs, he especially wants to know how the PCs found Gaerlewood. With a successful **DC 16 Charisma (Persuasion/Deception) check** the PCs manage to convince the lord that their intentions are good. The PCs might recognize Haerlskeel's insignia and if they hand over the Amulet (if they have it), Haerlskeel thanks them, though heartbroken hearing about his son's fate. That grants them advantage on the Charisma check.

Haerlskeel listens to the PCs errand and if they manage to convince the clanlord he decides that they

should present their case before the council. He asks one of the guards to strip the PCs off their weapons and show them where they can find Mugfyler's inn. If the PCs at any time mention the aranea, his eyes darken and he seems to ponder on the PCs words. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs feel that there's some sorrow in his face. Pressing the matter with him yields no result, for Haerlskeel is set on that the PCs need to present the case before the council, if they have managed to convince him of his good intentions.

If the PCs fail in convincing Haerlskeel to help them, he orders his guard to show them the way out. If the PCs respond violently he calls for more help and joins the guards in defending the clanhold against the evil intruders, as he calls the PCs.

2. MAIN HALL

The main hall is pillared and the walls decorated with heavy and colorful tapestries, depicting the Haerlskeel's history. The oldest tapestries show when the clan traveled to Arn forest and built Gaerlewood clanhold.

With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (History) check** the PCs see that the clan has lived there since before the Times of Troubles. They can find tapestry showing where the gods walk Faerun and with a successful **DC 13 Intelligence (Religion) check** the PCs discover that the clan has venerated both Garl Glittergold and Sylvanus through the years.

With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs see that almost a century ago an army of blue hobgoblins invaded Arn forest, enslaving many rock gnomes and seemingly humans that lived deep in the forest.

In the ceiling, there are a few slits and windows where the forest can be seen, though trees seem to block the view sunlight streams unfiltered through. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana) check** the PCs understand that the trees are probably part of some illusion, meant to keep the clanhold's position secret.

The pillars are carved and with a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (History – Stonecunning) check** the



PCs can see that the pillars are of dwarven design. If the PCs ask the guard showing them where to find Tradehome Inn, she will tell them that the Oakenthrone family have lived in Graevelwood for decades.

There are many hallways leading from the Main hall, to different section of the clanhold. In the middle of the hall is a shallow pool and in the middle of it stands a statue, showing Garl Glittergold fooling Kurtulmak, the kobold deity. With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Religion)** check the PCs know this.

3. COUNCIL ROOM

The Council room is a small room with a large wooden table and four chairs. The walls are lined with shelves showing books, scroll cases and tomes. On the table is a map showing Arn forest and vicinity.

Graevelwood council meets there to discuss matters of the clanhold. There isn't much room for many

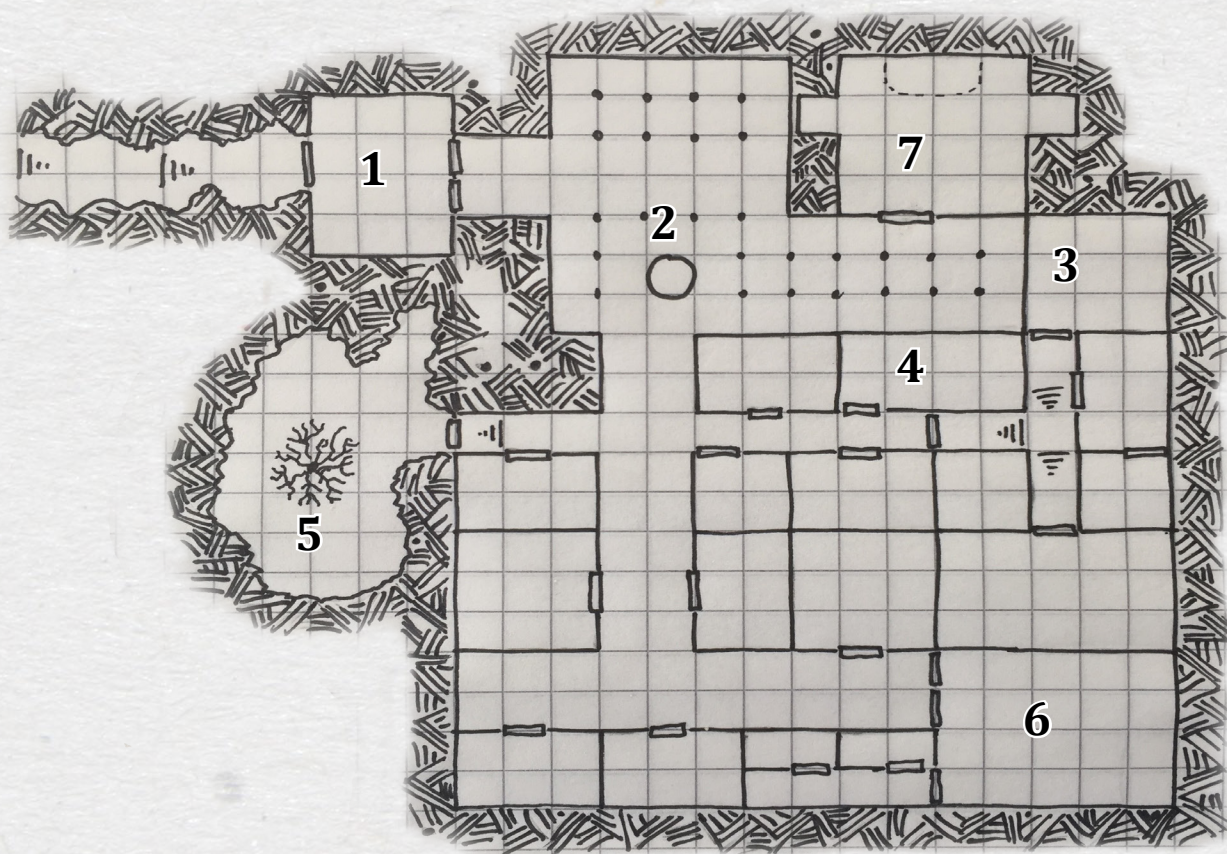
people in there and the council seldom invites guest in it.

4. HAERLSKEEL'S HOME

Kurluar lives in a small space south from the Main hall. He lives with his family and his abode is spartan. He keeps his home private as much as his position allows. His duty as a clan lord is above everything else and he only takes what he absolutely needs.

5. SYLVANUS' ASH, WARMSTONE'S HOME

Ramal Warmstone lives in the only open air area. A large ash tree grows there, its roots dug deep into the ground and the branches reaches as high as 100 ft. to the sky. Warmstone shares his home with squirrels and birds and eagerly invites anyone who wishes to either learn about Sylvanus or pay the nature deity her respect. The floors are green and soft moss and the walls are lined with vine and other fauna. Ramal





firmly believes that the ash is sacred and the source of Graevelwood's prosperity.

6. TRADEHOME, MUGFYLLER'S INN AND TRADEHOUSE

Tradehome is Blaiky Mugfyller's inn and the only store in Graevelwood. The common room serves both as a general store and a watering hole, where guests tend to make up their own tables using crates and boxes, sitting on tables and smaller crates. The walls are lined with shelves, displaying mostly equipment needed for woodcraft of all sorts. All common items can be found there at normal PHB prices.

There's a shared room for guests with bunks. Most of the bunks fit smaller characters, there's only one bed that fits medium sized person. There's room for 6 persons in the room, though if people don't mind sleeping on the stone floor, more could fit it. There's a large fireplace in one end of the room and a small stack of logs beside it. There are no cabinets or trunks for guests to store their equipment.

If the PCs decide to talk to other guests in Tradehome none of the locals are willing to speak with them. The reason is simple, the PCs haven't been sanctified and therefore no rock gnome is willing to talk with the PCs. Mugfyller, not being a gnome and couldn't care less about the strange customs of the gnomes, can inform the PCs about why the gnomes shun them. She's curious about why the adventurers are there and is quite talkative and friendly. If the PCs talk about the Queen Egg in Tradehome, whether in the common room or the bed room, she will likely hear it, unless the PCs are extra cautious, for there are a few peeping holes that she has access to and when the PCs are in the common room she's usually not far away. With a successful **DC 22 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs feel that there's something more to her friendliness than just being a good host.

7. HIGHSTONE, GLITTERGOLD'S CHAPEL – RUN BY GLITTERBRIGHT KERLIAROOT

There's a small chapel devoted to Garl Glittergold just off the Main hall. Most of the rock gnomes in

Graevelwood venerate the gnomish deity and pay the homage to it. Glitterbright Kerliaroot maintains the chapel. Few benches stand along the walls and by the altar is a large tapestry showing Glittergold fooling Kurtulmak, in a scene like the statue in the Main hall shows.

In a small room off the nave, there's a dark crystal ball on a brass tripod. This lesser crystal ball was a gift from the Aranea, when the two communities prospered. The spellcasters of either community can use these to communicate. The crystal ball hasn't been used for more than a century.

Convincing the council

When night has fallen clanlord Haerlskeel sends a guard for the PCs, with instructions to send their leader to speak before the council. The guard stresses that only the group's leader is to speak before the council. If the PCs haven't a designated leader they need to figure out who should be present their case before the council.

When the PCs are ready the guard shows the leader where to find the council.

You enter a small room with low ceiling. A wooden table dominates the room and shelves line the walls, filled with tomes, books, scroll and map cases. You see the lord sitting by the table, with grim look on his face. Three other gnomes are there too, on Haerlskeel's right an elderly gnome with bushy eyebrows and leaves in his hair, a wooden staff in his hand. To the lord's left are two gnomes, one is wearing leather armor and a leather skull cap. The one furthest to left is female with a sly smile on her face and playful look in her grey eyes. She wears Glittergold's holy symbol around her neck.

Haerlskeel introduces the council members, then introduces the PC and explains that the character presents a group of adventurers that burst through the entrance and entered the clanhold uninvited. The group on the other hand had news about his son, for which he is thankful, but he and the council would like to know more about their mission before the matter is taken into consideration.

Haerlskeel asks the PC to state his business and



explain why they are here. If the PC is honest and tells them about their adventures and that they are trying to find Laz'Shadamar, the aranea city that is supposed to be hidden in Arn forest, the council listens to the leader's case with interest. If the PC is dishonest the council quickly loses interest, unless the case presented by the leader is extraordinary and in context with Graevelwood's needs.

The council members ask the PC series of questions and interrogate him/her the best they can. Why are you here? Why do you need to find Laz'Shadamar? What is there that you seek? The leader is bombarded with questions like these. If the leader mentions the Queen Egg Ramal becomes very interested, though he tries to hide it. With a successful **DC 19 Wisdom (Insight) check** the acting PC realizes this.

With a successful **DC 16 Charisma (Persuasion) check** the PC manages to convince the council on helping the group and let them in on what the people in Graevelwood know about Laz'Shadamar.

With a successful **DC 24 Charisma (Deception) check** the PC bluffs the council to help the group.

With a successful **DC 26 Charisma (Intimidation) check** the PC coerces the council into helping the group.

THE DARK CRYSTAL BALL

If the PCs managed to convince the council into helping them finding Laz'Shadamar, they are invited to meet Glitterbright Kerliaroot and Haerlskeel in Highstone at first light the coming morning. The local's attitude becomes friendly and they are curious about the adventurers and their mission. That night there are many customers in Tradehome, all eager to get to know the characters.

Kerliaroot and Haerlskeel wait for you in the small wing of the chapel nave. They stand by a brass tripod upon a dark crystal ball stands. Haerlskeel nods his head once you've all gathered around the crystal ball and turns to Kerliaroot.

"It's time. Show them," he says. Kerliaroot closes her eyes and places her hands on the crystal ball. The dark mists swirl and prismatic colors dance below the surface. Suddenly a dark ravine, shadowed by large pine trees and strange, tall

monolithic stone formation, appears in the ball. Looking closer you see a cave opening not far from the stone formation, it's steep path leading down into darkness.

"This is where you find Laz'Shadamar," Kerliaroot says in a monotone voice. Her eyes have turned white. "Know that, there you'll only find arachnid death and webbed darkness. Know that, you seek that which wants to remain hidden. Know that... E'alatha... it calls!" Suddenly Kerliaroot falls down, unconscious.

Haerlskeel calls for help and Kerliaroot is quickly moved to her quarters. A successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Heal) check** reveals that the cleric is simply unconscious and only needs to rest. Haerlskeel will try and answer any questions the PCs might have.

Questions and answers

Where is the ravine? Can you guide us there?

Yes, I recognize it. It's only a half a day's hike from here. I will talk to our rangers and see if they can guide you.

What do you know about Laz'Shadamar's fate?

The city was attacked by an army commanded blue skinned hobgoblins with dragon wings (with a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Arcana) check** the PCs recognize these creatures as half-dragons), a group that called itself The Blood of Morueme, more than a century ago. We should've helped them but my grandfather thought that by doing so we might call upon ourselves the army and that would've been our doom. The aranea was slaughtered and enslaved by the blue hobgoblins.

Do you know what this is (if they show Haerlskeel the Queen Egg)?

No

What is E'Alatha?

E'Alatha was the Aranea queen when the blue skinned hobgoblins attacked. She was strong in the Art and respected by my grandfather. I don't know what happened to her, but I guess she was killed or enslaved like her people.



Have you ever visited Laz'Shadamar?

No, I have never. After the attack my people, shameful because we didn't help them, have never talked about the aranea. We left them to die, we could've helped but decided against it, in order to save ourselves.

What was the Blood of Morueme?

A clan of dragon worshipping hobgoblins. I think they live in Castle Doomspire.

In search for Laz'Shadamar

Once the PCs are ready to leave Graevelwood clanlord Haerlskeel arranges a guide for the group. Read or paraphrase the following:

The sky is gray and the clouds hang heavy above the forest. Still, the east wind is dry as the Anauroch and just as hot. Haerlskeel escorts you to the clanhold entrance.

"Fare travels and may your days be merry and heart filled with laughter. I fear though that your travels will before long be dark and every step treacherous. Take care, friends, and I hope that your exploits will be fruitful."

If the PCs don't want a guide, they need to find their own way to the ravine. With five successful **DC 20 Wisdom (Survival) checks** (each roll representing 2 hours) they find the ravine.

Haerlskeel leaves you with Aren, your guide. Silently he beckons you to follow. Somewhere in the distance thunder rolls across the sky.

It takes six hours to hike to the ravine. The weather slowly turns from bad to worse, wind lashes the trees, their tops swinging violently before long, though on the forest floor the PCs only experience a part of the storm.

Ramal Warmstone follows the PCs in the form of an owl, if the PCs mentioned the Queen Egg in the council meeting or when they met with Haerlskeel and Kerliaroot in Highstone. Sha'Xala, on the PCs trail, spots this, and decides to watch how this will unfold. If the PCs are especially wary and claim that they are actively looking out for someone following them, they might see the owl. With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs spot the owl.

If the PCs see the owl, they might discover that this is no ordinary owl. With a successful **DC 20 Wisdom (Insight) check** they get the feeling that there's something familiar with the owl, though they don't necessarily connect the dots. Ramal, on behalf of the Emerald Enclave, is interested in the Queen Egg and the vast knowledge it stores.

When the PCs arrive at the ravine they have a great view of it, though the cave which leads to Laz'Shadamar is nowhere to be seen. Many trees seem to grow now where the entrance is supposed to be. Looking closer, the trees don't seem to move like the other trees in the strong gale. In fact, this is a hallucinatory terrain left by the aranea. With a successful **DC 16 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs see through the illusion.

Aren finally comes to an abrupt stop. You catch up with him and see that you stand upon the ravine's ledge, overlooking the sharp decline and the cliffs on the other side. You feel the full force of the storm now, the roaring gale and lashing rain in your face, and witness the way it rages across the sky. You recognize the ravine from the vision in the crystal ball, the large monolith like stone formation looming over it. Yet the cave entrance is nowhere to be seen where it should be, just a stone throw from the stone formation.

Aren says that he won't lead the PCs any further, he was instructed to lead them to the ravine and having done so, he bids the PCs farewell and wishes them good luck.

Once Aren has left the PCs and they start trekking down the steep ravine, Ramal springs into action. He makes sure that the PCs can't see or hear him and does what he can to get the PCs to slow down and preferably stop for the night, before they enter the cave. He wants to try and get the egg from the PCs, to learn its secret for himself. He will stay out of sight (stealth +10) and use spells like *Entangle*, *Spike growth* and *Plant growth* to slow the PCs down. He has no intention in harming the PCs, but his goal is to make sure that the PCs won't reach the cave opening before dark, so perhaps they'll stop and rest for the night.

Trekking down the steep ravine is an arduous task. The slope is very wet due to the storm and the PCs need to climb down cliffs. Finding solid footing is not



Cliff - Side view

A The stream falls down the steep cliff, making the ground slippery and perilous. Falling here is really dangerous!

B Water has loosened rocks and mud, making the earth soggy. Once the PC's reach this place, the ground starts to slide.

C The cliffs are steep and hard to climb. The rocks are wet and footholds few. A good rope would be really helpful.

an easy feat. Also, because of the wet earth, the slopes themselves are a death trap and can easily fall from under the PCs. If the PCs take measures in securing themselves, award them for clever thinking.

You start your trek down into the ravine. The wet earth is muddy and finding solid footing is hard. The ravine's cliff side, part rock, part mud and earth where trees, moss and grass cling desperately to what small niche they have, would in normal weather be quite straining climb, to say the least. In this weather, it will be a long, hard and dangerous climb.

With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Nature) check** the PCs see that the earth is loose and know an avalanche could fall if it continues to rain. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check** the PCs spot the best route down to the monolithic stone formation.

Designer's notes: All these features can be very deadly to unwise PCs. Make sure that the PCs understand this peril and encourage them to

take every precaution. This can be made extra dangerous with a high-level druid trying to slow the PCs down. Use Ramal to create more tension and excitement, but remember that he has no intention to harm the PCs, though he will not help them in any way. All he wants is that they rest before entering Laz'Shadamar, so that he has an opportunity to steal the Queen Egg.

A - STREAM

The first hindrance on your way down is a small but powerful stream. Normally just a rivulet, enough to make the stones wet, but now a foaming stream, cascading down the steep cliff. The roaring sound from it makes it even difficult to hear what the person in front of you is saying.

The PCs need to cross the stream to move onwards. With a successful **DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs manage to climb across the stream. If the PCs are resourceful, e.g. use a rope to help less athletic PCs across, award them for clever thinking. By using



rope, they can use Dexterity (Acrobatics) instead of the Strength check.

If the PCs fail the check they fall 150 feet to the ravine floor, suffering 15d6 dmg, landing prone in a large but shallow pond. If the PCs are unconscious after the fall, there's always the possibility that the PCs will drown.

B – LOOSE EARTH

The wet earth suddenly becomes loose under your feet. With a shudder, it crawls forward. An avalanche!

With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity save** the PCs manage jump into safety. If the PCs are using rope award those who fail the save a second **DC 13 Constitution save**, where the rope grabs them. If the save is successful they manage to cling onto the rope, though it will leave a bad bruise.

If the save fails, the PCs fall 100 feet to the ravine floor, suffering 10d6 dmg, landing prone in a pile of mud.

C – CLIFF

You're almost there! You can see the ravine floor from where you stand. You take few steps more. The steep hill suddenly drops 40 feet. Rocks and cliffs are in your way. You need to climb down.

With a successful **DC 18 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs manage to climb down the cliffs. If the PCs secure themselves with ropes and pistons, they have advantage on the role.

If the PCs fail the check, they fall 50 feet to the ravine floor, suffering 10d6 dmg, landing prone on rocks.

When the PCs have reached the ravine floor they need to climb the gentle slope on the other side to reach the monolith. There they can search for the cave entrance.

You finally reach the strange basalt monolith. The alien stone formation is unlike anything you've seen in the forest so far. The rough surface is unpleasant to touch and even the wind seems to avoid it. The cave entrance is nowhere to be seen.

With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (History – Stonecunning) check** the PCs learn that this stone formation is not natural there. It resembles some

volcanic rock, yet there are no volcanoes near the forest.

Finding the cave entrance is hard, especially since the aranea used permanent hallucinatory terrain to hide it. With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs see that the trees little below the stone formation don't react the same way to the storm as the rest of the trees, they seem to move out of rhythm with the wind. With a **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs discover the illusion and see where the cave is.

Finally, you see where the dark cave opening is. Still the illusion flickers around it, almost veiling the entrance to Laz'Shadamar.

If the PCs decide to rest before entering the cave and start their decent towards Laz'Shadamar, Ramal Warmstone will use the opportunity to try to steal the Queen Egg. He will wait until most of the PCs have fallen asleep, then use *Druidcraft* to lure the PC standing watch (if there is one) away and use *Hold person* (save DC 15). He will then search the PCs belongings for the Queen Egg (Stealth +10), before using *Wind Walk* to get away. If either the PC on watch succeed the save or the PCs wake up (with a successful Wisdom (Perception) at disadvantage vs. Warmstone's Stealth), the druid uses *Tree stride* to get away. He takes no measures to hide his identity, so the PCs might recognize him.

Rewards

Award normal XP for defeated foes. Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Finding Graevelwood, 200 xp
- Convincing the council to help them, 400 xp
- Finding the cave leading to Laz'Shadamar, 300 xp

If you are using the milestone rule, the PCs should be level 5 after completing this chapter.



Chapter 6: To Laz'Shadamar

The trek down to Laz'Shadamar

Once the PCs enter the cave they need to trek down into the Upperdark. The first hundred feet the cave is a normal limestone cave, with stalactites and stalagmites, slowly descending, until it suddenly drops. The walls are smooth and the light from the cave opening is strong enough to provide dim light the first 80 feet, if the PCs enter the cave during day. Deeper in the cave the PCs need to provide their own light source.

The drop is 60 feet. The walls are smooth and hard to climb. With a successful **DC 18 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs manage to climb down. If the PCs use a rope the climb is easier. With a successful **DC 13 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs manage to climb down. The large cave is pitch black.

The PCs find themselves on a ledge in a large cave. The ledge is 35 feet long and 15 feet wide. There's a rope bridge leading over to another ledge a little lower and yet another bridge leading to the third ledge some 50 feet lower. The wall, close by the rope

bridge, is covered with green moss and fungi, which is in fact **Shrieker** (see MM p. 148) and it will start screaming as soon as the PCs come close enough, especially if they have torches or other open fire.

The rope bridge, consisting of three ropes made of spider silk, loosely woven together, is 35 feet long. The drop down is 80 feet. Of course, the PC's can take and should take all precautions, to ensure their safety.

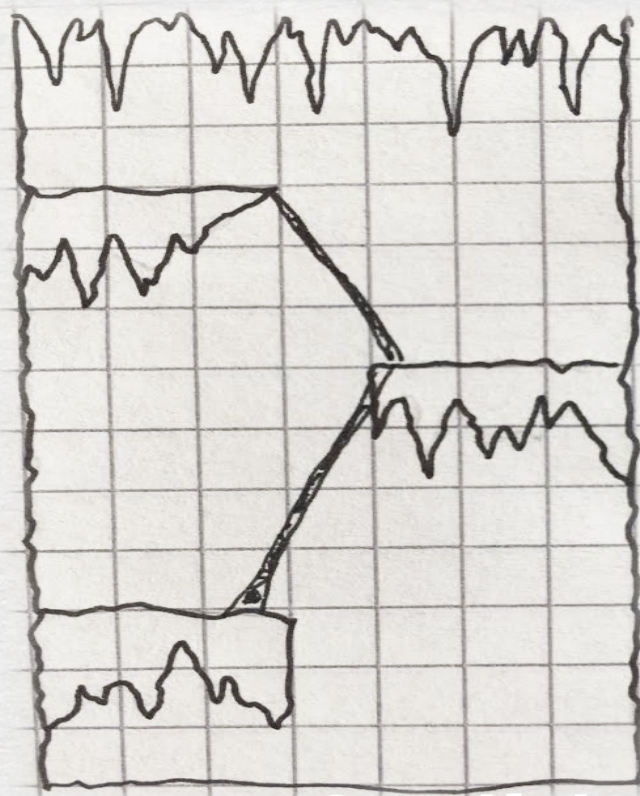
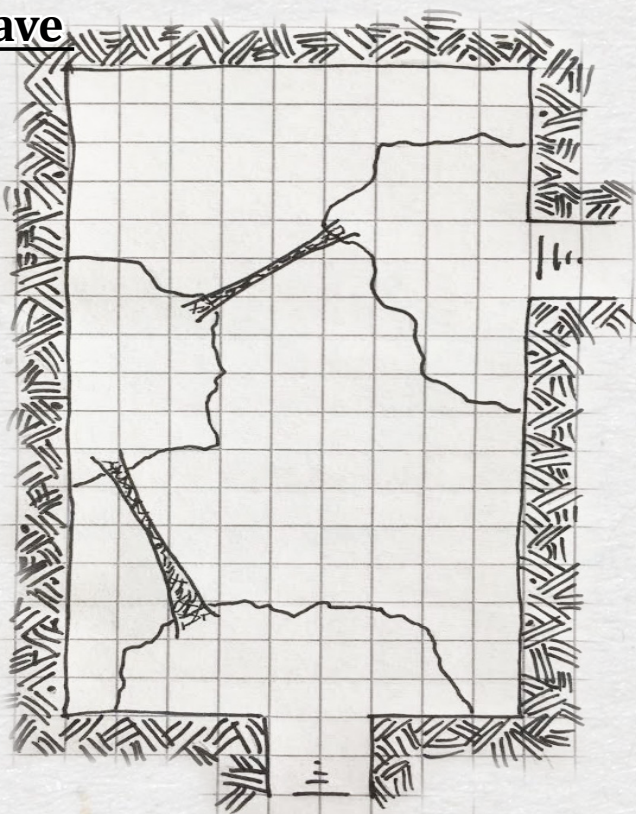
With a successful **DC 12 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check** the PCs find their way down to the second ledge, which is 25 feet long and 15 feet wide. 80 feet above is the cave ceiling. **8 Piercers** (see MM p. 252) hang there and will drop on anyone standing on the ledge.

The rope bridge leading to the third ledge is like the other one, but the descent is steeper. With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check** the PCs manage to find their way down.

The third ledge is 20 feet wide and 35 feet long. On the cave wall is a doorway, the doorframe encrusted with spidery runes. It is the entrance



Cave



Cave - sideview

to Laz'Shadamar. The runes, if translated (e.g. by using spells like *Comprehend languages*), say: Walk in the Dark Mother's majesty (left side), Walk into our Hidden Mother's blessed home (right side). With a successful **DC 24 Intelligence (Religion) check** the PCs see faint connection between the sign for the Dark Mother or the Hidden Mother and the dead deity Leira.

On either side of the door is a large stalagmite. One of these is a **Roper** (see MM p. 261), waiting for the PCs to come close enough. Beyond the door is a steep staircase leading 100 feet down to the fissure where the ruins of Laz'Shadamar can be found.

In Laz'Shadamar

When Laz'Shadamar was at its peak there lived over thousand aranea's in the city and it nested there in the cave unseen for centuries. It is now in ruins and deserted. Yet signs of its former glory are visible, though surface races are probably hard pressed in seeing the beauty of it. After all, this is a race of

shapeshifting arachnids.

The city is in a large fissure, dropping 200 feet down into darkness. The aranea houses rest against the cave's cliff walls and thousands of spider silk ropes, webs and rope bridges have been woven in a complex system, connecting the different parts of the city.

The city is wrapped in darkness and silence, eerie cold and unearthly silence, every sound made seems to echo forever. No matter where the PCs go and where they look, everything is alien and strange, not only due to the nature of the place, but also the culture of the city's former inhabitants. Permanent illusions, enchantments and strange shrines devoted to both drow deities and human gods along with hard climbs make sure that the PCs visit is both taxing on body and mind.

Few years ago, a rogue male drow necromancer, Paren, an exile of House Ousstyl in Ched Nassad, found Laz'Shadamar and made the Hidden Temple his home, raising many of the slain hobgoblins and aranea, as undeads. Paren was driven utterly insane



after an encounter with an Umber Hulk in the Underdark, fleeing from Ched Nassad.

Laz'Shadamar's features

HOUSES

All the houses, small and large, resemble egglike cocoons made of spider silk, with both large and small openings.

HALLWAYS AND ROOMS

There are few hallways. The aranea houses are connected with spider silk ropes and rope bridges. With a successful **DC 13 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs can climb them ropes.

DOORS

There aren't any doors on the aranea houses.

FLOORS AND LEDGES

The floors in the aranea houses are made of fossilized fungi, woven fast with spider silk. When stepped upon the floors vibrate and the PCs seem buoy. The ledges are of unworked and uneven stone.

VISIBILITY AND LIGHT

Faint purple glow comes from fungi growing on the cave's cliff side, giving off dim light, and casting faint yet strange shadows.

Entering Laz'Shadamar

The steep staircase leads to a ledge, 30 feet wide, 15 feet long, from where the PCs have a few of the fissure where the city once stood. The view is majestic and alien. The ledge is high on one cliff side, the drop down is more than 100 feet (see below).

After climbing down the steep stairs, you finally see a faint purple glow ahead. You press on and reach a small ledge overlooking a long cave, almost like great fissure in the earth. The purple glow seems to stem from weird fungi on the cave walls. There are numerous cocoon-like structures resting

against the walls, linked together with thousands of ropes, rope bridges and webs. You seem to have found Laz'Shadamar, the aranea city.

There seem to be five spider silk ropes that connect with other ropes and aranea houses in the city. All of them, however, are illusions. With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs discover the illusion and find the invisible rope bridge leading down to the city.

If the PCs decide to use the silk ropes to climb down they will soon discover the truth. With a successful **DC 16 Dexterity save** they manage to save themselves from falling. There's over 140 feet down, but the fall is broken by thick spider web, the PC suffers half damage from the fall and is prone. The PC's fall will also alert 2 giant spiders that lurk in the web and will arrive after 3 rounds.

Investigating the city

Laz'Shadamar is fairly large and it takes a long time go through the city from door to door. There are three noteworthy buildings, the Royal Palace, the Hidden Temple in the mist and finally the Webbed Sanctuary. Other houses share similar traits.

The PCs need to traverse the network of ropes and rope bridges to get from house to house before they can reach any of the important buildings. Roll on the Laz'Shadamar encounter table to see what the PCs discover in each house. There are numerous of evidence that show what kind of atrocity happened, though there aren't many leads that link the Blood of Morueme to the attack, for the half-dragon hobgoblins were thorough in removing their dead.

Laz'Shadamar encounters

Feel free to change and use these encounters at will.

RUINED HOUSE

Part of the cocoon-like building has fallen in. With a **DC 13 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs spot a part of a crude broken shield. With a **DC 15 Intelligence check** the PCs can see that the shield was probably made by goblinoids. The shield was



owned by Chierle Mal, leader of the hobgoblin army, and was an animated shield, but one of the aranea arch wizard destroyed it.

DEFILED SHRINE

On a ledge beside one aranea house is a small shrine that was devoted to Lolth. Underneath it is a sacrifice, a black dagger with an onyx in the hilt in a secret compartment. This is a *Dagger of Venom*. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs discover the secret compartment under the shrine.

SPIDER NEST

Just as the PCs are 30 feet from this house, **3 giant spiders** (see MM p. 328) crawl out of it and attack the PCs, while they are still on the ropes or rope bridges.

DEAD ARANEA

In this house, the PCs find a dead aranea in arachnid form, clutching a satchel. It contains a medium sized grey, shimmering cloak with spider-like clasps. This is a *Cloak of Displacement*.

D20 Roll	Laz'Shadamar encounters
1	Ruined house
2-3	Defiled shrine
4-5	Spider's nest
6-7	Dead aranea
8-14	Empty house
15-16	Dark house
17-18	Hobgoblin skull
19-20	Haunted house

DARK HOUSE

There are few fungi near this house and little light. If the PCs enter the house **4 Shadows** (see MM p. 269) attack. Otherwise the house is empty.

HOBGOBLIN SKULL

Just inside the door is a heavy hobgoblin skull. Under one fungi tile is a secret compartment, hiding three potion vials, 2 *potions of healing* and 1 *potion of invisibility*. With a **DC 16 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs find the secret compartment. The compartment is locked. With a successful **DC 17 Dexterity check** the PCs open the compartment.

HAUNTED HOUSE

The ghost of a male aranea (I'ilya) haunts this house. It will use possession and then try to steer the PC to the Hidden Temple, to kill Paren, the drow that has made the temple it's home and raising the aranea as zombies. If the PCs manage to fend off the possession the ghost will try to flee. If the PCs try to talk to it, the ghost will ask the PCs where Queen E'Alatha is, if the PCs treat the ghost well it will tell the PCs about the drow the Hidden Temple, how he has defiled the temple with his Lolth worship.

The Webbed Sanctuary

In a small side cave, not far from the entrance, the PCs can find the aranea nursery. The Queen was mother to all the aranea in the city and the eggs were nursed in the Sanctuary. The nursery was watched over by a few aranea caretakers and Kaxlarea, an ancient phase spider (see appendix). When the Blood of Morueme attacked, they slew all the caretakers and took every egg. Kaxlarea tried to defend the eggs but one of the hobgoblin's clerics shattered the spider's mind with a *Bestow curse* spell. It is utterly insane and believes that the PCs have come to take her eggs away and there is no easy way to ease her pain.

Finding the Webbed Sancturay isn't hard. With a **Passive Perception 13** the PCs notice an opening in the side of the cliff. A small ledge leads to it. The cave itself isn't large but covered in webs. Kaxlarea has restored the webs the Morueme sorcerers and attackers burned away.

You enter a small cave covered in web. Everywhere you look there's web. Egglike cocoons litter the cave floor, many have been cut open. Suddenly a



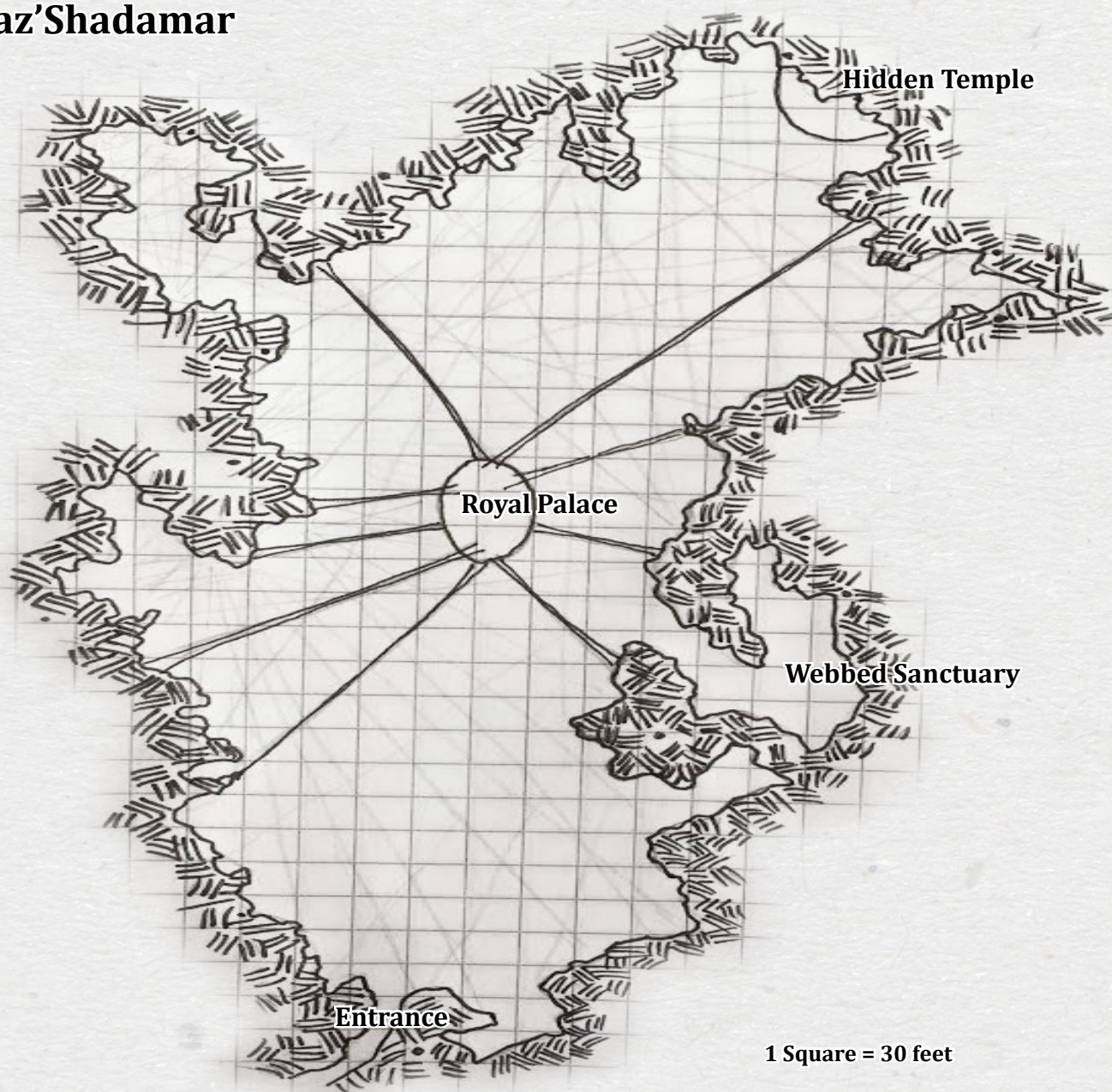
terrible and mad scream echoes somewhere deep within the cave. Then a large spider shimmers into being above you in the web, all it's red eyes fixed upon you, green frothing saliva drips from its fanged mouth. Static electricity, arcane power, crackles around its feet as it poises itself to strike.

Moving in the cave is not easy, due to all the webs. With a successful **DC 13 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check** the PCs manage to duck and weave their way around the webbing, moving only at half speed. With a successful **DC 13 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs manage to climb the web, moving only at half speed.

Laz'Shadamar

With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Nature) check** the PCs recognize the creature as a phase spider. With a successful **DC 16 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs can clearly see that the monstrosity is intelligent, yet clearly insane, its mind broken, probably by some spell effect. Kaxlarea will fight to the death. In her insanity, she feels that the hobgoblin invaders have returned. The spider will try to bite and fade into the ethereal plane, using its bonus action to do so.

If the PCs manage, through using spells like lesser restoration, restoration or similar spells, the Phase Spider backs down. With a successful **DC 15 Charisma**





(Persuasion) check the PCs can get Kaxlarea to commune what happened. The spider will tell the PCs about the attack and how the hobgoblins stole the aranea's unhatched eggs and the horrible acts of the Morueme army. Kaxlarea can also warn the PCs about the dark sorcerer in the temple. She fears him.

The webbed corpse of hobgoblin, perfectly preserved in a cocoon, is deep in the Sanctuary. It is still wearing the blue armor, bearing the insignia of the Morueme. In a sheath rests a crude looking scimitar, if drawn it glows with faint blue light and crackles with static electricity, in fact this is a *scimitar of speed*.

With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (history) check** the PCs recognize the insignia as the clan symbol of the infamous blue dragon worshipping hobgoblin tribe, the Blood of Morueme.

The Royal Palace

The Palace is in fact huge cocoon seemingly hanging midair in the middle of the fissure. Thousands of ropes and webs hold it fast and connect it with the city. There are hundreds of openings where aranea can crawl through and enter the palace. When the Blood of Morueme attacked and Queen E'alatha saw that the hobgoblins sought to enslave her people, she summoned as many aranea as possible to the palace and sealed it with a powerful enchantment, deeming that it would be fairer fate for her people to die in there, rather than suffer as slaves under the tyranny of the Morueme.

A huge spider silk cocoon hangs in the middle of the fissure. Thousands of ropes and webs run from it, connecting it with the rest of the city. As you draw closer you spot hundreds of dark openings and it's easy to imagine the arachnid people of the city enter and leave via these openings.

As soon as the Queen Egg is 30 feet away from the Royal Palace the Egg glows with golden light and arcane energy fills the air. Suddenly soft light emits from the openings. The sealing enchantment is dispelled and the PCs can enter the palace. With a **DC 14 Intelligence (Arcana) check** the PCs realize that strong enchantment was on the cocoon building and has been dispelled. If the PCs use divination they

can also see the traces of the enchantment lingering around the openings.

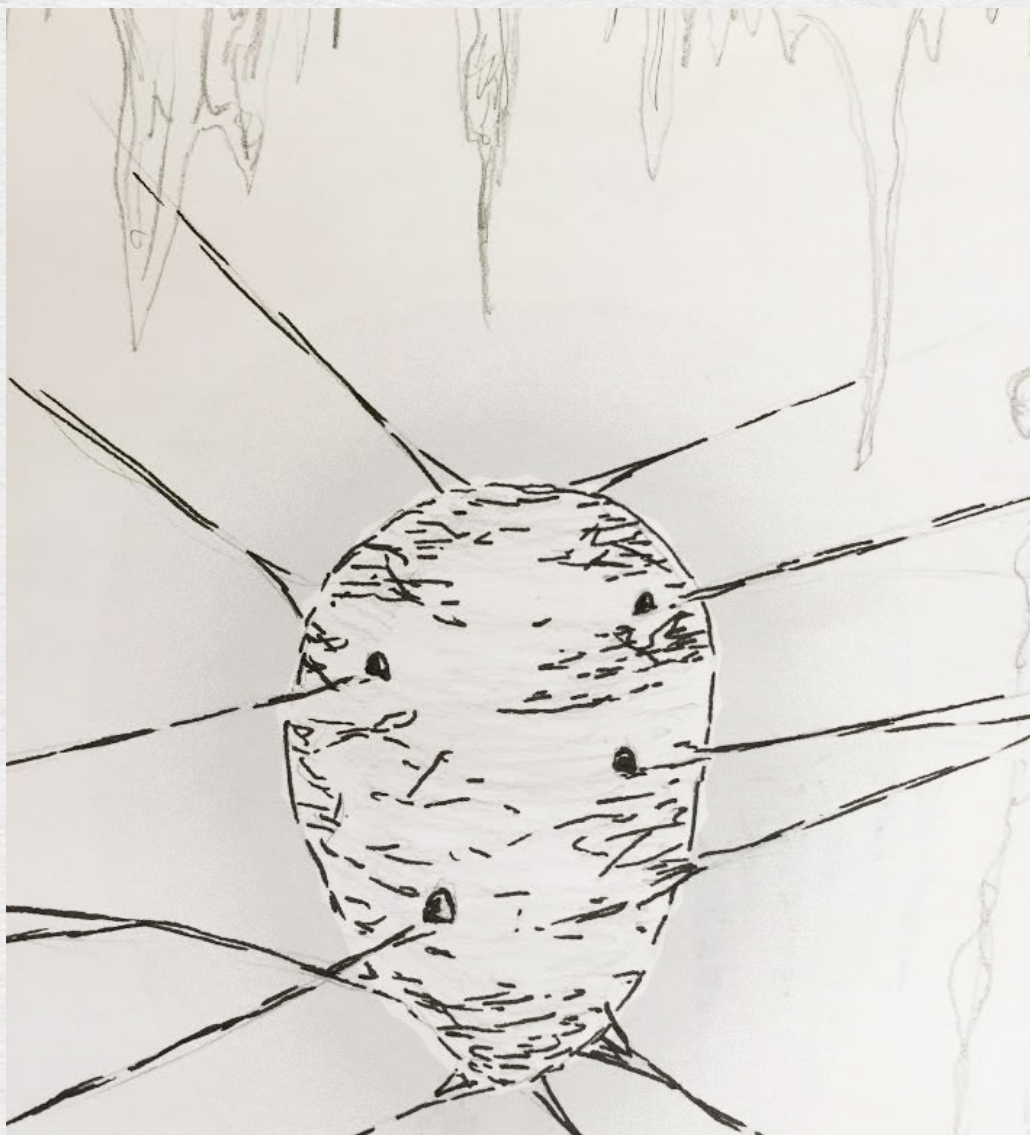
If PCs decide to enter the palace they will face a terrible sight. Everywhere they look, everywhere they turn are dead aranea. Many lie locked in embraces, other look as if they simply fell asleep, while yet others hang in spider silk rope in arachnid form. With a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Heal) check** the PCs know that every aranea in there died from the same cause and seem to have suffocated in poisonous air, caused by Queen E'alatha's *Cloudkill* spell. The air is heavy with tangible sorrow and mourning.

You enter the large spidery building. It is enormous and on many small platforms, linked together with a complicated web. The large room is silent, the way mausoleums are silent. The air is thick with serene and pristine sorrow.

Moving from one platform to another requires climbing, there are 10 platforms above the PC's and 6 below. With a successful **DC 13 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs can climb the web. On every platform, there are dozens of aranea corpses, perfectly preserved by E'alatha's enchantment. Searching the bodies reveals all kinds of jewelry and valuables. With a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs find different kind of jewelries worth 8d10 gp on every platform. Removing the valuables from the corpses is strange and feels a lot like tomb robbing, something a good aligned character should feel alien to.

On every platform, is a spider silk tapestry portraying the different aranea leaders, many of which show strong and regal looking Calishite females holding a spherical crystal ball, which is easy to interpret as sign or symbol of office. The white oval shaped crystal is the Queen Egg. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (History) check** the PCs figure out that as they climb higher the younger the tapestry become. One of the tapestries is interesting, it shows a woman in grey cloak, wearing a silvered mask before her face. With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Religion) check** the PCs recognize this figure as a Mistcaller, a priest of Leira, the goddess of illusions and deception.

Once the PC's reach the highest platform they find it empty, safe for a locked, golden chest, its panels



decorated with spidery sigils and pictograms. With a successful **DC 16 Dexterity check** the PCs can open the chest. It is, however, trapped with a poison needle, coated with wyvern poison (see DMG p.258).

If the PCs manage to open the chest they will find that it contains a hardwood staff with a carved spider on top. It radiates conjuration/summoning magic. It is in fact *Staff of Swarming Insects*, but it only summons spiders. The chest also contains a crown, which is also enchanted. It works as *Amulet of Proof against detection and location*.

After a few rounds an apparition appears before the PCs. A regal and majestic aranea in human form, resembling a hauntingly beautiful Calishite woman. This is the ghost of Queen E'Alatha. She tasks the PCs with finding the enslaved aranea and bring them

back home to Laz'Shadamar. Her spirit senses the Queen Egg, as it is bound to it.

A ghostly figure appears. A beautiful, majestic woman stands before you, looking each of you in the eye. Her eyes are hauntingly charming but deep with sorrow.

"Thank you for bringing my egg back to Laz'Shadamar," she says, her tongue thick with heavy accent. "Dark Mother bless you. There is still hope for my kin, my people. Our city was attacked by an army of blue skinned devils. They took our young, they took our people and they took our lives. They took Laz'Shadamar." She pauses for a moment and takes a step closer. "If you are true heroes, brought here by her grace the Dark Mother, I, Queen E'altha, leader of the hidden, ask of you this, free my people and lead them back home. Please, lead them back to



Laz'Shadamar. Help them clean the city of the one who defiles it, defiles our dark mother's temple. Help us. Will you help us, please?"

With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs feel that the apparition was sincere and hopeful in that the PCs will take on this mission. If the PCs either answer the Queen E'alatha and agree to take on this task, or offer to leave the egg, the figure reappears, now wrapped in grey cloak, wearing a silvered mask, hiding her whole face.

If the PCs ask E'alatha about the Queen Egg, she will tell them that it is simply a symbol of office, carried by every aranea queen since the city's founding. This is a lie, with a successful **DC 22 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs feel that she's not being sincere. No matter how hard the PCs press she will not back down from this story. If the PCs are stubborn, allow them to make a **DC 10 Intelligence check**. If they succeed, they realize that E'alata is a Leiran and will lie or distort the truth whenever possible. Therefore any question they might ask will be answered untruthfully and it is their task to put together the pieces.

If the PCs ask about the devils or hobgoblins E'Alatha changes form and takes on the form of a blue skinned hobgoblin with draconic wings. She will laugh and say that the aranea were easy to conquer, their sword cut easily through their frail arachnid bodies. Slaves for the Morueme, glory for the Morueme. Long live the Blood of Morueme.

If the PCs ask about the aranea slaves, E'Alatha will once more change her appearance and become a male aranea. She will inform that PCs that the aranea are treated with kindness, their young are healthy and the life in castle Doomspire is fair and filled with joy.

If the PCs ask about the 'one who defiles the Dark Mother's temple' E'alatha changes shape once, pristine colors playing around her, more and becomes a giant spider with human arms, then a dark haired human female, after that a white haired female drow, dressed as a high priest of Lolth. She will spit at them, curse them in Undercommon and demand their subordination, 'bow to the might and glory of Lolth'. Then her appearance changes once more and she becomes a frail looking human, with

rotten skin and sunken eyes. It's easy to see that she has become a zombie.

Queen E'alatha doesn't answer any more question with information that, if deciphered correctly, can be helpful to the PCs. She will on the other hand lie whenever possible, though most of the lies are either outrageous or farfetched.

When the PCs are ready to leave, she will once more change her shape and address the PCs, imploring them to find her kin and deliver the Queen Egg to her ascendant.

Once more the Queen changes her shape and becomes the regal Calishite woman again. "Please, kind heroes, I besiege you. Free my people, lead them back home and bring my ascendant the egg you have. Bring them back to Laz'Shadamar. Clean the city of the evil that taints it and you will be greatly awarded. Bring us ipsi renascantur ex deo." Then the image fades away.

With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (History) check** the PCs recognize the last part from an ancient Oghmanyte prophecy, written before the Times of Troubles, where it is foretold that the lying god will be killed by the insane, only to be reborn again.

The Hidden Temple

The Hidden Temple, once devoted to Leira, the goddess of illusion, lies and deception, lies deep in the fissure, where Laz'Shadamar rests. When the aranea still lived in the city the temple was shrouded in fog and mist, that streamed from a geothermal area from below. The mist doesn't stream as much as it used to and when the rogue drow necromancer, Paren Ousstyl, found the ruins he made the temple his and defiled it with his zombies.

As you go deeper into the ruined city you see where a large cocoon structure rests against one cliff side. It's partly shrouded in hot mist, smelling faintly of sulphur. There's a large opening in the middle of the cocoon and ledge in the cliff. Even from where you stand you can see people shuffle about there on the ledge.

There are **8 zombies** (see MM p.316) on the ledge and will attack the PCs as soon as they step on the ledge. The ledge is 30 feet long and 25 feet wide, of



uneven stone. The opening is 10 feet away from the ledge, but a permanent illusion makes it seem as if the ledge goes all the way. With a successful **DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs see through the illusion. If they fail to see through it and step on the illusionary ledge they fall, if they fail a **DC 14 Dexterity save**, falling 60 feet down, landing on stones and rock.

If the PCs manage to defeat the zombies they can enter the temple. When the temple was in order and devoted to Leira the mist streamed freely in it, making it difficult to find one's way in it. Mirrors and silvered walls made it even more confusing and uninitiated could easily get lost in there. Paron has however ruined many of the mirrors and closed the holes which let the mist in, now the temple is a sad reminder of its former glory.

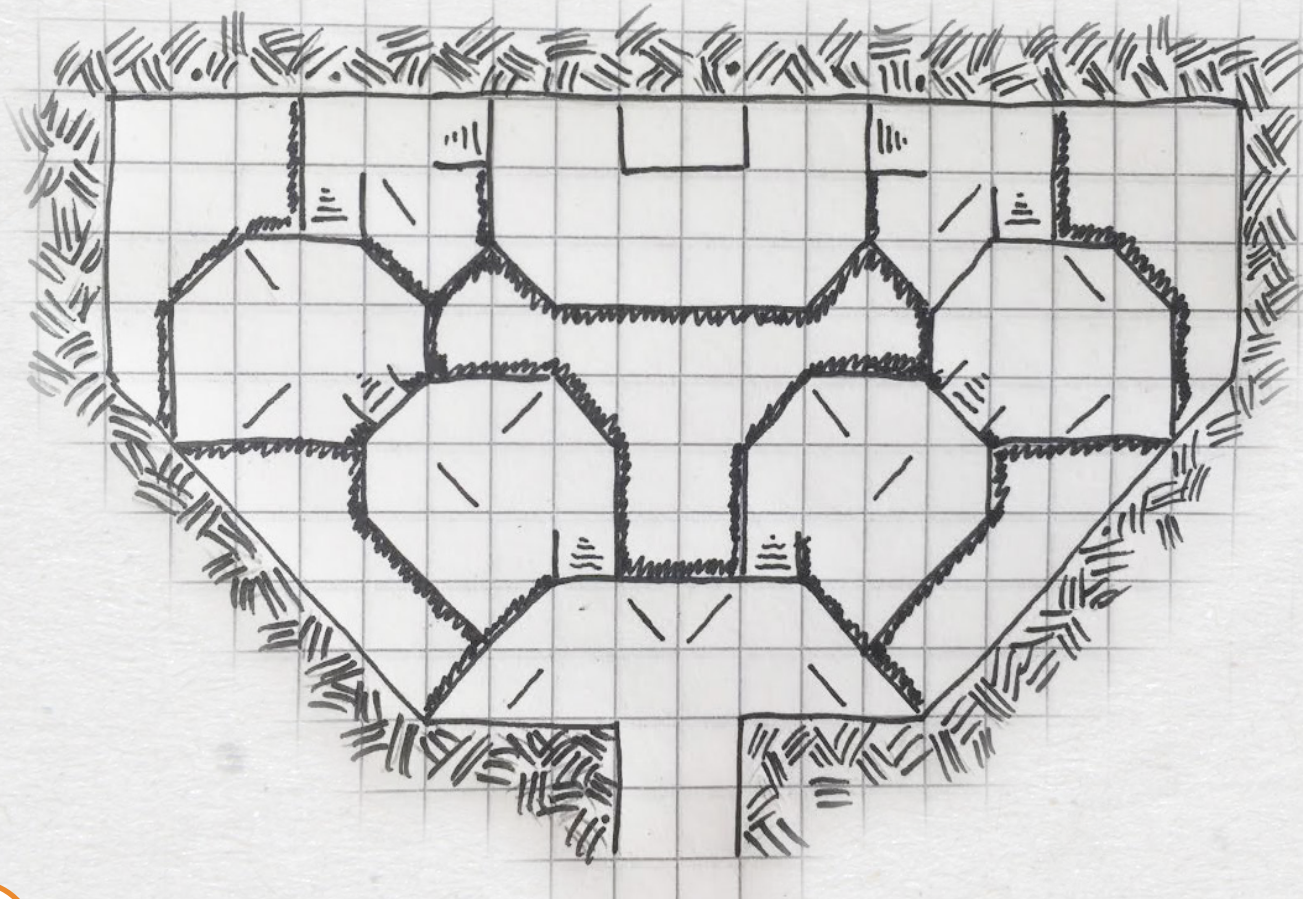
You enter a large spherical hall with many platforms. Broken mirrors and strange silvered walls are everywhere. Everything reeks of rotting flesh and decay. In the middle of the hall, on a raised dais, is a horrible throne, made of rotting aranea bodies. Surrounded by dozen zombies, a white haired drow stands by the throne and once

he becomes aware of you, he turns around and smiles wickedly. "Welcome, travelers, welcome to the house of the dead. How wonderful that you decided to stop by, I just recently ran out of..." he beckons to the zombies with this gaunt, frail hands, "spell components."

Paron is insane and his ultimate goal is to become a lich, ruling over these ruins. He firmly believes that the only thing he needs is locked in the Royal Palace and that the Palace is locked because of some cruel punishment from Lolth, since house Ousstyl fell and he didn't die with it. He has erected a shrine devoted to Lolth in the temple and believes that by making regular sacrifices the deity will sooner or later become pleased with him.

Paron will order his zombies to attack the PCs and use his spells to attack any spellcaster. He is eager to both get the PCs bodies to turn them into zombies but also, he wants to see if the PCs have something of value that could please his evil goddess. Paron is a **drow mage** (see MM p. 129) but his spell list is different due to the fact that he is a necromancer (see Appendix.)

Moving from one platform to another requires





climbing. With a successful **DC 13 Strength (Athletics) check** the PCs climb the ropes and webs that link the platforms.

If the PCs defeat Paron and clear out the Lolth shrine they will gain inspiration. Underneath the Lolth shrine is a secret compartment. With a successful **DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation) check** the PCs will discover it. In it Paron has stowed away a *ring of evasion*, *chain mail +2* and *frost brand short sword*.

Leaving Laz'Shadamar

Once the PCs leave the empty aranea city Warmstone will be waiting from them, eager to steal the artifact. He will at first try to reason with the PCs, telling them that he is a member of the Emerald Enclave and that the egg is a valuable artifact that needs to be in the right hands, since there are many evil beings that lust for it, especially the sorcerers of the Blood of Morueme. If the PCs deny him he will warn them and say that they are meddling in affairs that are way beyond them, using his Intimidation (+8) to spook them. If they still resist he will once more say that he foresees that their stubbornness will be their doom, before turning into an owl and fly away. He will try again to steal the egg from the PCs, using his shapeshifting abilities and spells to the fullest.

If the PCs agree and give him the egg he will thank them and turn into an owl and fly back to Graevelwood. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Insight) check** the PCs get the feeling that perhaps this wasn't the wisest of choices.

Conclusion

The PCs should now have enough information about what happened in Laz'Shadamar to decide what is the best course of action. They can decide to keep the egg for themselves, they can give it Warmstone or even sell it and live happily ever after, for the Queen Egg will easily sell for a fortune.

On the other hand, the PCs now know that the aranea are being held as slaves in Doomspire village and that they were asked to free them and lead them back to Laz'Shadamar. Not only that, but Queen

E'Alatha hinted that the freedom of her people and the PCs part in it, might have something to do with the resurrection or rebirth of the lying god, Leira.

Sha'Xala, the half-dragon hobgoblin sent for the Aranea Egg by the Blood of Morueme, is furious. The hobgoblin lost the trail once the PCs entered Laz'Shadamar and fears that the PCs will discover what happened there. Sha'Xala searches for the PCs for a few days before backtracking to Graevelwood and, after a short investigation, goes back to Doomspire.

REWARDS

Award normal XP for defeated foes. Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Finding Webbed Sanctuary, 300 xp
- Talk to Queen E'alatha and accept her mission, 600 xp
- Clear out the zombies and the Lolth shrine in the Hidden temple, 600 xp

If you are using the milestone rule, the PCs should be level 6 after completing this chapter.



Chapter 7: To Doomspire

Enroute to Doomspire

The PCs are on their way to Doomspire village in easternmost Nether Mountains, to save the Aranea tribe. Whether they are coming from Arn Forest, Graevelwood or Deadsnows, their trip is mostly uneventful. Roll on the weather table for every day the PCs spend on the road. It takes about four days walking from Arn Forest to the Nether Mountains. If the PCs decide to stop in Graevelwood Clanhold or backtrack to Deadsnows, add a few days. Feel free to add random encounters, especially in Arn Forest, since the chance to encounter a troll is quite high there (see Trouble Under Arn Forest).

D20 roll	Weather feature
1	Storm!
2-3	Rain and wind
4-5	Heavy rain
6-7	Ominous Fog
8-14	Overcast
15-16	Gale and sunny
17-20	Beautiful day

Weather features

STORM!

The day starts overcast but soon the wind picks up and around noon thunder roars in the sky. Lightning flashes and soon a heavy storm hits the region. If the PCs decide to push onwards they need to make a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Survival) check** every two hours to make sure they don't lose their bearing and get lost. The weather slows down the PCs pace.

RAIN AND WIND

Wind blows from the north, bringing cold rain and biting wind. The PCs can push on through the day but in they spend more than 6 hours outside and not in shelter or protected with waterproof clothes, they need to make a **DC 13 Constitution save** or become ill with cold. All Wisdom checks are made with a disadvantage the following day.

HEAVY RAIN



Creeks become rivers, puddles ponds etc. It's raining cats and dogs, making bows, crossbows and similar weapons mostly useless. It's even difficult holding onto melee weapons. If PCs roll 1 in attack, their weapon slips from their hands. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Survival) check** the PCs can find a dry spot to wait out the downpour, which ends late in the afternoon.

OMINOUS FOG

Strange fog lies heavily upon the region. With a successful **DC 12 Intelligence (Nature) check** the PCs know that fogs like this isn't usual this far from sea. The fog doesn't lift until noon and even after it has lifted and the sun comes out, the nature and wildlife is still.

OVERCAST

The whole day is overcast and warm.

GALE AND SUNNY

The sun is out but a hot, strong gale blowing from the Anauroch seems bent on slowing the PCs down. The hot wind combined with the sunshine can have serious effect on the PCs. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Heal) check** the PCs know that they need to protect their faces. If they don't they can suffer a heatstroke. They need to make a successful **DC 13 Constitution save** or become sickened the following day.

BEAUTIFUL DAY

Warm and still weather.

Hobgoblin patrols

There are hobgoblin patrols, consisting of **1 hobgoblin captain** and **6 hobgoblins** (see MM p. 186) roaming near the mountains and the PCs can either choose to face them or try to avoid them. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check**, followed by a successful **DC 15 Dexterity (Stealth) check** assures that the PCs avoid the hobgoblins. If

the PCs decide to talk to the hobgoblins, e.g. if they have attacked the patrol and captured one or more hobgoblins alive, with a successful **DC 17 Charisma (Intimidate) check** they can coerce the hobgoblins to disclose some information about Doomspire village (all hobgoblins know about the warlords and the politics in Doomspire as well as about the many slaves that are in the village, only the captain knows about the entrances to the caves and the secret entrance to the village).

Alizarinathrax returns

The third night after the PCs head out for Doomspire village the red dragon Alizarinathrax (**Young Red Dragon**, see MM p. 98) finds them. The dragon is eager to get back at the PCs for freeing her dwarven slaves and attacking the Burnt Hand Clan. If the first PC on watch that night has more than 15 in Passive Perception the PC hears something large fly once over. The rounds later the dragon lands with a mighty roar in the middle of their camp. If the PC on watch fails to notice the dragon approaching, the group is surprised when the dragon lands.

A large red dragon crashes down upon the fire in the middle of your camp and roars threatenly. Its eyes burn with anger and malice. "You thieves, you insolent thieves, did you really think you could steal my slaves, my food and get away with it. Now you will die, just like your friends in that despicable village," the dragon hisses and inhales sharply.

Alizarinathrax will start with breathing fire, trying to catch as many PCs in the cone as possible. She is overly confident and arrogant, believing that she is far superior to the PCs. She will attack with claws and bite, eager to show off her strength. Alizarinathrax only has 150 hps, due to her fight with the Deadsnows militia. With a **DC 17 Wisdom (Perception) check** the PCs see that the dragon has scars on her forelegs and neck.

If the PCs manage to get her below half hp value she will take off, using her wings to fly above the PCs. There she will use her breath weapon again (if it has recharged). If the PCs manage to get her below 25% hp value, she will flee, threatening that this is



not the last the PCs have seen off her and they will meet again etc. If the PCs manage to slay the dragon, there's a considerable dragon hoard waiting for them in the Burnt Hand Clan lair, if they wish to visit it again.

Alizarinathrax can become a recurring villain. She might be seen flying high in the sky, or attack when the PCs are not expecting it, though she doesn't appear more in this adventure. Feel free to use her at will, for her hatred for the PCs knows no boundaries and she will, once she heals, stop at nothing getting back at the PCs.

Ol'Tom and message from Deadsnows

On the forth day, when the Nether Mountains are looming close by, a bear comes running down a hill not far away. It changes shape and turns into the Ol'Tom, the druid that roams the mountains near Deadsnows. He greets the PCs, though he smiles his eyes are grim and serious. With a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Insight)** the PCs feel that there something wrong, something that lies heavily upon his heart.

"Dear friends, I've come to warn you. A red dragon attacked Deadsnows few days ago. Most of the villagers managed to hide away in cellars though many houses were burned down. Sergeant Olaf and Rupert Anon along with a few dwarves attacked the dragon and managed to drive it away, but at a great cost. The dragon killed Olaf and seriously injured Rupert, claiming it would return again. My friends, Dorna Ironboot, asked me to find you and warn you, for the dragon was the one that had held the dwarf clan hostage. The dragon is looking for you!"

If the PCs tell Ol'Tom about their encounter with the dragon he is genuinely surprised, especially if they managed to slay Alizarinathrax. He will be relieved to hear that they survived the encounter and will offer what healing spells (*Cure Wounds* as 5th level caster, *Goodberry*), he has to speed their recovery. If the PCs tell Ol'Tom about their plan to rescue the Aranea slaves, he will nod his head, deep in thought.

"For a long time the hobgoblins in Doomspire have been a thorn in my shoe. Their cruelty knows no limits. Not only do they venerate their disgusting warmonger god, but many of them also

have found love for the maiden of pain, Loviatar. I also believe they have some Banites among them. But be careful, there are still some hobgoblins in the village that have dragon blood in their veins, who are strong in the Art and very dangerous. I've heard that they venerate someone called The Son of Morueme. And finally, the blue dragons who live there, are mighty spellcasters and you should show extreme caution around them.

Doomspire is not stronghold you can maul like a bear, you need to be foxes, mice and ravens. Saving the slaves is not an easy task and requires even some unsavory acts on your behalf. Are you ready for that? Do you think you have it in you to straight out steal, murder and cause other creatures harm?"

Give the players chance to discuss the matter with Ol'Tom. He will not partake in their decisions but will just remind them that this is not your typical storm-the-castle task, because it will take more than just brawn and battle skills. The PCs might face some hard choices, e.g. assassination of a hobgoblin leader is an evil act. Is the greater good always a viable excuse? This is a great roleplaying opportunity, especially for characters of different alignment.

Ol'Tom knows about the secret entrance to Doomspire (see chapter 2) and shares that information with the PCs. If the PCs ask about the village, he knows that it is more like an army camp, and there are many slaves held there, not only the Aranea, but also goblins, humans and orcs. The hobgoblins send out war parties and patrols on a regular basis, but the war parties have mostly attacked caravans coming over the Anauroch desert to the Silver Marches.

When Ol'Tom is leaving his face turns grim and he says:

"Just remember friends, that every action has a counteraction, just as the attack on Deadsnows showed us. Be careful and make sure that your actions don't bring more harm to either the ones you wish to save or the good people of the Nether mountains."

Ramal Wurmstone

Ramal, the Emerald Enclave druid, is fast on the PCs heels and desires to own the Aranea Queen Egg, he favours wildshaping into an owl. Still, he dares not



to confront the PCs himself so he will try to use his spells and knowledge of nature to slow them down. He will use spells like Spike growth, Sleet storm, Grasping vine and other similar spells. Ramal does not summon animals to attack the PCs, since that might harm the animals. His goal is not to kill the PCs since that goes against everything he believes in, but his goal is to keep them away from Doomspire and wear them out.

If the group is below 50% strength on their travels, e.g. after the fight against Alizarinathrax, he will appear before them and ask them to give the Aranea Queen Egg to him. If the PCs refuse he will grow angry, with a **DC 13 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs understand this, and threat them, that one way or another he will have that egg. If it too dangerous to be in the hands of inexperienced and wet-behind-the-ears adventurers like themselves. It could fall into the wrong hands. If that isn't enough to convince them to hand over the egg, he will wildshape into an owl and fly away, very angry.

Sha'Xala follows

The half-dragon hobgoblin Sha'Xala is also after the Aranea Queen Egg. If the PCs backtrack after leaving Laz'Shadamar, e.g. visit Graevelwood or Deadsnows again, they learn quickly that someone is after them, but make sure that it is never the same person, for Sha'Xala uses a *Disguise Self* spell to change his appearance. As a master transmuter, he can also use shapechange.

If the PCs linger in one place he will discover their whereabouts and orchestrate an ambush. He will have a party of 11 hobgoblins in place along with a hobgoblin captain. He will stay invisible and use spells from a safe range, e.g. fireball. He doesn't care if her area spells also affect the hobgoblins.

If the PCs keep a good pace and move fast towards Doomspire village, Sha'Xala doesn't concerns them until after they have arrived in Doomspire.

Rewards

Award normal XP for defeated foes.

Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Beating Alizarinathrax, 500 xp
- Getting to Doomspire village, 400 xp
- Not giving Ramal the Aranea Queen Egg, 300 xp



Chapter 8: Doomspire village

Doomspire village rests high in the steep slopes of mt. Dragondoom. It once guarded the entrance to Morueme's cave, the Mouth of Morueme, where the Blood of Morueme lived. Five blue dragons, each with it's own retinue of hobgoblins and half-dragon hobgoblins, had secured the caves with all manner of traps, should anyone try to invade it. The clan was ruled by Kizilpazar, an ancient blue dragon, but he was betrayed by his sons, Nahaunglaroth and Roraurim, who are avid collectors of magical items, spellbooks and forbidden lore. The dragons don't show much interest in the day-to-day business of the village, leaving running the castle and the village to a half-dragon hobgoblin called Ardo'Uloan. Ardo titles himself as the Son of Morueme and proclaims that he is a direct ascendant of the mighty blue dragon Morueme, who once ruled the Nether mountains.

The village is a three tiered and battlements on each tier, where castle Doomspire rests on the highest tier. Ballistae, catapults and other siege weapons rest upon ramparts and each tier is surrounded by high walls and towers. Attacking Doomspire is nigh impossible task, using only ground force, even airborne force

would have a hard time due to both catapults and the fact that the village can, in need, call upon five adult blue dragons.

Doomspire has access to water via Dragondoom stream and the many slaves of the village tend to both cattle and fields. The war parties are also send regularly out on missions, where they ambush caravans, especially caravans coming across the Anauroch desert, which has caused the Zhentarim serious trouble. The Zhents use the desert routes to smuggle contraband and illegal goods from the Dalelands and the Moonsea region to the Silver Marches. Every now and then the blue dragons send few manned parties out on missions to retrieve magic items, tomes on the Art or artifacts. These parties stop at nothing to achieve their objective, since failure almost always results in death, while success can be quite rewarding.

Arriving in Doomspire

Doomspire is unlike any village in the Silver Marches. It is a village where over 500 hobgoblins



live and their many slaves who toil under the hobgoblin leaders tyranny. In many ways the village resembles military barracks, yet there are parts that could almost be mistaken for a human village.

Calling Doomspire a village is hardly right. The village is surrounded by 25 feet tall and massive stone wall, where sentries are stationed with regular interval along the palisade. The village stands on three platforms in the steep mountainside of mount Dragondoom, each tier enclosed within it's own walls and barred with heavy wooden gates. Long houses, that seem to be some form of barracks, stand in line under the walls. Hobgoblins bark out orders to the many slaves that toil in the meager fields and animal pens. The few houses that stand out are built of stone and wood and most of them look as if they're still standing only by the habit of not falling over. The air is stale and has a salty taste to it, under layers of sweat, wet, worked leather and coal smoke there's a distasteful reminder of vomit, urine and mildew. Three hobgoblin emerge from a two story building, drunk and singing a rude and all-too descriptive song about a Calimshite slave girl. Above it all looms Castle Doomspire, cold, dark and forbidden.

When describing the sights and sounds of Doomspire emphasize the crude and brutal, yet militaristic nature of the hobgoblins. This is a sadistic and evil lot, who have no qualms about brutally maim and hurt their slaves. The village bears many marks of this. While they keep order in a very efficient way, they use every opportunity to remind their slaves of their place. Some of its notable features are described hereafter:

The streets are paved with flagstones, and many of these show how the slaves are treated. It's not uncommon to see dried pools of blood, broken teeth or part of a finger.

The hobgoblins have trained worgs as mounts and they trust that the slaves clean the streets, which isn't always the case. The worgs relieve themselves where ever they please, adding to the awful stench in some areas of the village.

The village defense walls are sturdy and heavy, made of thick stone and mortar. There are towers, who are over 40 feet high and hobgoblin sentries stationed on the palisades. Siege weapons, e.g.

ballistae and catapults, are on the towers.

Hobgoblin patrols walk the streets every now and then, though the hobgoblins are not too bothered about it, if the alarm hasn't been raised. These patrols are more interested in harassing the slaves. The hobgoblins have disadvantage to the Wisdom (Perception) check.

The relationship between the five war parties are at best called strained, sometimes just openly hostile. Walking through the village this becomes very evident, as the war parties argue and bicker over which war party is the best, strongest etc.

While in Doomspire the PCs often get the feeling of being watched. Whenever they turn around or try to see who is watching them, they only spot a raven, a rat or an blackbird looking at them, before taking off. Make sure that every PC experience this at least once while in Doomspire. This is Ramal Wyrmsstone, in shapechanged form, watching the PCs and wondering what they have done with the Aranea Queen Egg.

There are many ravens in Doomspire. The hobgoblin leaders use ravens as messengers and even spies.

Getting into Doomspire

Doomspire is a fortified village and a direct approach is not necessarily the best way to get in. There is a secret entrance in the pond in the Lower Ward, but the PCs can also use other methods to get in. Reward clever thinking, e.g. if the PCs use illusions in a smart way. The guards at the gate and on the palisades are on guard, though they don't suspect invasion and are overly confident in the strength of the Blood of Morueme they are vigilant and on guard, especially against humanoid races who usually are not friendly towards hobgoblins.

Locations in Doomspire

Shown in Map 1 Doomspire is a walled three-tiered village. Wealth and power is distributed unevenly and the higher you get, more you have of either. The most powerful one live in Castle Doomspire.

More than half of the hobgoblin population lives in the many barracks. The most powerful war parties



have the best and the largest barracks, while the smallest and weakest one have the worst barracks. The slaves live in either in slums or pens, which consist of almost anything that shelters them from wind, rain, snow and sleet.

If danger approaches the walls, the sentries sound the alarm by ringing large bells. Once the bells toll the war parties quickly lay aside their quarrel and grab their weapons to man the palisades.

Feel free to add more locations, e.g. stores, granary etc. to the list of locations.

Lower Ward

The lowest tier and the largest one is called Lower Ward. Most of the hobgoblin barracks can be found here as well as the fields and cattle pens, which the slaves tend to. The Lower Ward is a busy place, enjoying only a few hours of sun each day since the Higher Ward and Castle Doomspire, not to mention mt. Dragondoom itself, cast their shadows over the ward.

In the Lower Ward you can find everything that

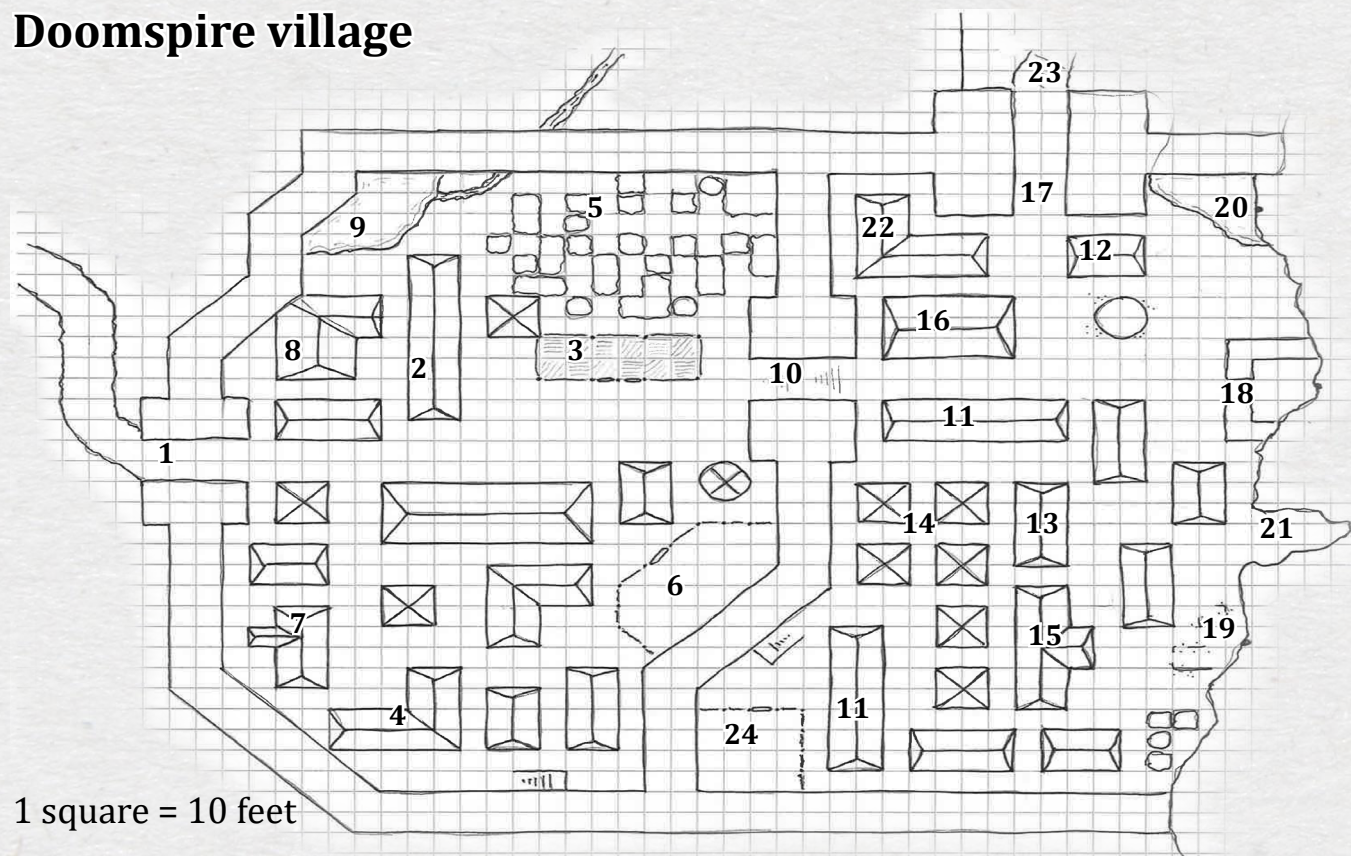
makes Doomspire a horrible place, it's a filthy, decaying venue where slaves are treated with absolutely no respect. This is where the hobgoblins enjoy themselves, either in brothels or taverns where worgs are pitted against each other, so screams of slaves being raped or tortured in any other disgusting ways blend in with hobgoblin drinking songs and worgs fighting howls.

There are shrines to Maglubiyet, Loviatar and Bane, where the hobgoblins leave their offerings, often in the form of something they have taken off their enemies, e.g. finger or ear. In the human part of the slave slum there's a well hidden shrine to Ilmater.

1. MOUTH OF TERROR

The gate to the Lower Ward is called the Mouth of Terror. The gate itself is fashioned in the shape of a giant blue dragon head. There are always **11 hobgoblins** and **1 hobgoblin captain** (see MM p.186) stationed here. The gate is usually closed with an iron rail, but the gate can also be closed, so that the dragon closes his mouth. It takes 5 rounds to fully close.

Doomspire village





2. BARRACKS

The hobgoblin war parties, Warmongers and Spearheads, have their barracks there. At any given time there are at least **30 hobgoblins** in either barrack. The barracks are run down, dirty and the houses reek of mildew, sweat and wet armor. The houses are built of stone with thatched roofs.

3. FIELDS

Slaves tend to small fields where barley and cabbage is grown. At day time there are usually 12 human and goblin slaves, watched over the **4 unarmored hobgoblins** armed with whips and clubs. The human slaves are not eager to speak to anyone, with a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs feel that their spirit has been broken. The goblins on the other hand are willing to talk, especially if they can gain anything from it. With a successful **DC 14 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs manage to convince the goblins to help them, as long as the PCs speak goblin. The goblins know that many female Aranea are held in the brothels. The goblins also believe that Shagrath, the unofficial leader of the goblins, knows more.

4. AXES 'N LILLIES

The tavern Axes 'n Lillies is run by a fat hobgoblin called Laxl. It serves bad mead and has a reputation for serving what could almost be called a stew. Laxl has two goblin slaves as chefs, so perhaps one shouldn't wonder why the cooking is not comparable to the finest inns and taverns in Waterdeep. A one eyed hobgoblin, Bash, is a regular who happens to know three tunes on a mandolin, that some poor unfortunate bard used to own. Bash plays these three tunes over and over again, every night. These are your typical hobgoblin songs about drinking and more drinking, i.e. the songs Take me down to the Waterdeep City, Welcome to Chult and Mr. Greystone, and the crowd at Axes 'n Lillies wouldn't have it any other way. Laxl knows that in Xe'Kala hid her Ioun Stone of Mind Control in the Cave of War. With a successful **DC 18 Charisma (Intimidate)** check the PCs manage to coerce Laxl to tell them about where Xe'Kala hid the Librarian's body.

5. SLAVE SLUM

The slums are mostly litter, boxes and barrels, in fact, anything that you can find and offers some refuge from the cold wind and lashing rain. The slum are under one of the village walls, and some slaves have even managed to build a ramshackle of sorts, though they look as if they wouldn't last through a windy night. The stench is awful there, especially around the goblin part. Even the orc slaves find the goblins less than arguable and only the most unfortunate slaves have to find room near the goblin quarter.

Most of the orcs are uncivilized and seem to have come in terms with their lot in life, after all their inborn respect for strength tells them that it's their role to follow the strongest one around and at the moment that are the hobgoblins. Their leader is Gorack, a large brute with broken tusks. Gorack doesn't speak common very well and it is easy to believe him to be stupid, but he is actually quite smart (Int 13). He fears for his lover, Ragor, who the hobgoblin took away a few days ago. Gorack has been asking around, but has until now only learned that Ragor was taken to the Cave of Pain. If the PCs could rescue him Gorack would be willing to do anything for the PCs.

The humans are mostly unfortunate caravan people, whose spirit has been broken, some have even been years as slaves in Doomspire. A elderly woman from Daggerdale, Helga, is their leader and she is not keen on revolting, knowing that it can bring terrible pain and misery down upon the slaves. She knows that the Aranea male are held captive in the Cave of Suffering (see above), since they have become more irritated and unruly.

The goblins are lead by a despicable goblin called Shagrath. Shagrath actually likes Doomspire. He has secured himself a good position and he sees the slums sort of as his fiefdom. He can help the PCs to get into the Higher Ward, but it comes at a price. If the PCs come before him armed with magical weapons he asks for one of these. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs feel that Shagrath is a very greedy and shady fellow, and not to be so easily trusted. Striking any sort of bargain where he doesn't stand to gain anything personally is due to fail. A bargain that would ensure him his freedom



is also not likely to succeed, with a **DC 22 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs manage to convince him. A get-rich-quick on the other hand is something likely to work, with a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs manage to convince Shagrath to help them. Shagrath also knows about the Medusa in the Cave of Pain, if the PCs try to trick him (he has +8 to Insight) he will tell them that what they seek is in the Cave of War (he has +10 to Deception).

6. BULL PEN

The hobgoblins raise cattle to feed the war parties. Slaves take care of the cattle. During daylight hours there are usually 8-10 slaves tending to the cattle, overlooked by 4 hobgoblins (see area 3). The bulls are hungry and easy to agitate, with a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Animal Handling)** check the PCs make the bulls made enough to crash through the pen and make some serious trouble in the Lower Ward.

7. PARADISE

Paradise is anything but. It's a brothel run by Madame Wexal Lily, a sadistic androgyn hobgoblin and a devout follower of Loviatar, the house appears to be one story stone house, but there are many rooms in the cellar who are specially outfitted to serve any desire the clientele might have. Paradise popular among the Warmongers and Spearheads, since it is cheap and offers everything a depraved mind could want. Among the brothel's slaves are eight female aranea. Their leader is Ri'Uala, who usually appears as an elderly Illuskan woman. She knows that there are more female aranea in the brothels in Higher Ward, and that there are a few that have been taken to Castle Doomspire, never to be seen again. Ri'Uala doesn't know who is fit to lead the Aranea. Ri'Uala's sister, Gar'Relatha, is also among the aranea in Paradise, but she has been feeling ill lately and has suffered heavily for it, since Wexal doesn't abide any of her slaves a rest.

8. THE TORN BANNER

The only inn in Doomspire is reserved for those very few travellers who come to the village. The inn

stands not far from the Mouth of Terror in a three story stone house with barred windows. Usually the clientele is mostly hobgoblins, though every now and then envoys from the orc tribes in the North, bounty hunters and artifact seekers employed by the blue dragons stay overnight there. The Torn Banner is the closest thing to comfort in the Lower Ward, the inn's common room has wooden furniture and the food there is not that bad, mostly because it is cooked by the halfling Yordar, who is a Harper spy. The hobgoblin Barazh, who runs the inn, was charmed by Yordar and believes Yordar to be his slave.

If there are any Harpers among the PCs they could get help from Yordar. There is a small Harper rune on the doorpost of the inn, with a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs see it. Yordar knows that the male Aranea were taken to the Cave of Suffering four days ago, because they were acting crazy and unruly. He also knows that any slave taken to the Castle is as good as dead.

With a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs can get more information from Yordar. He tells them that the dragons are hoarding knowledge, especially about Netheril. They hold a creature the hobgoblins call the Librarian hostage, to guard the library. Yordar doesn't know what kind of creature it is, but he has heard that it desires nothing more than to be set free and avenge itself on the hobgoblins who enslaved it. He suggests that perhaps the PCs could find more evidence about the Librarian in the Cave of Secrets under the Broken Tower.

9. POND

The water in the pond is a lot cleaner than one would expect. The Doomspire creek is a clear mountain creek, that cascades down the steep slope ending in the pond. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs find out that the pond is actually artificial, the creek is dammed by the wall. A successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation or Stonecunning)** check leads the PCs to suspect that there is a way for the water to flow out. In fact the water flows out into a large cave under the Lower Ward. The cave is accessible through a crevice far



below the village. The water flows through 10 feet wide and 5 feet high tunnel 60 feet before dropping over 100 feet down into the cave. Using this way to escape the Lower Ward is very dangerous, that high a drop can easily kill even the sturdiest people. But a determined person could climb the cave with a successful **DC 12 Strength (Athletics)** check and swim upwards with a successful **DC 18 Strength (Athletics)** check.

Higher Ward

The Higher Ward is more agreeable than Lower Ward but barely so. Though there aren't as many slaves around, the hobgoblins here are better armed and more vigilant (add +2 to their Passive Perception).

The sounds of the Higher Ward are a bit different than in the Lower Ward, for there are blacksmiths and weapon makers, tanners and armorers constantly at work during daylight hours, covering the ward in soot and with a heavy stench from the tanneries. The two war parties that live in the Barracks are more disciplined and every day at noon there are marching and phalanx fighting practices.

The houses in the Higher Ward are in better shape than in the Lower ward, but only marginally. At least they don't seem to be about to fall over. The houses are built on stone foundation but the higher stories are made of plaster and wood.

10. MOUTH OF MADNESS

The gate to the Higher Ward is carved to resemble a goblin skull with three eye sockets, where fires are constantly kept lit. No one knows why it was made this way, though with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Religion)** check the PCs can see a reference to Maglubiyet in the burning eyes. The gate itself is merely 10 feet wide and 30 feet long, with many slits for crossbowmen and bowmen, making it an ideal defence position. The hobgoblins often say that it would be pure madness to invade the Higher Ward through the gate.

11. BARRACKS

The barracks in the Higher Ward are in much better

shape than the ones in the Lower Ward, though the houses look much the same. The hobgoblins also make sure that they have enough room to practice and that there's no refuse or litter anywhere near the barracks. The war parties Cragmouths and Skinners make their home in the barracks.

12. BROKEN TOWER

The Broken Tower was once the home of the half-dragon hobgoblin Aruth-Kala, a powerful sorcerer and leader of the Blood of Morueme for a few years. He became too powerful and arrogant until Roraurim decided to kill the sorcerer. In the ensuing battle between the pair the dragon bombarded the tower with spells and lighting bolts, until the top three levels crumbled. Now there's not much left of it, only the first floor and the cellar. But in the cellar there's the entrance to the Cave of Secrets.

13. THUNDERROAR

The tavern Thunderroar is run by Eangeus the Old, a white haired goblin who has lost most of his teeth. In his youth he travelled all over the Heartlands, as a part of a mercenary hobgoblin party called the Dingos. He served both as a cook and a standard bearer, but earned his reputation for writing a lengthy rhyme about the ventures of the party, a rhyme called Highway to Thay. Thunderroar is a warm, almost unbelievably cozy place, with large, round tables and a roaring fire in a great fireplace. The food is good and the ale decent, and therefore Thunderroar is frequented by the elite of Doomspire.

14. SMITHIES AND TANNERIES

All smithies and tanneries stand in line not far from the Mouth of Horror, the gate to Castle Doomspire. The air is constantly filled with the sounds of hammers hitting metal, the smell from the tanneries and the shouts of the smiths and tanners, shouting commands to their many slaves. All sorts of large, cruel-looking weapons and sturdy armors. Hobgoblins of all war parties make their way to the smithies to have their weapons fixed or replaced. Mostly human and orc slaves toil in the smithies and tanneries.



15. HOUSE OF PLEASURE

The brothel in Higher Ward is run by Brimgor, a small, one-armed half-dragon hobgoblin. Brimgor was born with disabilities, his left arm never grew as it should and his wings never fully developed. He was soon rejected by the dragons but managed to eak out a meager living making all manner of deals and dealings with the people of Doomspire. Brimgor knows almost all in Doomspire, especially the hobgoblins, though he keeps an eye out too for the slaves. He is smart (Int 16) and willing to sell almost any information for the right price, with a successful **DC 16 Charisma (Persuasion)** the PCs manage to talk him into selling them information. Brimgor knows that Goran is a werewolf, since he had to clean up after he had shapechanged and torn one aranea apart. Just as he has absolutely no qualms about making money from his brothel, which houses 18 araneas, of all genders, 3 female humans, 4 half orcs and an elf called Jonheidal, which is considered a delicacy and the House's most valuable asset.

16. TEMPLE OF WAR

The temple of Maglubiyet is a horrifying structure. The front is adorned with eight pillars, where skulls have been piled along. Under an arched roof is a large chamber and an obsidian altar in the middle, where sacrifices are made at sunset, more frequently when the tribe is about to go to war. The high priest is Argur the Bloody-Handed, a large hobgoblin who most people in Doomspire fear and hate. Argur is ill tempered and hates every day that the war parties spend behind the walls and he is not shy in letting the leader hear his opinion.

17. MOUTH OF HORROR

The gate to the Castle Ward is not large, only 10 feet wide and 10 feet tall. The portcullis is usually down and **12 hobgoblin** guards stand on the other side, both by the portcullis and on the castle walls, armed with crossbows and longspears. The walls are 25 feet and 30 feet wide, made of smooth rock. With a successful **DC 22 Strength (Athletics)** the PCs manage to climb the wall.

18. CAVE OF SUFFERING

See below.

19. CAVE OF TYRANNY

See below.

20. CAVE OF PAIN

See below.

21. CAVE OF WAR

See below.

22. WARLORD ARDO'ULOAN MANSION

Ardo lives in a large building with many guards of the Chosen of Morueme war party. The building is nothing less than a small fortress within the village and he guards it heavily. He runs the village and can often be seen moving from the Mouth of Terror to the Mouth of Madness, never with fewer than **8 heavily armed hobgoblin** guards. The building is made of stone, with a heavy and sturdy portcullis, with a successful **DC 25 Strength check** the PCs can lift it. The interior, though spartan, is expensive and Ardo has a small treasure cove where he has stored away whatever treasure he believes he has managed to keep away from the Morueme dragons. Ardo has Xe'Kala's diary and knows how she played Argur.

Please note, there is no map provided for the mansion, feel free to add one.

23. CASTLE DOOMSPIRE

The Castle is off limits to anyone except the war party leaders and the Chosen of Morueme, who venture very seldom outside the castle these days. The Castle is not detailed in this module, feel free to describe and include it if your players seek to explore it.

24. WORG PEN

The Skinners love to ride massive worgs to battle and cause as much mayhem as possible. The worgs are kept in a pen and looked over by the Skinners, there are always **three hobgoblins** by the pen, tending to the worgs. Their worgs are well trained



as mounts, though their nature and hunger for blood is always there. With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Animal handling)** check the PCs make the Worgs angry enough to attack each other and anyone close enough, causing a huge turmoil and problems for the Skinners.

The Five Caves

There are five cave systems in the Higher Ward, each of the war parties are responsible for guarding one cave system. These caves serve both as lairs for the blue dragons of Morueme and as a place where the hobgoblin war parties can do whatever they need to do in private.

CAVE FEATURES

Unless otherwise noted the caves all share the same features. The caves are well built and the corridors wide. With a successful **DC 15 Stonecunning** check a dwarven PC quickly spots that the caves were built by non-dwarves and judging by the lack of support beams magic was probably used.

FLOORS AND WALLS

The floors and walls are worked and even. In some places the walls are rough and coarse, obviously hewn by someone not used to mining.

DOORS

All doors are sturdy and made of wood. Unless otherwise noted all doors are locked. The doors can be open with a successful **DC 18 Dexterity** check, using thieves tools. With a successful **DC 25 Strength** check the doors can be kicked or pried open.

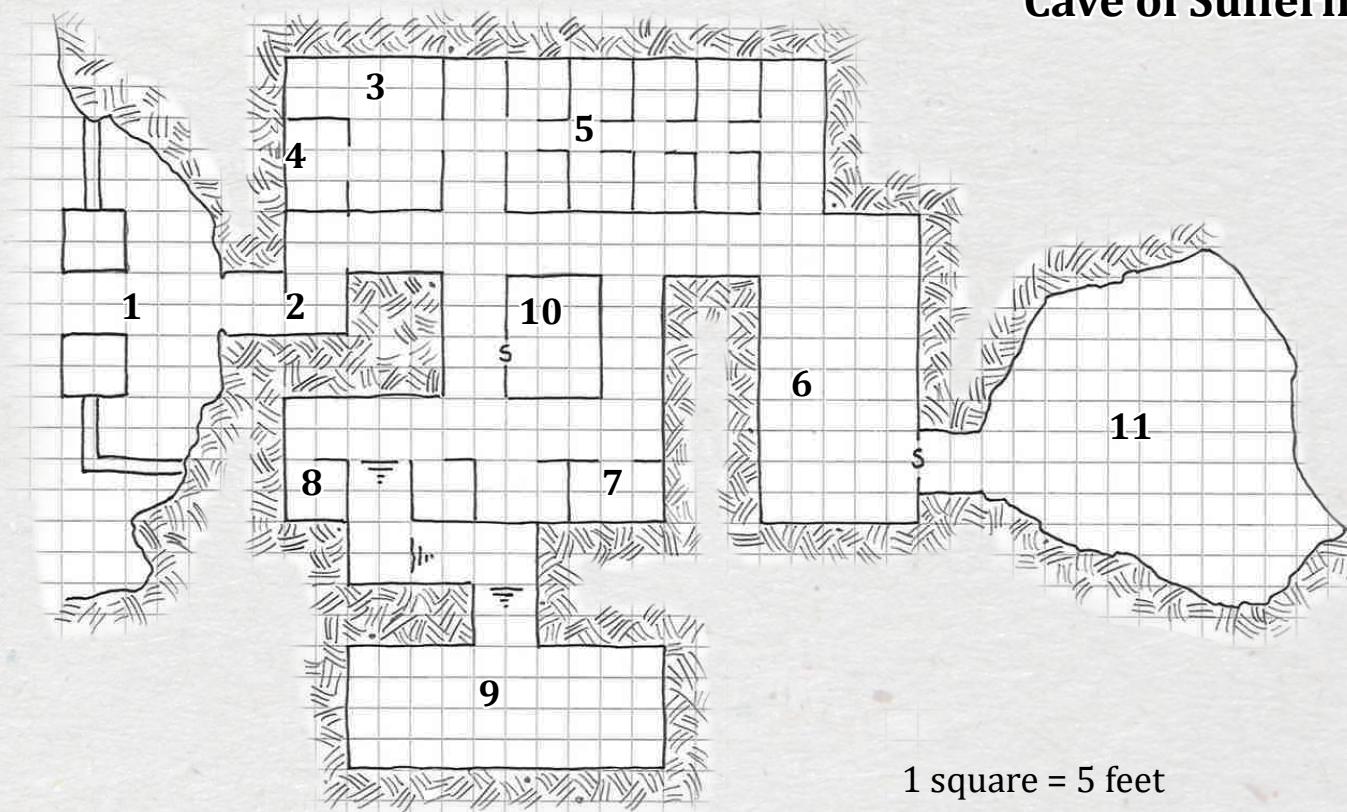
VISIBILITY AND LIGHT

All hallways are lit with braziers and sconces for torches are on the walls.

Cave of Suffering

The Cave of Suffering is used by the Blood of Morueme to discipline the slaves. It has many rooms in which the slaves spirit is broken. Screams of pain

Cave of Suffering





and terror echo through the cave every now and then. The young blue dragon Jor-Kalaz makes her lair in this cave. The Cragmouths are responsible for the Cave of Suffering.

The Cave of Suffering is hidden behind a 20' high wall and two stone towers, where 8 hobgoblins from the Cragmouths war party are on watch. In front of the wall Horag and the half-orc slaves (see below) have made their home in boxes and anything that they have managed to gather to build shelters.

1. GATE

The Cragmouths have erected a wooden wall and two stone towers to guard the Cave of Suffering. There are always **8 hobgoblins** on watch and they allow no one to enter the cave not in company of someone from the Cragmouths. If the village is attacked the guards close an iron gate and bolt it. With a successful **DC 28 Strength** check the PCs manage to break through the gate.

2. ENTRANCE

The entrance to the cave is designed to stall invaders and give defenders time to muster their defence. If the village comes under an attack the guards from the gate fall back into the cave and take up defensive position. If the attackers break through the defenders can, by turning a lever, make the cave entrance fall in.

3. GUARD ROOM

The guards have a room where they can sleep and eat. At any give time there are **4 hobgoblins** there, either sleeping or playing dice. They have disadvantage to their Wisdom (Perception) checks to spot anyone sneak up on them. There are six beds in the room and a large round table. With a successful **DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot a hidden compartment under one of the bed, where 2 bloodstones, worth 60 gps, have been stored.

4. CAPTAIN ROOM

In the guard room is a small room intended for the squad captain. There's a bed and a desk in the room.

In the desk there's a pouch containing 3 gps and 47 sps. There's a 50% chance at any given time that the **hobgoblin captain** is there. If the captain is there and there's commotion in the guard room, e.g. the loud sounds of battle, the captain will rush into the guard room.

5. HOLDING CELL

Iron portculli close the holding cells, which all include the male Aranea in human form. The cells are locked, with a successful **DC 19 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to open the locks. The Aranea will point to an old Illuskan male, Gor-Ali, if the PCs ask any questions. Gor-Ali will not lead the Aranea away if the four Aranea, Ero-Lah, Tor-Mar, Hel-Gi and Hial-Tee, that were just an hour ago taken to Jor-Kalaz's lair haven't been freed.

You enter a hallway where four portculli are on either wall. Looking through them reveals all kinds of different humans, all males, in rags and tattered clothing; Chultans, Imaskaris, Calimshites. Each look at you in fear. The cells are overcrowded and obviously some of the men are injured or ill.

With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Medicine)** check the PCs see that just over half of the men in the cells are fit enough to leave. Even with their help and healing magic only 24 of the 40 Aranea men there are in good enough shape to leave the cells and make the journey to Arn forest.

6. JOR-KALAZ'S THRONE ROOM

Jor-Kalaz makes the Cragmouths pay homage to him, for he likes to see the cower in fear before him. He calls Goran and the captains before him once a week to remind them that he is of the Morueme and that they are his to command. The throne room is large, yet spartan. There's no memorophilia on the walls, no throne and nothing fancy.

There's a secret door in the far end, with a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the small lever that makes the hidden door open. A short hallway leads to Jor-Kalaz's lair.

7. TORTURE ROOMS

These rooms contain all manner of torture



instruments, e.g. whips, iron maiden, manacles etc. Dried blood splatters the walls and the floors, even the ceiling. The rooms have an aura of evil over them.

8. INTERROGATION CHAMBERS

These rooms contain chairs with leather straps, which are used to interrogate prisoners.

9. MAGLUBIYET'S TEMPLE

A large room with octagon pillars lining the walls. In one end there's a large altar and on the wall behind it a large mural of a hobgoblin with fire in its eyes. The temple is devoted to Maglubiyet, though a careful inspection will reveal that it hasn't been used much recently. With a successful **DC 13 Intelligence (Religion)** check the PCs will recognize the mural as Maglubiyet. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs will notice that dust has settled on the altar and the blood in the sacrificial bowls is dried and caked.

10. GORAN'S CHAMBER

With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the secret door leading Goran's chamber. The door is carefully locked. With a successful **DC 19 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs find the unlocking mechanism. With a successful **DC 17 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to unlock the mechanism and open the door.

The room beyond the secret door is spartan. No furniture of any sort, no books or weapons. Only a set of manacle, that hang from the opposite wall.

With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs notice coarse hair stuck in the manacle and pieces of torn colourful elven silk. A PC trained in **Intelligence (Nature)** will recognise the hair as lupine, with a successful **DC 15** check. Goran uses this chamber when he feels the moon's call, he chains himself to the wall and makes sure that he doesn't shapechange in front of his underlings.

11. JOR KALAZ'S LAIR

The short corridor leading to the lair is trapped with a **spiked pit** with iron spikes (see map), see DMG

p. 123. When the trap door opens it also hits a large gong, alerting Jor Kalaz of any intruders.

You enter a large cavern of unworked stone. In the other end it opens to reveal a beautiful scene of snowcapped mountains and pristine alpine woods. You take in the scenery for just a moment, before the large and annoyed blue dragon catches your eye. Behind it lie four tied and motionless humanoids, by four large chests and a few barrels.

Jor-Kalaz (**Young Blue Dragon**, see MM p. 91) attacks. It will start with its breath weapon, followed by melee attacks, waiting for the breath weapon to recharge. If Jor-Kalaz is down to 25% health, it will try to flee the scene and alert the rest of the Morueme. If it manages to escape, in three hours the village is on high alert.

The chests and barrels contain 3800 cp, 600 sp and 320 gp. The barrels contain 6 50 gp gems, 4 30 gp gems and a crown worth 800 gps. Along these are potion of resistance, potion of greater healing and potion of flying, scroll containing *Fire bolt*, *Light* and *Detect Magic*, Adamantine chain shirt and *Longsword* +1.

The four humanoids are Ero-Lah, Tor-Mar, Hel-Gi and Hial-Tee, the aranea that Gor-Ali said had been taken away. Award the PCs Inspiration if they manage to save the four Aranea.

Cave of Secrets

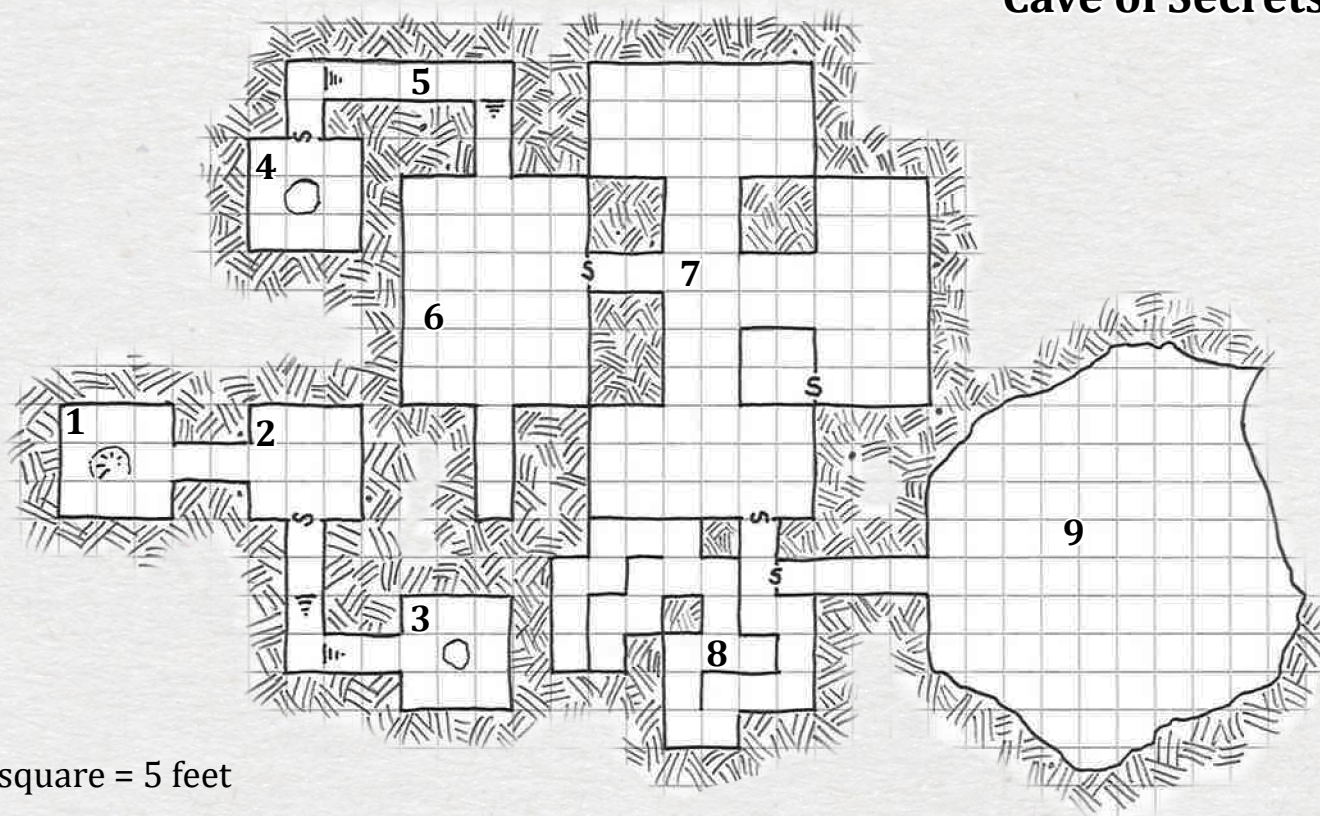
The entrance to the cave of secrets is under the Broken tower. The Cave of Secrets should be guarded by the Chosen of Morueme, but the war party is not concerned with that duty at the moment, being preoccupied with guarding the castle. Xe'Kala also firmly believes that all traps, wards and the many secret doors will keep the war party's cave safe.

1. ENTRY ROOM

A iron-wrought round stair leads over 70' feet down. The entry room is decorated with tapestries, depicting the history of the Morueme. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (History)** the PCs can see where the Blood of Morueme attacks the Laz'Shadamar and the gruesome battle in the underground city. Older tapestries also show how the Morueme slaughtered



Cave of Secrets



1 square = 5 feet

the hobgoblins of Doomspire after discovering that the hobgoblins killed one of the blue dragons.

2. FAKE WORSHIP ROOM

A large bas-relief of a blue dragon wyrm covers the wall opposite the hallway. Two large brass candlesticks stand in each corner. With a successful **DC 19 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs notice that a faint trail leads to the west wall. The door is magically locked. Using a *Knock* spell can open the door. Picking the lock requires a successful **DC 25 Dexterity** check. The hall beyond the door leads still lower into the ground, on the stair platform is a *Glyph of Warding* (**Dexterity save DC 15**, 5d8 lightning damage). Spotting the Glyph requires a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation check)**.

3. TELEPORT ROOM

Dominating the center of this room is a large, magical circle. A detect magic spell will reveal that the circle radiates strong conjuration magic. This is a permanent Teleport circle. To activate it you need to say: Morueme kurila. With a successful **DC 16**

Intelligence (Arcana) check a PC proficient in the skill and with the help of an *Identify* spell can decipher the runes and discover the activation words. Without the *Identify* spell raise the DC by 5.

4. TRAPPED TELEPORT ROOM

This 15'x15' room is empty save for the teleport circle, where the PCs appear. The floor is trapped with magical glyphs. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** the PCs spot the glyphs. If a PC steps off the teleport circle the trap activates, hitting them with a *Hold Person* spell (**Wisdom Save DC 15** or be held for 1 minute). As soon as the first PC enters the room a hobgoblin guard **ghost** (see MM p. 147) takes form and attacks. The glyph resets in one minute. On the east wall is a secret door, with a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the faint outlines of a door. The door is locked with a mechanical lock, which is connected to a mechanism in the hallway beyond. If the lock is not opened with the right key, which is on Xe'Kala's keychain, the mechanism will activate. With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to unlock the



lock. With a **DC 22 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to disable the mechanism. If the PCs don't manage to disable the mechanism, with a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs hear mechanical grinding from beyond the door.

Going back requires the PCs to repeat the phrase.

5. ILLUSIONARY HALLWAY

The mechanism removes the floor from the hallway beyond the stair after the hallway turns north. *Hallucinatory Terrain* spell activates and makes the hallway seem just as before. Stepping on the illusory floor reveals the truth. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the difference. If a PC steps on the floor, with a successful **DC 15 Dexterity** save the PC manages to avoid falling 80 feet down. The hole is 20 feet long.

6. HALL OF ENLIGHTENMENT

You enter a large hall. The walls are lined with tapestries and paintings, showing blue dragons of the Morueme govern over the Doomspire and the neighbouring valleys, fighting bronze dragons of the Anauroch desert and tearing through hordes of orcs of the Many-Arrows clan. A iron-clad door is on the wall beyond. A horrid stench of rotting flesh fill the hall.

A **flesh golem** attacks. The flesh golem is assembled from hobgoblin, human and goblin parts, making it even more horrifying than usual, created to guard these quarters.

The door on the east wall is unlocked. The floor on the other side is trapped. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the glyph. If a PC steps on the glyph, with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom** save the PCs manage to shake off the curse. The glyph has a *Bestow curse* which makes necromantic spells more potent.

At the other end of the hall is another iron-clad door, but this one is an illusion, hiding another *Glyph of Warding*, this one containing the spell *Vampiric touch*. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs see through the illusion.

The door on the north wall is hidden by a tapestry. The door is also iron-clad and locked, but not

trapped. With a successful **DC 18 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to unlock the door.

7. RORAUIM'S SPELLTRAINING ROOMS

The blue dragon wyrm Roraurim uses these three rooms to train the Chosen of Morueme as spellcasters. The rooms are littered with bones, stones and all kind of debris after powerful spell-explosions, the air smells of sulphur and is thick with magic. In the north room is a magically locked secret door. With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs spot the cleverly hidden stone door. A *Knock* spell opens the lock. The door rotates on a simple axis, revealing a small room beyond. In there the PCs spot an elderly human, seemingly in a catatonic state. This man is known as the Librarian and his soul is trapped in the Beholder body in the Cave of War. The beholder's soul is trapped in a clay jar, that the Librarian is holding in his hands.

The easternmost room is another secret door, also magically locked. A *Knock* spell will open it.

8. MAZE

Beyond the secret door is a narrow corridor, covered in permanent magical darkness. A **black pudding** (see MM p. 241) prowls these corridors, waiting to drop on a hapless adventurer. A secret opening, no wider than a keyhole, leads north to Roraurim's lair. The dragon uses gaseous form to move through the hidden hole. Finding the small hole requires a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation)** check.

9. RORAUIM'S LAIR

The **Ancient blue dragon** Roraurim is not often in his lair, since he prefers spending his time either in the castle or soaring above the Nether Mountains and the Anauroch desert. The lair contains a part of his treasure hoard, 5600 gp's in gems and artwork, black dragon scale mail, *Staff of thunder and lightning*, *Ring of protection* +2 and a *Dancing sword*. There is 20% chance that Roraurim is in it's lair.

Cave of Tyranny

The Cave of Tyranny is the smallest of the five



caves and has fallen in disrepair. The Warmongers show little interest in maintaining it since they were demoted and it is no longer lit like the other caves, there's total darkness all locations except 1 and 2. All doors are open and unlocked. The Warmongers do selcom come there and the other hobgoblin war parties stay away.

Few weeks ago Kath Rual, an **oni**, found Doomspire and took up residence in the cave. Since then the giant has been terrorizing the slaves in the slum, especially the human slaves. The other hobgoblin war parties won't go any nearer than the ruined houses, since the word on the street is that something evil lurks there.

1. RUINED HOUSES

These used to house guards from the Warmongers war party. The houses have fallen into ruins and the other war parties have used them as training grounds.

2. ENTRANCE

The cave opening is narrow and with a successful

DC 17 Wisdom (Perception) check the PCs notice holes on the walls, wide enough for crossbow bolts to pass through.

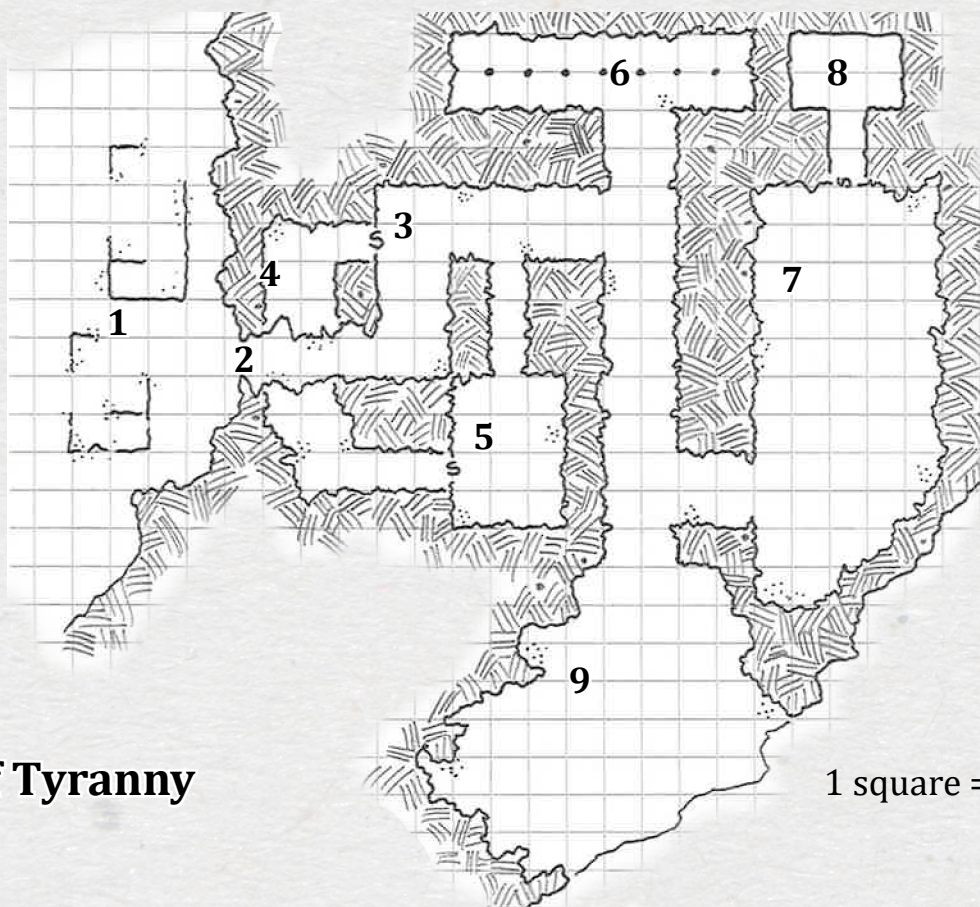
3. HALLWAY

The hallways are littered with debris and garbage. A perspective PC might notice that someone or something has probably lived there for some time, with a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check. A small brown homemade doll lies in one corner, the doll is torn. With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Investigate)** the PCs spot the secret door. It is unlocked and leads to location 4.

4. GUARD ROOM

The Warmonger guards used this room to watch the entrance. There are openings in which they can see through and fire their crossbows. Three broken crossbows and 40 bolts lie neatly stacked in one corner, ready to use.

5. ARSENAL



Cave of Tyranny

1 square = 5 feet



The Warmongers had a sizable arsenal stored here in case of an emergency. There are still troves of weapons and armour here, though most if it is used. There are no magical weapons here. With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the secret door, which leads to a room identical to location 4.

6. HALL OF TYRANTS

This long hall has many stone sarcophaguses sett in the walls. These are former leaders of the Warmongers. Each of them was buried with their weapons, but the sarcophaguses have been pried open and looted.

Seven octagonal pillars hold up a vaulted ceiling in this long hall. A heavy rotten stench fills the air. The walls are lined with carved and decorated sarcophaguses, who have all been smashed and opened.

With a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Religion)** the PCs know that the many of the hieroglyphs relate to the deity Bane.

7. TEMPLE OF BANE

The Warmongers built the temple many years ago, despite the fact that all the other war parties opposed to it and the most of the Morueme as well.

You enter a large hall. An altar, bearing the symbol of the Black Hand inlaid with black sapphires, stands in the middle of the temple. Above it is a tattered black tapestry depicting Bane with red burning eyes as a fighter towering over hundreds of cowering humans. In the far corner a blond girl stands, holding her brown teddy bear, seemingly very afraid.

The girl is in fact Kath Rual (see MM p. 239), who has shapechanged. If the PCs approach him he will use *Charm person* to get the acting PC to believe him. Kath will try to lure as many of the PCs closer, before using his *Cone of Cold* spell. If the PCs found the teddy bear in area 3, they will see it is identical to the one Kath is holding. If the PCs manage to get Kath's HPs below 40% he will use *Darkness* and *Invisibility* to try to escape.

The secret door in the temple is well hidden and not easy to spot. Kath Rual found it and decided to do his

best to hide it even better. With a **DC 20 Intelligence (Investigate)** check the PCs spot the secret door. It isn't locked.

8. HIGH TYRANT'S QUARTERS

The secret door in the Temple of Bane leads to the High Cleric's room, which Kath Rual has made his. There the PCs will see Silvia, inside a small locked wooden box. With a **DC 18 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to unlock the lock and let Silvia out. She is terrified, with a **DC 12 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs feel that she has suffered from a nervous breakdown and needs her parents above all else. Good aligned PCs who make it their priority to get her back home receive Insight.

There's another box there, a little larger than the one the held Silvia, but Aron is nowhere to be seen. A blue ragged shirt is in one corner of the room, blood all over it. Kath has already murdered Aron and eaten him. Helga can help the PCs let his father know, who thanks the PCs, though he is utterly heartbroken.

Kath gathered the weapons from the Hall of Tyrants into this room. By his bedroll are a *Shortsword +2*, *Shield of Missile Attractions* and *Rod of Rulership*. In a heap in one corner are a fine crafted spear, a longsword and a flail.

9. NARZELAHAZ'S LAIR

The **young blue dragon** Narzelahaz used to lair in the cave, but when the Warmongers fell into disgrace he abandoned the Cave of Tyranny, leaving nothing behind. The opening however offers a great view of the Far Forest.

Cave of Pain

The Skinners guard the Cave of Pain vigorously. They don't allow any member of the other war parties to enter the cave and only the highest members, the knights and captains, and other members of the sadistic cult of Loviatar. Artual, a medusa and the mother of the Skinners' leader, commands the cult. She is not only evil and dangerous, but also a devoted Loviatan and referred to as Pain Artual.

Once every 12 day the cult gathers and go through



all kinds of rituals. Slaves and prisoners are brought to the temple, to be flayed and tortured. The cult also believes in self-inflicted pain and therefore many members wear cilices around their thighs.

The whole Cave of Pain is devoted to Loviatar and should reflect that in as many ways as possible. Screams of pain, whiplashes and tapestries showing tortures and torture victims are all encompassing. Feel free to add to the horror of this place.

1. ENTRANCE

Reaching the Cave of Pain the PCs need to wade through freezing cold water, which is thigh deep for a medium sized creature. Using Dexterity-based skills while in the water is with a disadvantage. There are six hobgoblins in the entrance, who are on guard. They will alarm the other hobgoblins in the cave if they get the chance, by running towards the secret door.

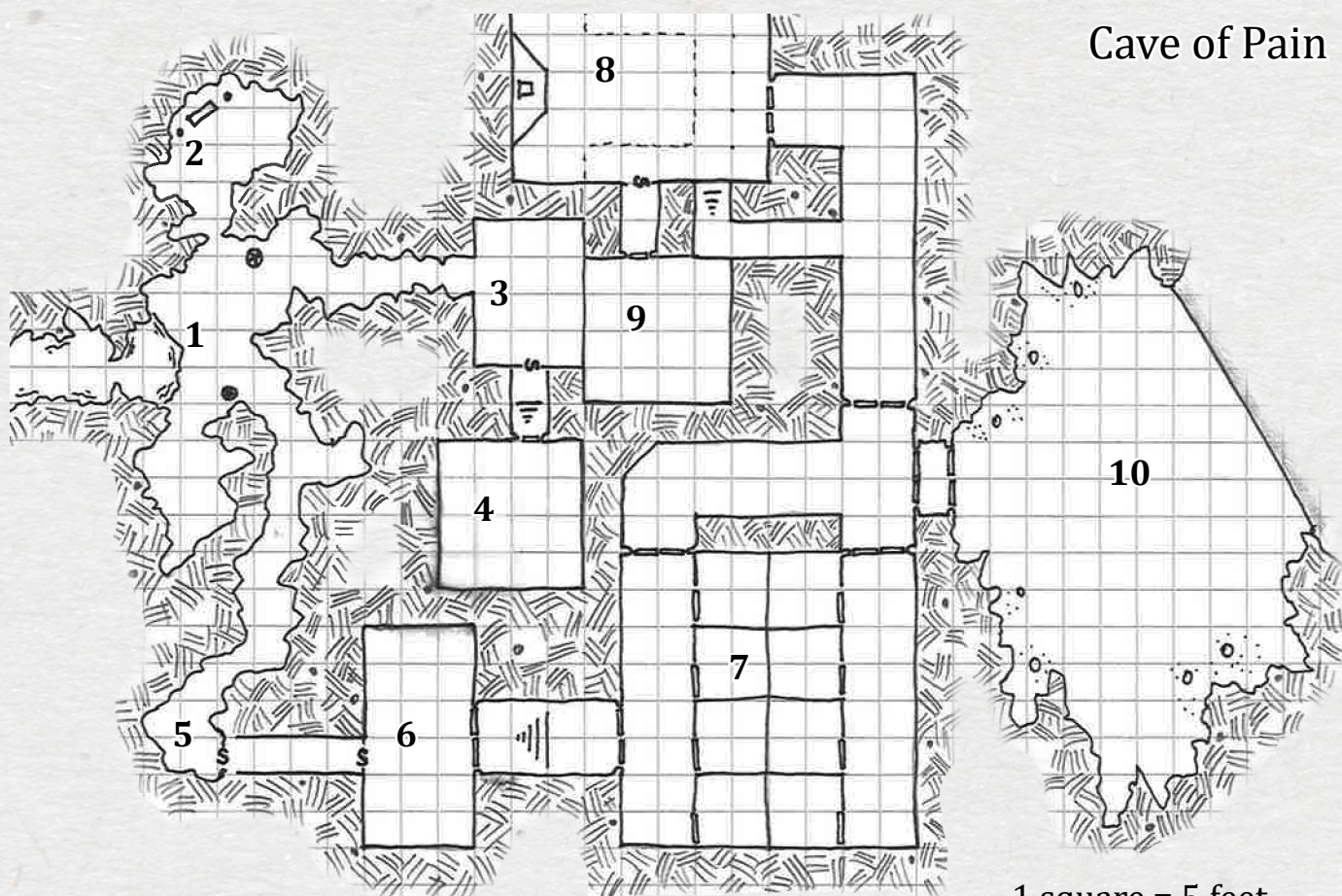
In the entrance are two incredible lifelike statues of hobgoblin warriors, one male, the other female,

both naked from waist up and seemingly in much pain. They were victims of Pain Artual. The walls are rough and natural, the floor is covered with gravel. Torches hang in sconces, illuminating the area in dim light. Moving silently in the gravel is done at a disadvantage.

If the guards manage to alert the cult members they will come to the guards aid in 8 rounds. Artual will arrive after 15 rounds, in hope of more victims for the Maiden of Pain.

2. LOVIATAR SHRINE

In this room is a shrine devoted to Loviatar, the shrine consists of a large stone slab and a nine stranded whip with barbs. With a **DC 12 Intelligence (Religion)** check the PCs recognize the altar. The most devoted cult members come here everyday to pray and go through rituals of pain and cleansing. Two large black candles stand in iron candlesticks on either side of the altar. It is customary for the Loviatans to light the candles and hold their hands



Cave of Pain

1 square = 5 feet



over the flames while they recite Loviatan tenets and pray.

3. GUARD ROOM

The Skinner guards have their own room, where they can rest and eat while on cave duty. The room is tidy and orderly and has no valuables, other than few rations of food. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the secret door. It is locked and only Aruma has the key. The lock is also trapped, with a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the trap. It is a simple **poison needle trap** (see DMG p. 123), but it is poisoned with **Wyvern Poison** (see DMG p. 257). Once the trap has been disabled, with a successful **DC 17 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to open the door.

4. ARUMA'S SANCTUARY

The Skinners' leader has her own room where she can pray to Loviatar and discuss matters with her captains. There is 10% chance that she is in there at any given time. The room contains a bed, desk and small shrine devoted to Loviatar. The shrine contains a *Nine-stranded whip* +1. The desk contains few documents and a map showing the Nether mountains and Anauroch, along with the known trade routes.

5. SECRET DOORS AND HALLWAY

With a **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the secret door at the end of the corridor. It is locked in the same way as the door to Aruma's sanctuary (see above). The hallway beyond is short, but the walls are lined with colored murals depicting humans on a torture racket, being whipped by female hobgoblins with nine-stranded whips. At the end of the hallway is another secret door, with a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Investigation)** the PCs find the door, which is locked. With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to unlock the door.

6. HALL OF AGONY

You enter a large room. The walls hold tapestries which depict horrible scenes of torture, naked humans being burnt alive, flagellant elves and

dismembered dwarves. On the floor is dried blood.

If the alarm hasn't been sounded:

Two despicable creatures watch you, a bit surprised. Their red eyes shine with malice and the thorns on their body bristle. They lick their lips and summon fire in their hands.

With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana)** check a proficient PC recognizes these creatures as **Barbed Devils** (see MM p. 68). The devils were summoned from Banehold by Artual to watch over the cult members as they go through the Rite of Agony, before going further into the Cave of Pain.

When the devils see that the PCs aren't a part of the cult they attack and fight to the death.

7. CHAMBERS OF TORTURE

These chambers are used to torture prisoners and are used by cult members to show their faith and vent their sadistic behaviour. These chamber are identical. There are manacles on the wall and number of torture tools hang of the walls, e.g. whips, hammers and flails. The floors are littered and it's easy to see dried blood there, a foul stench hangs in the air, of vomit, feces and urine. A PC inspecting these chambers must make a **DC 15 Constitution** save or feel nauseated for 1d4 hours. Ragor is in one of these chambers.

8. TEMPLE OF PAIN AND SUFFERING

A large stone altar stands on a raised dais, a massive bas relief showing a nine-tail barbed whip has been edged into the face of the stone. There are a number of wooden poles holding up a balcony overlooking the temple. Bloody manacles are on every pole.

With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Religion)** check the PCs know that this is a temple consecrated in honour of the Maiden of Pain.

There is a 50% at any given time that **Artual** is in the temple with 3 **hobgoblin** acolytes armed with flails. She will order the acolytes to attack and use her gaze attack on the most dangerous looking warrior type. The Acolytes will fight to the death. If Artual falls below 30% hps she will try to escape into her harem.

If Artual isn't there, the acolytes are memorizing



the rites of pain and agony, praying or going through self-torture routine. They will attack and make as much noise as they possibly can, hoping to alert Artual.

With a successful **DC 16 Intelligence (Investigation)** the PCs discover the secret door leading to Artual's harem.

9. ARTUAL'S HAREM

If Artual isn't in the temple she is in her harem, where she has 4 male slaves, 3 humans (Jonie, Hargal and Sicmar) and 1 half-orc (Gurund). The harem is luxurious, beautiful furniture, excellent calimshite rugs and stunning art pieces. Artual's slaves are completely at her mercy and obey her every command. She will use them as meat shield.

Artual will fight to the death. She will use her gaze attack against whoever has attacked her and caused damage. She will try to use spells to inflict wounds on the PCs and inflict as much pain as possible.

She has her treasure in a brass-wrought chest. The chest is carefully locked, with a **DC 20 Dexterity** check the PCs can unlock the chest. It holds *Tentacle rod*, *Potion of Invisibility*, *Mithral chain shirt* and *Flail of Wounding* (as *Sword of Wounding*). The chest also holds 540 gp's and 6 bloodstones worth 30 gps each.

If the slaves survive the fight, they can inform the PCs that Aruma is Artual's daughter and that the cult strives to keep its presence and the temple secret. With a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs manage to convince the slaves they mean no harm and are here to help, making the slaves feel relaxed enough to share their information with the PCs. They can also tell the PCs how Artual and Aruma torture them and rape. Feel free to be as visual as you like.

10. LIDALIA-THUZURDA'S LAIR

Lidalia is the youngest of the Morueme. Yet, she is eager to prove herself and often flies out to hunt and test her strength. Her lair is spartan and she hasn't collected much treasure and Artual has taken most of it, leaving only 3215 cps behind. Lidalia is terrified with Artual and hates her with all her heart, and she can't wait having enough strength to kill the medusa

and take control of the war party.

When the PCs enter her lair the dragon at first thinks this is Artual and bows her head, mostly trying avert her eyes from the medusa's gaze. When she discovers that her lair is being visited by someone else, she doesn't attack. Instead she keeps her distance and makes sure that she can escape by flying out.

Lidial tries to get insight to why the PCs are there. If the PCs tell her that they have killed Artual, she will thank them and tell them that they are free to go. If the PCs speak nothing of it or haven't met Artual, Lidial will try to orchestrate the high priest's death. With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs get the feeling that the dragon sincerely hates Artual, yet fears her and dares not to take the medusa on all by herself. She will under no circumstances put her into a position of danger. If the PCs get violent or threaten Lidial she will flee and alert the other dragons. With a successful **DC 12 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs get the feeling that anything that makes Lidial feel safe and not threatened is key in making sure that she won't alert the other dragons.

Cave of War

The Spearheads guard the Cave of War and put much pride in it. They firmly believe that this is a sacred duty, since the Morueme hatchery is in the Cave of War. The Spearheads have a party of **20 hobgoblins** on guard at all times, divided into 5 groups who are supposed to be constantly marching through the cave. Unfortunately, the war party isn't disciplined and likes more drinking and visiting the brothels. The best part though, being on watch in the cave, is to get to bully the beholder in the library.

If the alarm is sounded the hobgoblin muster their defences and all have advantage to Wisdom (Perception) and +5 to their Passive Perception.

1. ENTRANCE

Deep under castle Doomspire is the entrance to the Cave of War. It is guarded by **4 hobgoblins** at all times, but their lack of discipline makes them careless. They have a disadvantage to Wisdom (Perception) and -5 to Passive Perception. They will however attack any intruder after one of their team



has sounded the alarm. There is a brass gong by the stairs.

The stairs leading to the captain's quarters is trapped. With a successful **DC 13 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot a thin rope that is tied to the gong and strung across one of the steps. If the PCs trigger the trap the gong will simply fall over and make enough racket to put the whole cave on alert.

2. MAGLUBIYET'S SHRINE ROOM

The shrine room is devoted to Old Fire Eyes and a crude shrine stands in one corner. The Spearheads often place tokens and small sacrifices at the shrine, but these are mostly cut off ears, fingers and other similar items.

3. NAHAUNGLAROTH'S THRONE ROOM

The ancient blue dragon and brother to Roraurim is vain and likes nothing more than being worshipped. He sometimes takes the shape of a human and sits in his throne, giving the Spearheads leaders a chance to grovel before him. The throne is made of adamantite and decorated with gems and precious stones, worth 2500 gps. It weighs, however, over a ton.

4. LIBRARY

Nahaunglaroth's library is extensive and holds many priceless codicis and libremes. His spellbooks and more priced scrolls are stored in the castle. Still, with a **DC 15 Intelligence (History)** the PCs can find great and expensive, extremely rare and nigh obtainable books on all kinds of subjects, e.g. *Iondalara's treatise on Thay*, *The Underdark - a merchant's tale*, *Do Drows ever feel down?* by S.A. Lva'Tore and *Is this your cutlery or mine?* - A Zhentilman's guide to goblin etiquette and culinary culture.

The library is guarded by a beholder, who is in fact a human normally just called the Librarian. His soul is trapped in the beholder's body, while the soul of the beholder is in the jar in the Cave of Secrets.

The smell of old books fills the air. Books, libremes, codicis, scrolls, maps and all kind of manuscripts fill the large room you've just entered. There are many bookshelves and all are full. Suddenly a

large sphere floats into your view, a large eye dominating the center of the sphere, which also holds a big mouth, filled with sharp teeth, and smaller eyes on stalks that all turn to you. The sphere narrows its eye and whispers: "What are you doing here?"

The Librarian is in no mood for any games. He has a library to run and he certainly doesn't allow any noise in it. If the PCs wish to speak to the Librarian they will have to whisper. The Librarian has come to terms with his condition. He was taken many years ago as a slave and tasked with taking care of the library. He still remember what it was like to be human, though it was many years ago. He can inform the PCs that Xe'Kala put a spell on him but he has no knowledge of magic, so he can't tell which spell it was. But the Librarian doesn't remember what his real name was anymore, he has been called the Librarian for so long now.

With a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs know that this is not an act, somehow Xe'Kala either polymorphed the Librarian or moved his soul. If the PCs break the magic jar in Cave of Secret, the Librarian's soul is transferred back into his old body and the beholder's soul returns into the beholder body, which will leave the Spearheads war party with a large and a very dangerous problem in their cave.

With a successful **DC 17 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot the secret door leading to the Librarian's room.

5. LIBRARIAN'S ROOM

The librarian has his own room. He uses it mostly to read and nap. It is almost empty save for three books and a small reading stand.

6. HATCHERY

The Hatchery is reserved for the Morueme's eggs and strictly off limits for anyone but the dragons of the Morueme. At the moment there are no eggs there, but fragments of old dragon eggs can be found with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception)** check. These egg shell fragments have a leathery feel to them, tinted with blue and gold streaks in them.



With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana)** check the PCs know that some wizards would pay for these as spell components.

7. CAPTAINS' QUARTERS

Only the Spearheads's leaders have access to this room, so that they don't need to sleep in the barracks. There are 6 bunkbeds and just as many small chests. At any given time there are **two hobgoblin captains** here. There is 60% chance that they are both sleeping, 90% chance that one of them is sleeping. With a successful **DC 15 Dexterity (Stealth)** check the PCs manage to sneak up to them without waking them. Captains that are awake attack and shout for help, alerting the hobgoblins on watch in the cave. The captains fight to the death, knowing that if they fail defending the cave their dragon overlord will make them suffer far worse.

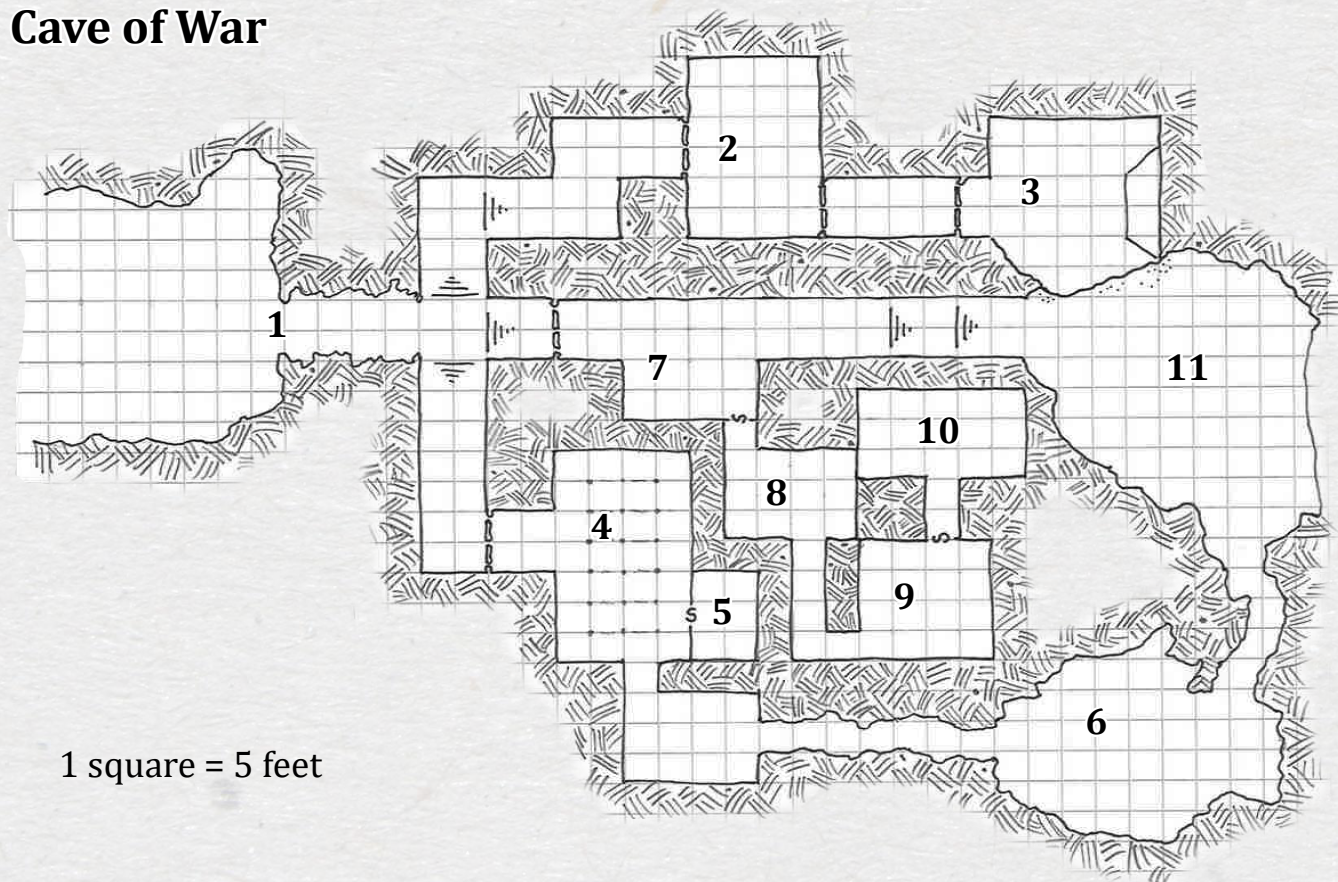
The secret door leading to the headquarters isn't well hidden, with a successful **DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs spot it. However, if the mechanical trap isn't disabled first, opening the

door can prove quite dangerous. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs spot the trapdoor and with a successful **DC 18 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to disable the mechanism. If someone opens the door without disarming the trap, with a successful **DC 15 Dexterity save** the PC jumps away before the trap springs. A failed save means that the PC fails down (5d10 dmg) and hits cold water. With a successful **DC 10 Strength (Athletics)** check the PC manages to stay afloat. Raise the DC by 1 for every minute that passes. A failed check means that the PC fails to stay afloat and starts drowning, see PHB p. 183. Climbing the walls is not an easy task, with a successful **DC 18 Strength (Athletics)** check the PC manages to climb up again.

8. SPEARHEADS HEADQUARTERS

The Spearheads' headquarters are only for the top ranking captains and leaders of the war party. A large wooden table dominates the room and a moth-eaten tapestry hangs from the wall opposite the entrance, showing a scene from a large battle,

Cave of War



1 square = 5 feet



where blue dragons and hobgoblins fight orcs. With a successful **DC 20 Intelligence (History)** check the PCs recognize that the scene is from one of the many wars that the Blood of Morueme have fought against the Many-Arrows orcs.

9. WAR ROOM

The Speaheads' war room was used by Balugar's predecessor and her captains to plot and plan campaigns and wars. The walls are lined with shelves holding maps and models of siege engines etc. Since Balugar took over as the Spearheads' leader this room has fallen into disrepair.

With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs notice a trail in the dust, leading to one wall. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** the PCs spot the secret door. It is locked, with a successful **DC 18 Dexterity** check the PCs manage to unlock it.

10. BALUGAR'S ROOM

The room beyond the secret door is a mess. A ornate and once beautiful desk stands in one corner, an open closet and a bed in the other. Everything smells of sweat and ale.

Balugar usually spends his days in the Lower Ward, and only returns to his quarters late at night, usually drunk. His most prized possessions are his armor and his *Spear* +2, both of which he usually has with him. In a secret compartment in the closet is a pouch containing 4 bloodstones, worth 320 gps. With a successful **DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation)** check the PCs find the secret compartment. It isn't locked.

11. NAHAUNGLAROTH'S LAIR

Nahaunglaroth isn't often in his lair, preferring to stay in Castle Doomspire. When he comes he only comes to have his hobgoblins grovel at his feet. He stores his treasure in an extra-dimensional space, only accessible by him. There is a 10% chance each day that Nahaunglaroth decides to grace the Spearheads with his presence. If he discovers the PCs in his lair, he will at first be amused that they dared to enter the lair. He offers the PCs to bow to his might. If they refuse he will attack. If they bow and speak about

his awesomeness, with a successful **DC 18 Charisma (Deception/Persuasion)** check he will allow them to leave his draconic presence, not caring why they are there or who they are.

Five war parties

There are five war parties in Doomspire village and Castle Doomspire. There's a strict hierarchy among these war parties and between them, the lowest war parties live in the dirt in the Lower Ward, the elite war party lives in Castle Doomspire and is responsible for defending it. Their relationship between these different groups is at best strenuous, at worst outright violent. The leaders of the war parties form a war council along with Argur the Bloody-Handed and Ardo'Uloan (see appendix), who acts as a speaker of the Morueme.

Every hobgoblin in Doomspire village belongs to any of the war parties. Each of the war parties venerates Maglubiyet, and some also venerate other evil deities. The war parties in the Lower Ward covet the place the war parties in the Higher Ward, while those two eagerly seek ways to replace the Chosen of Morueme and making sure that the war parties in Lower Ward don't get a foothold in Higher Ward. The politics between the war parties at a time when there's no war to be fought or no raids to be made is best described as minefield. Once as Argur declares a war or a time for a raid strict discipline takes over and every hobgoblin knows its place and marching order.

The war party descriptions offer Social Points Opportunities, which are ideas for how the PCs can gather Social Points. Feel free to add to these and reward the players for clever thinking.

WARMONGERS

The Warmongers are the lowest of all the war parties. The Warmongers used to live among the elite of Doomspire in Castle Doomspire, but few years ago the war party leader, Ruthless Roudy, had the Maglubiyet high priest, Harkell, killed, after the priest had said that her buttocks was so large that whole platoon would be needed to surround her.



Roudy had the priest beheaded and the head nailed to the temple doors. Roudy and her war party was demoted. Since then she responds to any insult in the worst possible manner.

The Warmongers are an unruly lot by hobgoblin standards. Roudy is furious over being demoted and can't wait to have her vengeance, she especially detests Argur who take great pleasure in sending her and the Warmongers on every insignificant and tedious mission he can think of.

If not out on a mission Roudy and her lieutenants can be found in the Torn Banner where she plots how the Warmongers can regain their place as the Morueme favourites. Every now and then she pays a visit to Paradise, where she gives vent to her anger and sadistic desires on the unlucky slaves.

War party information:

- There are 90 hobgoblins in the Warmongers war party
- The party has 5 hobgoblin captains, who are all female; Sousy, Arthena, Kilana, Hourel and Bardin.
- The party pays tribute to Bane in the Cave of Tyranny.
- Warmongers are ruthless and refrain from taking any prisoners.
- The party has a decent group of orc and human slaves.
- The captains all wear helmets with red manes.
- The party's preferred weapon is a morningstar.

Relations with other war parties

- Spearheads: Miserable lot, idiots who venerate the Maglubiyet
- Cragmouths: Bloody cannibals
- Skinners: Weak, they don't deserve their place in the Higher Ward
- Chosen of Morueme: Puppets of Argur.

Social points opportunities

- Free Ragor and get Garock to rise up against his

captors.

- Make Roudy believe that some of the other warlords have said something insulting about her.
- Find evidence that Argur orchestrated and was responsible for the Warmongers demotion.
- Let Roudy think that any of her captains plan to take her place as warlord.

SPEARHEADS

The Spearheads are the least disciplined of the war parties. They are loud, rowdy and dirty, even for hobgoblins. The Spearheads used to be the lowest party and Argur sent them on long and often fruitless missions. The Spearheads were content, for they are not all too eager to rise in rank and responsibility. They like it in the Lower Ward.

The Spearheads leader is Balugar, a large and burly hobgoblin who claims that his father was an ogre. He is a frequent guest at the Axes 'n Lillies and likes a good bar brawl more than the other regulars. He is a dislikable person, evil and despicable. He strongly believes in Maglubiyet and in his mind Argur the Bloody-handed is Maglubiyet incarnate, everything the high priest says Balugar considers to be as good as law. Balugar is therefore mostly only concerned in following Argur's orders and thinks little of the politics between the war parties and their leaders. If he ever gets the notion that Argur favours some of the other war parties more than the Spearheads he will challenge than war party outright.

The Spearheads have a loose formation and not a strict hierarchy, since infighting is quite common the role of captains change frequently though few dare to challenge Balugar, since he doesn't mind killing his challengers outright or bring them as sacrifices for Maglubiyet to Argur.

War party information

- There are 112 hobgoblins in the Spearheads war party, 47 are out on a mission.
- The party has 7 hobgoblin captains at the moment, three of these are not in Doomspire at the moment. The captains in Doomspire are



Einiar, Bloodrinker, Hargual and Jular.

- The party pays tribute to Maglubiyet and most of the party is fanatical in their devotion.
- The Spearheads are not disciplined and can go berserk in battle.
- The party has few slaves, most are goblins.
- The captains are marked with a bloody hand on their shoulder plate.
- The party's preferred weapon is a spear.

Relations with other war parties

- Warmongers: Heretical Banite bitches
- Cragmouths: Not as devout as we
- Skinners: Their love of their mounts is not natural. It keeps them away from the fight.
- Chosen of Morueme: Our finest.

Social points opportunities

- Get Balugar to suspect that the other war parties are more in Argur's favour.
- Make the captains believe that they can take on Balugar.
- Desecrate Maglubiyet's shrine.
- Defame Argur.

CRAGMOUTHS

The Cragmouths are disciplined and well trained. They train every day under the watchful eye of their leader, Goran Steelshield. The Cragmouths are well equipped and have mastered phalanx fighting. The members of the war party have formed a strong bond and they rely heavily on their training and their comrades. They are frightfully efficient in combat and to make sure that their enemies fear them. Recently they took up eating the leaders of their enemies and make sure that the word goes around.

Goran Steelshield is a brilliant tactician and a strong leader. The members of his war party and the captains would follow him anywhere and into any fight. What discipline he pushes on his underlings he takes on himself. Their barracks are spartan and so is their living. What no one knows on the other

hand is that Goran is afflicted with lycanthropy, he is a werewolf and he hates the fact and believes that if the other leaders or his captains would know, they would try to have him replaced. His hunger for raw meat get stronger every day. Still, Goran is flashy and likes to wear colourful clothes, especially elven silk shirts.

The Cragmouths rely heavily upon slaves, since the war party is busy training and marching. There are over 20 Aranea slaves in the barracks who tend to the war party needs, 15 human and goblins slaves who cook and tend to armours and weaponry. The slaves are treated badly and malnourished.

War party information

- There are 93 hobgoblins in the Cragmouths war party
- The party has 3 hobgoblin captains; Birgir, Groula and Karouvar.
- The party pays half-hearted homage to Maglubiyet.
- Warmongers are disciplined and evoke fear in their enemies hearts.
- The party has a large group of aranea, human and goblin slaves.
- The captains are armed with *longswords* +1.
- The party's preferred weapon is longsword.

Relations with other war parties

- Warmongers: Spiteful bitches.
- Spearheads: Argur's tools.
- Skinners: Great mounted fighters. Fearful respect.
- Chosen of Morueme: They cower behind those walls and make us keep the village safe.

Social points opportunities

- Discover Goran's secret and use it against him.
- Turn the slaves against the Cragmouths.
- Kill the captains.

SKINNERS



The Skinners are a terrible war party, efficient and brutal, fear for their cavalry. They have trained worgs as mounts and they ride these awful creatures to battle. Their aim is to create as much mayhem as possible, leaving a gory trail behind them and sowing fear and discord among their enemies.

Leader of the Skinners is Aruma, believe it or not, a strikingly beautiful hobgoblin. She has a mesmerizing gaze, one that can freeze the blood in the bones of her enemies and make their limbs go stiff. Her mother is Artual, the medusa in the Cave of Pain and the Loviatar high priest.

The Skinners are disciplined and well trained, though Aruma doesn't take much part in the trainings. She leaves that to her lieutenants, while she spends her time in the House of Pleasure, seeking more and more ways to inflict pain to the slaves.

The war party's knights are hobgoblins who have proved themselves over and over in battle and have been elevated in rank and awarded with a worg. The knights are then introduced to the secret cult that venerates Loviatar. Each knight takes care of her mount, along with a score of slaves.

War party information

- There are 120 hobgoblins in the Skinners war party, 80 of which are on a mission.
- The party has 12 hobgoblin captains, 8 are on a mission, 4 are in Doomspire; Aron, Hergul, Jirlia and Esmer.
- Most of the footsoldiers pay tribute to Maglubiyet, the knights and the leaders secretly pay homage to Loviatar.
- Skinners are brutal and try to inflict as much pain as possible to their enemies.
- The party has a large group of slaves.
- The captains are armed with *Flail* +1 and *shield* +1.
- The party's preferred weapon is a flail.

Relations with other war parties

- Warmongers: Pity they're no longer in the Castle.
- Spearheads: Their idiot leader needs to learn

discipline.

- Cragmouths: There's something off about Balugar.
- Chosen of Morueme: Hateful lot.

Social points opportunities

- Kill Artual.
- Expose the secret Loviatar cult.
- Poison the Worgs' food supply.

CHOSEN OF MORUEME

The Chosen have recently taken up position in the Castle. They are highly defensive and distrustful of anyone, believing that the other war parties are plotting against them.

The Chosen of Morueme is the only war party that has a number of half-dragon hobgoblins. The war party, though not as numerous as the largest war parties, is the only war party that has put focus on sorcery and witchcraft and is trusted by the blue dragons.

Leader of the Chosen of Morueme is the half-dragon hobgoblin Xe'Klara, a vicious and evil evoker. She has an affinity with lightning spells and loves the smell of electrically charged air. Her wings are fully developed and she loves to soar above battlefields and let lightning bolts rain down on her enemies.

Few weeks ago Roraurim sensed the distress of the Aranea and divined that the Aranea Queen Egg was not as hidden as before. The dragon ordered Xe'Klara to retrieve it, who in turn sent Sha'Xala, one of her lieutenants. Sha'Xala returns to Doomspire shortly after the PCs, which will set the Chosen of Morueme on high alert and go searching through every house of the village. The captains have kept a beholder in captive in the Cave of Secrets (see above), one who has served as a librarian and translator of spellbooks.

Xe'Klara and Argur are lovers and therefore the relationship between the high priest and the war party is close. What Argur doesn't know is, that Xe'Klara used him and charmed him into starting the rumour about the Warmonger's leader, knowing that Roudy would react in the worst possible way.



War party information

- There are 90 hobgoblins in the Chosen of Morueme war party.
- The party has 3 hobgoblin captains who all are half-dragons and spellcasters (use the Mage spelllist on p. 347 in MM, swap out Fireball for Lightning bolt); Sha'Xala (see appendix), Gar'Kla and Gil'Tana.
- The war party pays tribute to Roraurim.
- Chosen of Morueme are highly trained in fighting alongside spellcaster.
- The party has a large group of orc and half-orc slaves.
- The captains are armed with *Staff of Thunder and Lightning* and *Ring of protection +2*.
- The party's preferred weapon is a glaive.

Relations with other war parties

- Warmongers: They wish to take our place.
- Spearheads: At best a useful tool, though not a sharp one.
- Cragmouths: Awfully efficient and a threat.
- Skinners: Their combat prowess is admirable but their leader is something else and not to be trusted.

Social points opportunities

- Expose Xe'Kala and Argur's relationship.
- Discover Xe'Kala's plot and evidence of Argur's part in demoting the Warmongers.
- Release the Librarian.

Slaves

The hobgoblins hold about 400 slaves captive, mostly humans and goblins. The slaves take care of most of the day-to-day business in Doomspire and service the war parties. Most of the slaves have been captured and would like to be set free, but are simply too afraid to act or do anything, with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs get the feeling that the slaves are broken and hard to rally.

There are few leaders among the slaves, each specie

has their own leader and to convince the slaves to do anything needs to go through these characters. Finding the leaders is not so easy, with a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion/Intimidate)** check the PCs managed to find enough information that will lead them to the right leader, if they speak the same language as the race in question. Raise the DC by 5 if the PCs don't speak the racial language.

Most of the slaves live in the slave slum (see the Lower Ward) and eek out a meager living there. If they become ill or hurt it's not uncommon to see those slaves dragged away, either to become a sacrifice for Maglubiyet or to the castle, never to be seen again.

All the slaves fear three things above all else in Doomspire; Argur the Bloody-Handed who sometimes randomly finds a slave and sacrifices it in the Temple of War, Ardo'Uloan who mercilessly punishes the slaves and brings them to the Castle, and finally, the blue dragons of Morueme. With a successful **DC 13 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs get the feeling that there's a threat the looms over the slaves, a threat bigger than any threat or offer they will make. If the PCs manage to deal with any of these threats, assign Social Points accordingly and award the PCs with an advantage on all Charisma-based rolls when dealing with the slaves.

Aranea

The Aranea slaves have been in Doomspire for a few decades and in that time they have not reproduced, so they are an aging group and not many of them are left. The hobgoblins have mostly used the female Aranea in the brothels as sexual slaves, while the male aranea have been used in many different manual labor tasks.

Few weeks ago the Aranea felt the call of the Aranea Queen egg, though most of them didn't realize what it was. The male Aranea became unruly and difficult to handle, thus many of them were either taken to the Castle or to the Cave of Suffering. The female are still kept in the brothels and forced to shapechange into whatever fancies the hobgoblins.

The Aranea has suffered terrible as slaves of the Blood of Morueme. Originally they were over 400,



now they are about 60 and 20 of them are either too ill or too weak to escape and live. Convincing the rest to leave their friends, lovers and siblings behind is not an easy task, with a successful **DC 18 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs manage to talk the Aranea into leaving Doomspire with them. The Aranea will not leave Doomspire if none of the three major threats have been dealt with.

LEADERS

Ri'Uala - Lives in Paradise. Speaks for the Aranea in the brothel. There are 8 Aranea in the Brothel, some of which are very weak. She will not leave unless all the female can come as well. With a successful **DC 16 Wisdom (Medicine)** check the PCs know that with a few healing spells and cure disease they can mobilize all the aranea there. Ri'Uala's sister, Gar'Relatha, is a chosen of Leira and the future queen (see Appendix).

Gor-Ali - In the Cave of Suffering. Speaks for the 34 male Aranea in the cave, many of which are ill and injured badly. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Medicine)** check the PCs learn that only 22 of the males are fit to make the journey to Arn forest. No matter how hard the PCs press, Gor-Ali will not talk the slaves into leaving if Jor-Kalaz hasn't been dealt with and the four Aranea slaves in the dragon's cave been freed. If the PCs manage to free the slaves, without slaying the dragon, he needs some convincing. With a successful **DC 17 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs convince him to lead the slaves out from the cave. If Jor-Kalaz is dead, Gor-Ali needs no convincing.

Di'Ana - Lives in the House of Pleasure along with 18 Aranea. She is very afraid of Aruma, the leader of the Skinners, after being repeatedly tortured by the half-medusa. If the PCs bring her news of the war party leader's death the PCs will have an advantage to any charisma-based roll made against her. With a successful **DC 20 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs manage to convince Di'Ana and the Aranea to leave the House of Pleasure, but only if the PCs have a plausible plan of escaping the city. Of the 18 Aranea there, only 10 are fit enough to leave.

Humans

There are about 30 humans held captive in Doomspire. Most of these are Zhents from the Dalelands or the Moonsea region. The humans are treated badly and often used as dummies for hobgoblin war party battle practices. Their spirit is broken and talking them into revolting against their captors is hard. Most of the humans live in the Slave Slum and they are terrified, for something evil has been attacking them, especially the few young ones. The reason for their fear is the Oni who lives in the Cave of Tyranny.

LEADERS

Helga - an elderly lady from Daggerdale, former cleric of Sune. After she was attacked and suffered grievous wounds in her face, she abandoned her goddess. Helga is bitter and lonely, she misses her friends and family in the Dales, but mostly she mourns her good looks. Helga, despite missing almost half of her face (she was hit with a rendering flail in her head), is likeable and relatable. She tends to her fellow humans wounds (she has +8 in Medicine) and tries to make the best out of their situation. Helga isn't too keen on revolting against the hobgoblins, for that she has tended too many wounds and buried too many friends. She will listen to the PCs plan however and if they can produce a plan that will not endanger the humans, she will agree to it. A cleric PC, with a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Insight)** check, can sense that Helga would be open to hear about Ilmater and learn more about the broken god's tenets. With a successful **DC 20 Wisdom** check and invest at least two hours each night, the cleric manages to teach Helga about Ilmater. Helga feels inspired and next morning prays for spells.

Helga asks the PCs for help and hopes that they will make the boogeyman go away, the one that kidnapped a couple of young ones in the last three weeks. She doesn't know more than this, three weeks ago Aron was taken from his bed and 10 days ago Silvia vanished. Aron was 7 years old, Silvia was 3 years old and born into slavery. The human children



say that the boogeyman is after them and are terrified going to sleep.

Goblins

There are over 200 goblins in Doomspire, many of which who don't even think that they are slaves of the Blood of Morueme. The goblins live almost anywhere they can, in the Slave Slum, in barrels and boxes behind the taverns and brothels, on the roofs of the barracks. Where there is some refuge from the wind and rain, a goblin has probably made a home. The goblins are a dirty and despicable lot, driven by greed. Their leaders are few and the goblins only have loose connection between themselves, since they come from myriads of tribes from all over the Silver Marches and the North.

LEADERS

Shag'Rath - Lives in the Slave Slum. Shag'rath is an exceptionally despicable goblin, who delights in the suffering of others. On the other hand, he seems to know more than is good for a goblin like him about the hobgoblins and slaves. Still, if he should stand to gain anything from it, like if the alarm is raised after Sha'Xalala returns, he won't hesitate in squealing on the PCs.

Dark - Lives in a cardboard box by the Skinner's Worgpens. Dark is a good aligned goblin, who has seen more than his share of suffering and tyranny of his hobgoblin masters. He knows about the Loviatar cult in the Cave of Pain, with a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs manage to convince Dark to tell them about it. Dark secretly worships Ilmater.

Ab'Bath - Lives in a barrel-community (15 old wooden barrels interconnected) not far from Axes 'n Lillies. Ab'Bath and his gang, a group of 13 goblins who call themselves the Immortals, are a kind of street thugs who steal and learn a living by carrying out all kind of thuggish things that the hobgoblins don't want to do themselves. Ab'Bath was the one who started the rumour about Roudy's backend and told everyone that Harkell had said this. Argur paid him 30 silver pieces for that. With a successful **DC 18 Charisma (Intimidate)** check the PCs can coerce Ab'Bath to reveal the truth.

Orcs and Half-Orcs

There are about 100 orcs and half-orcs in Doomspire, who are all a part of the same tribe, which was enslaved about a year ago. Many orcs have died in captivity, making the tribe members actively hate the hobgoblins. The tribe, called the Darkscars, lost their leader, Norg Darkscard, in the battle when the Blood of Morueme enslaved the tribe. Since then the tribe has been divided. Most of the orcs seem to have come in terms with their lot in life, after all their inborn respect for strength tells them that it's their role to follow the strongest one around and at the moment that are the hobgoblins. The half-orcs are a whole different story and not ready to bow to the hobgoblins.

LEADERS

Gorack - Lives in the Slave Slum. His partner, Ragor, is being held in the Cave of Pain and if the PCs manage to free him, Gorack will see the PCs are the strongest one in the village and follow their plan to the extreme.

Horag - Lives with 17 half-orcs in the ruins in front of the Cave of Tyranny. He hates the cowardice of Gorack and the orcs. He strongly believes that the orcs should revolt against the hobgoblins, but needs weapons and armors. Horag is a great warrior but not a very bright or wise one (Int 6, Wis 5). If the PCs bring them weapons and armor, with a successful **DC 14 Charisma (Persuasion)** check, Horag leads the half-orcs on a suicide mission against the hobgoblins in Castle Doomspire, firmly believing that Gruumsh will aid them.

Freeing the slaves

If the PCs manage to collect the sufficient amount of Social Collapse points they manage to cause enough problems for the hobgoblins. You need to judge by the PCs action what happens, the war parties could attack each other, the order and disciplines of the hobgoblins could be weakened or the blue dragons feel threatened enough to leave their lairs and show the hobgoblins who rule Doomspire.

Once chaos ensues in Doomspire the PCs should see



a chance to leave with the slaves and set them free. There are guards at the gates but due to the chaos they don't get help when they call for it, the guards try to stop the PCs but if half of them are defeated the rest flees. If the PCs try to leave too early with the slaves, e.g. through the secret route in the pond, the hobgoblin guards could see them and sound the alarm. Feel free to make this as hard as possible, after all, there are many hobgoblins in Doomspire, some even quite powerful. Reward the players for clever thinking.

Once the PCs and the slaves are out from Doomspire they need to put as much distance between themselves and the village, because the hobgoblins will eventually figure out what has happened and follow their trail. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs know that they only have about half a day before the hobgoblins manage to get control of the situation and send out scouts to find the slaves' trail.

Reward

Award normal XP for defeated foes.

Award each player XP for completing the following:

- Freeing the Aranea slave - 500 xp
- Freeing the Librarian - 400 xp
- Freeing Ragor - 400 xp
- Restoring Helga's faith in the gods - 300 xp
- Freeing other slaves - 10 xp for each slave.

If you are using the milestone rule, the PCs should be at level 9 when they leave Doomspire and head out to Laz'Shadamar.



Chapter 9: Back to Laz'Shadamar

Leaving Doomspire

If the PCs have managed to leave Doomspire in chaos, it should buy them time to put some distance between the slave group and the village. For every point beyond 10 the PCs earn a day's headstart, e.g. if the PCs earned 12 points they will have 2 days head start.

Once the hobgoblin leaders have regained control in Doomspire and discovered that the slaves have escaped they will send out scouts. If the PCs do nothing to hide their tracks or to keep the slaves moving the scouts will pick up the trail in few hours and begin chase.

While enroute to Laz'Shadamar

The now-free slaves are in different condition when they leave Doomspire, some are well, some are injured while other are ill. They need any help they can get. They also need food and water, water is easy to come by while trekking through the Nether Mountains, but as soon as the group enters the

plains that lie between Arn Forest and the Nether Mountains, water is scarce.

The leaders of the group have different opinions on whatever decisions the PCs make and voice their opinion whenever they deem it necessary. The PCs can get these NPCs to help them move the group along, and hinder them. Feel free to add whatever skill checks you deem necessary when both interacting with these characters and the group as a whole.

Ri'Uala - She is adamant in returning to Laz'Shadamar, especially as her sister gets weaker. She will back the PCs up whenever they try to make the group march and move the Aranea closer to the Aranea city. She will reveal to the PCs on the first night that she was a cleric, though she will talk only about the Dark Mother, never about Leira. Her strongest ambition is to leave Doomspire and get her sister to safety in Laz'Shadamar.

Gar'Relatha - She is ill and gets weaker as days go by, no matter what the PCs do to help her. The only thing that seems to strengthen her is to be close to the Aranea Queen Egg. She bears the ever weakening



essence of Leira and needs to return to the Hidden Temple, as soon as possible.

Gor-Ali - He is at first relieved to be free, though he mourns those Aranea that were left behind. After the hobgoblins attack, he changes his mind and speaks freely about this is foolhardy, doomed to fail and that the hobgoblins will attack again. Their best course of action is to surrender.

Di'Ana - She is mostly silent and doesn't speak much to the PCs. Still, she works hard to keep the Aranea spirit high. She works hard making sure that everyone gets water and something to drink, neglecting her own well-being. She is well liked by all the Aranea and while the PCs work hard to ensure their safe return to Laz'Shadamar she will speak on the PCs behalf.

Other slave leaders - Helga is on the PCs side, especially if they have spent time in restoring her faith. She will then use her spells and skills to help move the group along. Gorack will also help the PCs, if they freed Ragor. If they didn't, Gorack will be a thorn in their shoe and speak often and freely about returning to Doomspire, to free those left behind.

The Chase

As soon as the hobgoblins discover that the slaves have escaped they will begin chase. Scouts riding worgs will be sent out to find tracks and get the slaves back. The PCs can do many things to make it harder for the hobgoblins to locate the group and attack. Reward clever thinking. Make a note of when the hobgoblins start their chase, the worg-riding scouts move twice as fast as the freed slaves, so for every four hours that pass the hobgoblins get one step closer, e.g. if the hobgoblins start the chase one day after the freed slaves the hobgoblins are 6 steps behind but reach the slaves in one day, if the PCs take no precautions. Use of skills and spells can help the group and put more distance between them and the hobgoblin scouts. Here are a few ideas, feel free to add to it.

With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Survival)** check the PCs see that staying in rocky terrain makes it harder for the hobgoblins to track the group. Move the hobgoblins one step back.

With a successful **DC 15 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs convince the group to move faster and push through, move the hobgoblins one step back. This, however, can only be done once per day.

With a successful **DC 20 Charisma (Persuasion)** check the PCs get the group to push on through the night. Move the hobgoblins one step back.

With successful **DC 20 Wisdom (Survival)** check the PCs manage to divert or scatter the groups trails enough to confuse the hobgoblin trackers. Move the hobgoblins one step back.

With the use of spells like *Hallucinatory terrain*, *Fog cloud*, *Pass without trace* etc. move the hobgoblins one step back.

With the use of spells like *Conjure Animals*, *Conjure Woodland Beings*, *Find Steed* or similar spells to summon beasts of burden, that can help and speed the group along, move the hobgoblins one step back.

With use of spells like *Enthrall*, *Create food and water* or similar spells to make the life easier for the freed slaves, award them with an advantage on Charisma-based checks regarding the group.

Hobgoblin war party attacks

If the hobgoblins make up the distance the trackers will attack. The group, who is a part of the Skinners war party, consists of **8 hobgoblins** and **1 hobgoblin** captain, all riding **worgs**. The hobgoblins will try to make as much mayhem as possible, and will flee if they fall under half strength.

Take note on when the hobgoblins attack. If they attack in the first two days, the group is still in the Nether Mountains and therefore in rocky terrain. Spotting the chase is hard due to this, with a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception)** the PCs see the hobgoblins coming and have 1 round to get ready or use ranged weapons or spells. If the hobgoblins attack after the first two days the attack occurs in the plains. Spotting the chase is easier, with a successful **DC 14 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs see the hobgoblins and have 2 round to to prepare themselves or use ranged weapons or spells. If the check fails, the hobgoblins have a surprise round.

If the PCs don't act heroically and use all their skills



in defending the slaves, they will have a disadvantage for all Charisma-based skills regarding the slaves. If they manage to defeat the hobgoblins in 3 rounds or fewer the group will believe even harder in the PCs cause and their leadership.

In Laz'Shadamar

When the group reaches Arn Forest read the following:

You finally see the woods and breathe a sigh of relief. You enter the cool shades of the trees, knowing that you should reach Laz'Shadamar, the Aranea city, before the sun sets. Suddenly a scream of terror grabs your attention. More follow. You hear people talk and point southwards. You look in that direction, in where Dragonspire mountain towers. Dragons. A flight of dragons. As you peer over the fields you see that dark columns of hobgoblins are marching towards the forest. The Blood of Morueme is gaining on you.

It is easy to get the people moving and push them forward. Ri'Uala leads the group through the woods, she still knows the forest and quickly spots a trail she recognizes.

Twice through the day a gargantuan blue dragon flies over canopy of the forest, bringing screams of terror from the frightful crowd.

As the sun sets the group of slaves and PCs finally reach the ravine where the secret entrance to Laz'Shadamar is. Soon as the group enters the three tiered cave where the gates of Laz'Shadamar are, most of the Aranea change into their arachnid form and quickly climb down and through the gate.

You climb down after most of the freed slaves, guarding the rear. You can hear echos of the hobgoblin captains shouting commands to their subordinates. As you finally reach the lowest platform and see the gates of Laz'Shadamar, Ri'ualala comes running in her arachnid form.

"Quickly, come quickly," she pleads. "My sister, you must help her." As she turns and scurries through the gate, you hear someone go through the verbal chant of spellcasting. You look up and see a winged blue hobgoblin with draconic features point its hands towards you. The air crackles with energy as lightning bolt shoots from its hands.

Sha'Xala and a retinue of **20 hobgoblins** has caught the group. He hopes to slow the PCs down, while her warriors climb down towards the gates. Ri'Uala ushers the PCs to follow her. She leads the PCs to the platform overlooking the Aranea city. They can see where the former slaves hurry towards the Royal Palace. If there are non-Aranea slaves they are being guided by the Aranea and helped across the many web bridges. Gar'Relatha, still in human form, on the platform, exhausted and gasps for breath.

You finally reach the city and see where the Aranea scurry across the web towards the Royal Palace. Gar'Relatha, however, lies in human form on the platform, her breath is shallow and her skin is gray. "Please, friends, she desperately needs to get to the Hidden Temple. I know you have magic. Can you please help her? Can you please get her to the Altar? Otherwise she will die!" Ri'Uala begs you.

If the PCs are worried about the following hobgoblins Ri'Uala will tell them that the illusions of the city are still good and will slow the attackers down. If the PCs ask about her plans, she hopes that she will reach the Royal Palace where she and the Aranea will make a stand. If the PCs ask why Gar'Relatha needs to get to the altar Ri'Uala will say that it has special healing powers and will help her get better. With a successful **DC 20 Wisdom (Insight)** check the PCs feel that this is only the truth from a certain point of view, but there's hardly much time to stand and argue. If the PCs hand her the Aranea Queen Egg or have at any given point in the story done so she clings to it and hold it close to her body.

As the PC get ready to move Gar'Relatha an owl shoots over their head and flies quickly into the city. With a successful **DC 18 Wisdom (Perception)** check the PCs see that the owl flies towards the Royal Palace and the Hidden Temple. This is Ramal in owl form.

If the PCs use spells like *Teleportation Circle* the hobgoblin warriors will reach the platform 2 rounds before the spell is complete. If the PCs use combination of spells like *Fly*, *Levitate*, *Gaseous form*, *Spider climb*, *Dimension door* or *Telekinesis*, rewards their clever thinking. If they plan on carrying Gar'Relatha to the temple, the hobgoblins and Sha'Xala will quickly catch up.



The Hidden Temple - Ramal Warmstone and Roraurim attack

Once the PCs reach the temple read the following:

You reach the platform where the main entrance to the temple is. You can hear that there is someone in there. Gar'Relatha is barely conscious and seems near dead than alive. Time is running out for her. As your about to enter the temple a deafening roar echoes through the cave. You turn to see a gargantuan blue dragon come into being in the middle of the city. Behind the dragon you spot the winged hobgoblin that shot you with a lightning bolt earlier.

Time is of the essence here. With a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Medicine)** check the PCs know that Gar'Relatha has no more than 12 rounds left, till she dies.

If the PCs didn't deal with the drow **Paron** in *Trouble under Arn Forest* his undeads have attacked **Ramal**, who has conjured forth a **fire elemental** to help him fight the necromancer. If Paron has been dealt with Ramal has conjured an *Insect plague* and waits for an opportunity to unleash an *Ice storm* on the PCs. He's through with asking nicely for the Aranea Queen Egg. He will direct the insects to attack as well and use other spells that don't need concentration to soften up the PCs, before moving in. If the Aranea Queen Egg is visible, e.g. if Gar'Relatha holds it, he will direct all his attention to it.

Sha'Xala enters the temple just after the PCs, three rounds later, eager to make them pay for freeing the slaves and make her look bad, for not finding the Aranea Queen Egg. He will eagerly join the fight along with **6 hobgoblins**.

Three rounds after the PCs enter the temple is starts shaking violently, making all normal and climbing movement difficult, effectively making all squares difficult terrain. Flying movement is not affected. This is because the ancient blue dragon Roraurim has begun tearing through the temple walls.

This is both a very chaotic and a very dangerous encounter. It shouldn't be easy for the PCs to get Gar'Relatha to the altar, but it's very important. Reward their clever thinking. This is a showdown and should feel like it. Ramal will scream at the PCs,

trying to get them to give him the Aranea Queen Egg, while Sha'Xala will threaten the PCs and curse them for their insolence for freeing the slaves. The threat of Roraurim should also be present. If Paron is still alive he will use his spells to mostly attack Ramal and any cleric that could turn or destroy his undead.

If the PCs manage to get Gar'Relatha to the altar before she dies, read the following:

Gar'Relatha falls exhausted on the altar. With a shudder mist starts pouring from her eyes, mouth and fingers. Her lips move and her body shakes. The Aranea Queen Egg falls from her hands.

Suddenly a huge tear opens in the temple wall and the head of a gargantuan blue dragon pushes through. It roars and inhales. The air around it's head crackles with static electricity.

LEIRA RETURNS

The PCs get the chance to react. Ask for their actions. When they have declared what they do, read the following:

The mist thickens. You feel the hair on your hands and heads rise, as shivers go down your spine. Gar'Relatha's limp body rises to the air, prismatic mists still pours from her eyes, ears, fingers, mouth and even her nose.

"No, it can not be," roars the gargantuan dragon, its voice showing hints of fear.

Allow the PCs and NPCs to act out their actions in initiative order.

The form of a human woman starts taking shape before you, her outlines blurred and strange, her face hidden by a shimmering wall of fog. She turns towards the dragon.

"For too long have you tortured my people, Roraurim, son of Kizilpazar," she says, her voice deafening. "For too long have you tortured *me*."

She throws herself at the dragon, growing in size as she does. She seems simultaneously to create multiple versions of herself.

Roraurim breathes a huge lightning bolt at her, one that could've easily killed a full grown stone giant. The lightning bolt doesn't seem to have harmed the huge woman.

With a successful **DC 18 Intelligence (Religion)** check the PCs recognize the woman as Leira, the goddess of illusions and lies, who was thought to be dead.



Sha'Xala, if he's still alive, will press his attack, though he is now more concerned in guaranteeing his escape. Ramal, if he's still alive, will shape change into an owl and make haste in leaving the place, for he recognizes the woman and has no interest in staying there any longer. If Peron is there, he will quickly scramble away, knowing that he is in way over his head.

If the PCs check on Gar'Relatha, she seems to be sleeping and with a successful **DC 10 Wisdom (Medicine)** check, the PCs see that she is alright now.

Leira will wrap herself around Roraurim and no matter how the dragon tries, he doesn't seem to get loose. She uses *Weird* and after a few rounds of melee the dragon dies. After Roraurim has been dealt with the avatar of Leira quickly makes good work of any hobgoblin in the city, using all kinds of illusions.

Sha'Xala, once outside the temple, will teleport back to the surface and tell the Blood of Morueme what has happened, which will convince the leaders of the Morueme that they are in too deep.

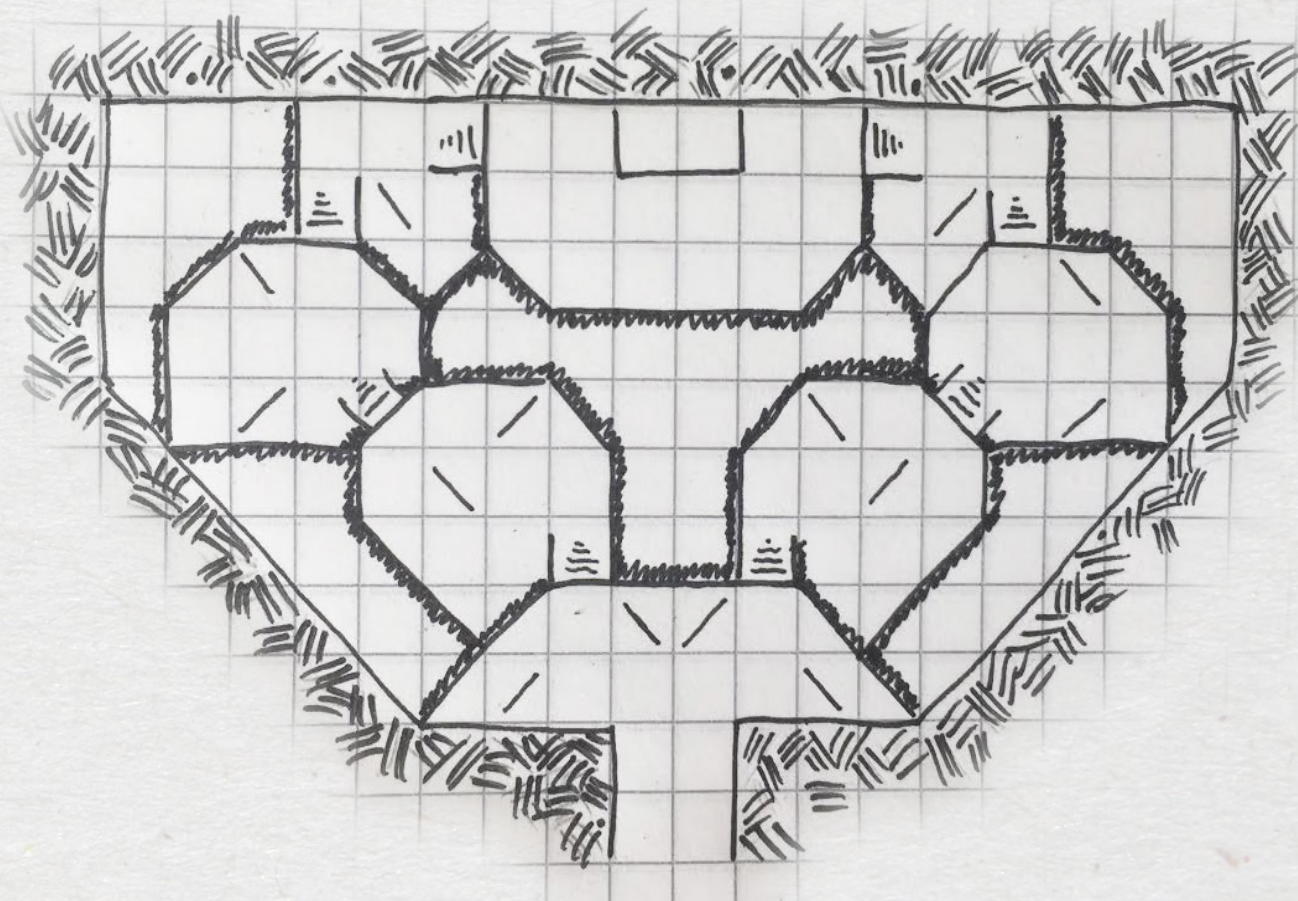
Aftermath

In the following days, Gar'Relatha recovers and is throned as queen. Her sister, Ri'Uala, becomes a priestess of Leira and takes over the Hidden Temple. Di'Ana takes on the responsibilities of a chancellor. Gar'Relatha doesn't have much to offer the PCs, since the city is poor but says that they will always have refuge in Laz'Shadamar.

If the PCs saved any non-Aranea slaves they can escort them to Deadsnows. The trip is uneventful but when they return to the village word quickly spreads about their heroic acts. The PCs are from now on in Deadsnows referred to as The Saviours of the Aranea.

The Doomspire village and the Blood of Morueme won't be trouble for the next few years, while they get over the loss of Roraurim.

If Alizarinathrax is still alive, she can return at a later time, still thirsty for revenge. If Ramal or Sha'Xala survived the battle they have little interest in meeting the PCs again.





Conclusion and rewards.

The PCs were instrumental in bringing back the goddess of illusion, lies and deceit. Unbeknownst to them she has blessed them, every time they lie or deceit, they do so at an advantage. If they use illusions they are more potent than before and harder to resist, saves are made at an disadvantage. They also get a +1 to one ability. The PCs should be at 10th level after the campaign.



Appendix A: NPC's



Rubert Anon

LG Human cleric 2 (Acolyte)

Rubert is dark haired and blue eyed. He's in his early 30's yet his well-groomed beard has grey streaks in it. Rubert usually wears a rose hued tabbard and his golden holy symbol. He has a small scar under his cheekbone.

Background: Rubert was born and raised in Sundabar, where he joined the church of Lathander. His father was a tanner and had higher hopes for his son, he managed to convince a dawnlord to take Rubert on as an acolyte. Rubert was quick to learn and found that the life of a cleric suited him well. He spent two seasons as a travelling cleric with a group from the church in Sundabar and when he returned to Sundabar, the high cleric asked him to go to Deadsnows and rebuild the church that had once stood there. Rubert accepted this mission and after he moved to Deadsnows has proven a great asset for the growing community.

Personality: Rubert is fair and just, he believes that given the right circumstances people will always

endure and do the right thing. He is a strong believer in Lathandar and promotes his deity when he can. He usually has a warm smile on his face and strives to bring hope to those who have none.

Connections: Rubert is a member of the Church of Lathander in Sundabar. He is also a member of the elder council in Deadsnows and he knows both the villagers and the surrounding farms and mines well. He knows how to brew healing potions and can use his spells to heal the wounded. He is a valuable ally.

Secret: Rubert has been investigating on his own the Icespear Manor, for he fears that undead are haunting it. So far, he hasn't been able to go deep into the cellar, but a few weeks ago he braved the cellar alone and found strange sigils carved into on wall. A couple of zombies attacked him and managed to wound him, leaving a white scar under his cheekbone.

Harad Havsum

CN Halfling rogue 4 (Criminal)

Harad is sandy haired and brown eyed, quick-witted and cheerful. He likes to wear colorful clothes



and usually wears a brown belt with three sheathed daggers, each richly decorated. He has a brand on his neck, one he eagerly explains he got due to big misunderstanding.

Background: Born and raised in Mulmaster, Harad quickly learned to help himself from living on the street. His alcoholic parents never paid him much mind and were more concerned about making sure they had something to drink, rather than feeding their children. After his mother died, Harad ran away from home and managed to south to Raven's Bluff. There he joined a gang of thieves and quickly rose through their rank, though he got caught once and was branded a thief by the magistrate. He joined the Zhentarim a few years later and travelled through the Dragonmere region. After falling into disgrace in the Black Network he slipped away and carved himself out a new life in Deadsnows.

Personality: Harad is ironic and quick with a sarcastic remark, which sometimes make his guest look twice. But he's quick with a smile and though many travelers and guest in his inn the people in Deadsnows know that he doesn't mean much with it. Harad's eyes usually dart from side to side and for some reasons he always has his back to a wall, whenever he can.

Connections: Almost all travellers going through Deadsnow spend the night at The Rose and Hammer. He knows most caravan leaders and guards and keeps a good eye where the caravans are headed and where they're coming from. Harad has also a good eye for valuables and can appraise both mundane and magical items.

Secret: No one in Deadsnows know that Harad used to be a member of the Zhentarim. There is a price on his head and he knows it. Even though he changed his name and now uses his fathers name (he used to be called Spider), he silently fears the day when his past comes knocking on his door.

Ol' Tom

N Half-elf Druid 7 (Hermit)

Ol'Tom is a tall but scrawny figure. He has some whiskers of hair in his face, betraying his human

heritage. His almond eyes are green as a field of grass. He wears a leather armor and a cape made of twigs and leaves. His gnarled oaken quarterstaff is old and worn.

Background: Born to a elven mother many decades ago Ol'Tom was never fully accepted in Evereska. He took to wandering and cherished being alone in nature. He left Evereska and spent many years in the High Forest, being tutored by the druids there. Few years ago, he received a dream from Chauntea, where the rebuilding of Deadsnows was prophesied. He travelled to Nether Mountains and has been watching over the rebuilding ever since.

Personality: Ol'Tom is a stoic and relaxed figure. He is eager to help those who are on nature's side and do not bring harm to it. He isn't all too fond of people and likes animals more, after being looked down upon most of his youth has left its mark on him.

Connections: Ol'Tom is a good friend to the farmers in Icespear Valley and knows the surrounding valleys well. He's also in good connection with the druid circle in the High Forest, especially those who venerate Chauntea.

Secret: Lately Tom has been dreaming about a many-faced threat rising from the darkness below. He hasn't figured out what these dreams mean but they have left him deprived of sleep and tired.

Olaf Arnesen

LG Human fighter 3 (Soldier)

Olaf is a large man in every way, his arms resemble tree trunks and his hands look like mallets. His head is bald but he has thick mustache. He usually wears his leather armor and a sword hangs loosely by his side.

Background: Olaf used to be a caravan guard before settling in Deadsnows. Originally from Ten Towns Olaf was raised by his father, a blacksmith, and after spending more time around the anvil than he cared for he told his father he wanted something more out of life and signed on as caravan enroute to Waterdeep. Olaf only got as far as Neverwinter but there he joined another caravan. He spent a few



summers like this, until he came to Deadsnows and heard that they council was looking for a sergeant.

Personality: Olaf is serious and down to earth character, he is pragmatic and realistic. He does not tolerate lawbreakers but strives to solve problems so that he doesn't need to arrest anyone. So far, he has managed to do so and the only people who have spent the night in his holding cell are either drunks or travelers when all rooms are booked in the Rose and Hammer.

Connections: Olaf is generally well liked by the caravan leaders, who know Olaf from the time when he was a caravan guard. Lately he has also been trying to get Deadsnows a part of the Lord's Alliance, but so far it has been fruitless.

Secret: Though he doesn't show it, Olaf is in fact xenophobic. Therefor he usually handles things differently when other races than humans are involved when something happens in Deadsnows that need his attention. Olaf dislikes Harad and is certain that the halfling is up to nothing good.

Coral Brittlebeard

CG Dwarf fighter 2 (artisan)

Coral is just above 5ft tall, with dark hair and heavy beard that he usually braids. When he's in his smithy he has his leather apron on and wears red trousers covered in soot. Coral tends to carry a large and battered warhammer when he leaves his smithy. His eyes are the color of clear sky and when he gets mad they seem to darken.

Background: Coral was born in Mithril Hall to a happy couple. His parents mentored him in the blacksmithing arts but just as many dwarves in the Halls Coral also received military training. After spending years trying to carve out a niche for himself in different dwarven societies Coral finally came to Deadsnows, bent on succeeding as a master blacksmith.

Personality: Coral is gruff and appears almost unfriendly to non-dwarves. His strong suit is blacksmithing and socializing with people is something that he feels someone else should be doing. To dwarves he's friendly and fair. His grasp

of Common isn't that strong and much is lost to translation.

Connections: Coral is the speaker for the dwarven clans in the elder council in Deadsnows. He knows all the leaders of the dwarven clans.

Secrets: Coral has been working on getting his family to Deadsnows, he hopes that he can convince them to join him and they could open a mine in the Nether Mountains.

Diliana Viveros

LN Human commoner 4 (noble)

Diliana is a fading beauty. She's in her late 30's and was probably a real stunner when she was younger. But years of struggle and hard work has left its mark on her. Viveros' blond hair is greying and her blue eyes have a worried cast on them. She often wears colorful clothes and has big golden earrings.

Background: Diliana was among the first people who returned to Deadsnows. She came with her husband, a hard-working baker who had won her heart few years earlier. Unfortunately, he got ill the first winter and never recovered, he passed before spring broke the ice on the Icespear river. Yet she continued to make a living in Deadsnows and tried to help the people get by. Before long she was elected on the elder council.

Personality: Viveros is a kind woman but pragmatic. Though she would love to help everyone she feels that her duty is first and foremost to the people of Deadsnows. Hard life and sorrow has left its mark on her, there's always a shadow in her eyes and longing in her voice.

Connections: Diliana know almost everyone in Icespear Valley and has a great pull in that society. She's not concerned about what the dwarven strongholds are doing or how the different power groups are fighting for more political power in the Heartlands.

Secret: Diliana secretly hopes that there's some way to bring back her husband. She has been pouring over books and scrolls she has discovered in the ruined buildings of the village.



Evert

NG Human wizard 5 (Spy)

Evert is one legged and part of his face is badly scarred. He constantly smells of different kinds of herbs due to constant potion making. He tends to wear his green cloak with golden trimming. Evert is in his 40's and going bald.

Background: Evert joined the Harpers not long after his time as an apprentice. He travelled up and down the Sword Coast, fighting evil where ever the organization needed him to. After a mission went horrible wrong, with him losing his foot and leaving his face scarred after a fight with a cambion, he decided that it was time to settle down.

Personality: Evert is a loner. He never wastes more words on the villagers than he must and keeps to himself for most of the time. He is a sucker for a good puzzle and nothing interests him more than magical items.

Connections: Evert is still a member of the Harpers and every now and then some agent pays him a visit. His expertise and knowledge of magical items is valuable to the organization.

Secret: No one in Deadsnows know that Evert is a part of the Harpers, though Rubert suspects. Evert also fears that the Cambion who took his leg will return and kill him.

Thodvar Nun

CG Human ranger 3 (Outlander)

Thodvar Nun hails from Furitep in Mulhorand. His skin is dark and he braids his black hair. He wears skins of bears and boars. Nun is usually accompanied by 2 large mastiff dogs, a common breed in Furitep but a rare sight in the Nether Mountains.

Background: Born and raised in slavery Thodvar never had any choice about what profession he learned. Though he loved the dogs he was to take care of he hated his masters and their treatment of their canine stock. On a hunting trip Nun lost his temper after his owner had beaten one of his dogs to death for failing to catch a prey. Thodvar attacked his master and killed him. He took the remaining dogs

and fled. He wandered for many years, breeding his dogs and selling pups, before settling down in Icespear Valley.

Personality: Thodvar is wary of strangers and likes dogs more than people. He watches carefully for how people treat his dogs and how they accept people before he decides how to react. He is a no-nonsense type of person, preferring facts over fiction. The slave in him makes it hard for him to look people straight in the eye.

Connections: Thodvar knows the people of Icespear Valley and the farmers in the neighboring valleys.

Secret: Thodvar despises Harad, simply because his dogs don't like the halfling and Nun feels that there's something about the halfling that reminds him off his former masters.

Kax

CE small humanoid (Kobold Dragonshield)

Kax is red skinned though the scales in his back range from crimson to golden. His eyes are yellow and a scar crosses his face, leaving one of his eye dark and dull. Most of the time he wears a blood stained cloth over his bad eye. Kax wears a studded leather armor and fights with a beautiful shortsword, obviously crafted by elven hands.

Background: Kax was the first to hatch of his litter and before he was three days old he had eaten two of his brothers. His father taught him the art of kobold warfare and he has been led many raids, growing the hoard of the dragon. Lately Kax has been dreaming of replacing his father and he hopes that he can manipulate events so that Alizarinathrax will get angry at Roqua and eat him. Kax has already talked many of the best warriors over to his side and though he knows that Roqua is aware of what he's doing Kax doesn't mind. In fact it only amuses him seeing how paranoid Roqua has become.

Personality: Kax is the epitome of the despicable and sadistic kobold. He enjoys seeing the fear in his adversaries eyes. He only fights when he knows he has the upper hand and even then he fights as dirty as he possible can. Kicking a man in the groin, no problem. Murdering the innocent, burning, maiming



or terrorizing in any way, Kax has no problem using any of these techniques if they assure that he has the advantage. To say the least, he is a cunning, manipulative son of a female dog.

Roqua

LE small humanoid (Kobold Dragonshield)

Roqua is aging, his red skin is loosing its color and the scales on his back have lost their vibrant hue. His claws are many broken and the same goes for the horns on his head. He wears an ancient scale mail, a treasure he aquired years ago from a gnome adventurer he killed. He uses both a crossbow and a spear.

Background: Roqua took over the clan after murdering his father, Ragek, in his sleep. When Alizarinathrax claimed the lair he quickly perfected his art of groweling. The dragon was amused with Roqua's pleading and allowed him to lead the clan. Roqua has managed to make the clan's life a whole lot better and the most of the older kobolds in the clan are grateful for eating something more than fungi.

Personality: Roqua is a master manipulator and has had years of experience learning how to read people and understanding what makes them tick. He is not only cunning but also a huge opportunist, making the most of every situation. Roqua knows every nook of the lair and if the lair is attacked he quickly summons all his warriors and makes a stand. He is the one that has crafted most of the traps in the lair. Roqua is intelligent, not only for a kobold, and he's eloquent and charismatic. He will resort to any means to ensure his survival, he would prefer that it wasn't at the cost of his clan though that wouldn't stop him. The years have taught Roqua that self preservation is the best preservation.

Yappa

LE small humanoid (Kobold Scaled Sorcerer)

Yappa is the Burnt Hand Clan religious leader and she wears that mantle with pride. She dons a feathery headpiece and a grimson cloak. She recently replaced her mentor, after the older shaman displeased the dragon and got eaten by Alizarinathrax. Yappa has a

crude holy symbol but her main treasure is a gnome skull the clan brought the temple few years ago, something that has more value in Yappa eyes than all the dragon hoard.

Background: Yappa is quite young considering her status. She feels chosen by Kurtulmak, for ever since she can remember she has dreamt the kobold god. The former shaman discovered that Yappa was wise beyond her years and seemed to be blessed with Kurtulmak's divine spirit, for Yappa learned quickly how to channel Kurtulmak's rage and her hatred for the gnome race was endless. It didn't come as a surprise to Yappa when the dragon decided to eat the old shaman, for Yappa was convinced that the former shaman was overly fond of Alizarinathrax and Yappa believed that it didn't please Kurtulmak. Lately Yappa has been a huge advocat of attacking Deadsnows, simply for the fact that Yappa believes that gnomes must live there.

Personality: Yappa is wise and wicked. She strongly believes that Kurtulmak has chosen her and that her dreams are visions sent by the god. She delights in tormenting and torturring gnomes and hates the small race more than one could deem healthy, even would be easy to say that Yappa is uterly obsessed with killing and hurting gnomes, so that it borders on the sane.

Rolinda Fenabar

CG dwarf Cleric 6 of Dugmaren Brightmantle (Sage)

Rolinda is a tall shield and proud shield dwarf. She usually wears a tabbard emblazoned with Brightmantle's holy symbol, a rune encrusted tome.

Background: Rolinda was born in Citadel Feldbar but moved with her parents to the Fenabar Hold, where she learned the teachings of Dugmaren Brighmantle. She took over as leader of the Fenabar clan a couple of decades ago and is generally well recieved by her people. She has kept a good relationship with the neighbouring dwarf clans and citadels, and the clan is on good terms with the people in Deadsnows.

Personality: Rolinda is calm and wise. She tends



to take the highroad, a firm believer in karma and she trusts that people are in one way or another responsible for their own fate. She is grateful and helpful to those that she deems to be friends to clan Fenabar.

Secret: Rolinda is ashamed that the clan's library has been the setting of possible two murders. She has locked the library and feels that in a way Dugmaren has left her. She is very conflicted when the PCs find her, especially since the hobgoblins got away with some of the relics from the clan's chapel.

Kurluar Haerlskeel

LN Gnome Paladin 8 (Noble)

Kurluar is a rockgnome, leader of the small community in Graevelwood. He is a warrior and usually wears some part of his magical plate mail. He is a follower of Gaerdal Ironhands.

Background: Kurluar was born to be the leader of Graevelwood and was taught how to be a fair and just leader from early age. Still, he has seen more of the world than most of the gnomes living in Graevelwood, since he was a part of the famous Red Riders adventuring group, that delved into Undermountain and discovered many treasures (with a successful **DC 14 Intelligence Wisdom check** the PCs know this). In recent years Kurluar has been training his son to take his place.

Personality: Kurluar is fair, just but strict. He expects that the people in Graevelwood abide to the clanhold's law and the council's rulings. He is unusual for a rockgnome, for he doesn't like any luxury and excess. He is sober in mind and mood and not one to make a joke or jest.

Connections: Kurluar is in good relationship with the dwarven clans in the North. He was also a member in the Order of the Gauntlet and still follows their creed.

Clitterbright Kerliaroot

CG Cleric of Garl Clittergold 5 (Acolyte)

Kerliaroot is a likeable middle aged female rock gnome. She wears brightly colored robes and often wears flowers in her hair. She wears a small scepter,

with a gold nugget on top, Clittergold's holy symbol.

Background: Kerliaroot was a carefree and easy-going rockgnome when she had a dream, where Garl Clittergold said that she was to be his cleric. She took that dream seriously and became an acolyte for the local cleric. After she had learned to become a cleric she ventured out into the world, joined the Harpers and had a few adventures, before returning to Graevelwood.

Personality: Kerliaroot is still carefree and easy-going. She is likeable and fun to be around. Yet she is wise and a shrewd judge of characters.

Connections: Kerliaroot is still a member of the Harpers and will help any Harper who seeks her out (a Harper PC knows that she's a Harper with a successful **DC 12 Wisdom Insight check**).

Secret: Kerliaroot knows about Mugfyller for she was sent back to Graevelwood to investigate Zhentarim involvement in the clanhold.

Blaiky Mugfyller / Jorn Skinner

LE Half-elf Bard 9 (Charlatan)

Blaiky is a blond haired, blue eyed half-elf, usually wearing colorful clothes and high leather boots. He is quick with a smile and strives to keep his customers happy.

Background: Born and raised as Jorn Skinner in the Dalelands Blaiky was the eight child to the poor Skinner family, his father aging fast, to the dismay of his mother, who got through the day by drinking poorly distilled homemade wine. He soon learned, from his older brothers, how to take care of himself and ran away from home shortly after turning 13 years old. He found his way to Marsember and joined small band of thieves and scoundrels, one connected with the Zhentarim. His resourcefulness and cunning quickly caught the eye of the Black Networks leaders and he was soon sent out on different missions, the most recent one being securing Zhentarim's influence on the trade routes from Anauroch to the Silver Marches.

Personality: Blaiky is ruthless, selfish and sly as a cambion. Towards the people of Graevelwood he plays the role of the joyous and happy-go-lucky



Blaiky Mugfyller. Blaiky is a devout follower of Cyric.

Connections: Blaiky is a member of the Zhentarim and devoted to the Black Networks cause. If the PCs are in the Zhentarim they know of Blaiky's connection with the Network with a successful **DC 15 Wisdom (Insight)** check.

Secret: Blaiky's real identity is something he wishes to remain secret, for he is still securing the Zhentarim influence on the trade routes.

Queen E'alatha

CN Aranea Ghost (Noble)

In life Queen E'Alatha used number of different guises, though most often she appeared as a hauntingly beautiful Calimshite female, dressed so it didn't leave much room for imagination.

Background: E'Alatha was queen from the moment she hatched in the Webbed Sanctuary. She was a high ranking Leiran cleric and strived to keep clan save, especially during the Spellplague. When she learned about the impending hobgoblin attack she had her must trusted advisors take the Queen Egg and secure it. After the Blood of Morueme had penetrated Laz'Shadamar's defenses, she called what was left of her court to gather in the Royal Palace. She decided that it was a better fate to die rather than face a life of slavery.

Personality: E'alatha is a true Leiran, she prefers to distort the truth whenever and mask her identity. For E'alatha it's all smoke and mirrors.

Kaxlarea

Insane Phase Spider

Kaxlarea is a large monster, it's body blue with yellow markings. It's eight eyes are red. Static energy crackles around it.

Background: Many years ago the leaders of the aranea convinced Kaxlarea to serve as midwife in the Webbed Sanctuary, a role she took on gladly and with great honour. When the Blood of Morueme the Sorcerer Supreme cursed the arachnid with insanity. She relives the attack again and again and her failure

in protecting the eggs and the young aranea.

Personality: Before the attack Kaxlarea was happy to serve the aranea, now she's but a fracture of her former self, lost in nightmarish insanity.

Ardo'Uloan, Son of Morueme

LE Blue Half-dragon hobgoblin Sorcerer 9 (Urchin)

Ardo is a wicked and cruel minded half-dragon hobgoblin sorcerer. His wings are developed and his scales blue. He favours lightning spells above all else. Ardo is vain and dresses like a noble human, and he prefers that he is addressed as his majesty or the high-born Son of Morueme.

Background: Ardo was by far the smallest half-dragon when he was growing up, and the Morueme dragons had little faith that he would make anything of himself. He had to make a living on the streets of Doomspire, where he learned to take care of himself. His faith in himself and his abilities was, however, immense and once he learned to harness the draconic might within himself, his sorcerer powers grew quickly.

Personality: Ardo is vain and arrogant. He is wise, still not that smart. After growing up on the streets of Doomspire Ardo hates goblins with all his heart.

Secret: Ardo never experienced any love as a kid, he has a secret room in his mansion where he has toys and a blind old hobgoblin wench who he refers to as Mama. Sometimes, when Ardo feels lonely, he goes into that secret room and cuddles with Mama.

Combat: Ardo uses the hobgoblin warlord stat block (see MM p. 187) with the following changes:

Blindsight 60 feet, Damage resistance (Lightning), Languages: +Draconic

Action: Lightning breath (recharge 5-6). The half-dragon hobgoblin exhales lightning in a 30 feet line that is 5 feet wide, Each creature in that line must make a successful DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 22 (4d10) lightning damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Ardo's spell list (spell slots per day), spell save DC 14. Sorcerous origin: Draconic. Sorcery points: 9, Metamagic: Quickened spell, Heightened spell



Cantrips: *Shocking grasp, Acid splash, Message, Light*

1st level spells (4): *Thunderwave, Sleep, Mage armor*

2nd level spells (3): *Levitate, Darkvision*

3rd level spells (3): *Lightning bolt, Fear*

4th level spells (3): *Dimension door, Polymorph*

5th level spells (1): *Cone of cold*

Argur the Bloody-Handed

LE Hobgoblin Cleric of Maglubiyet 7 (Soldier)

Argur is a devout follower of Maglubiyet, some would even call him a fanatic. He is always dressed for battle, in his blood stained armor. Whenever and wherever he gets the chance will he preach the tenets of Maglubiyets over the hobgoblins of Doomspire.

Background: Argur was a part of the Chosen of Morueme before becoming a cleric. He fell in a battle in Anauroch but was brought back. He believes that Maglubiyet sent him back, when in fact it was a fellow hobgoblin who poured a potion of healing into Argur's mouth. After this Argur has been an avid spokesman of Maglubiyet and the need for the Blood of Morueme to expand, wage wars on the nearby communities, especially the human communities, who are encroaching on the hobgoblins.

Personality: Argur is pretty one-minded. War is what he loves and truly cares about. War for the sake of war. He loves battles, the smell of blood in the morning and says whatever he needs to make sure that the war parties are either preparing for war, going to war or at war.

Secret: Argur is the lover of Xe'Kala, the leader of the Chosen of Morueme, and through her he hopes to get all the war parties to unite and march against the other communities in Nether Mountains.

Combat: Argur uses the hobgoblin warlord stat block with the following changes:

Abilities: Int 11 (0), Wis 14 (+2)

Action: Channel divinity (2/rest). Guided strike, War God's Blessing.

Action: Destroy undead (CR ½)

Argur's spell list, spellsave DC 13, Domain: War

Cantrips: *Light, Resistance, Sacred Flame, Thaumaturgy*

1st level spells: *Bane, Divine favor, Shield of favor, Bless*

2nd level spells: *Hold Person, Aid, Silence*

3rd level spells: *Spiritual weapon, Bestow curse, Spirit guardians*

4th level spells: *Freedom of Movement*

Artual

LE Medusa Cleric of Loviatar 4 (Far Traveller)

Artual is a stunning and incredible beautiful creature, if you look past the snakes she has instead of hair. She dresses provocatively, displaying her feminine figures and her many scars with pride. She never leaves her whip and loves nothing more than the sound of it.

Background: Artual fled from Arn more than three decades ago, after a group of adventurers invaded her lair, using illusion spells against her. She came to Doomspire, after finding her way through the High Forest and found that some of the hobgoblins open to hear about Loviatar. As a part of a sadomasochistic ritual she allowed one hobgoblin to impregnate her. She has no love for her daughter, though she finds her and her war party a useful tool.

Personality: Artual is best described as a cruel, sadistic bitch. She loves tormenting other creatures in any way possible. She uses whatever form of violence and torture, just to hear her victim beg for mercy. For her torture is not just a form to show her devotion to Loviatar, but also an art form and something that gives her immense pleasure, especially sexual-wise.

Secret: Artual fears nothing more than having adventurers invading her lair again, especially illusionists. If the PCs use illusions against her, she will try to flee and let other fight for her.

Combat: Artual uses the same stat block as the medusa (see MM p. 214) with the following changes:

Action: Channel divinity (1/rest) Inflict pain. As an action, Artual presents her holy symbol. One creature within 30 feet of Artual must make a Wisdom saving throw. If the creature fails its saving throw it falls down prone, incapacitated for 1 round.

Replace shortsword with whip.

Artual's spell list, spell save DC 12

Cantrips: *Guidance, Light, Resistance, Sacred flame*



1st level spells: *Infllict wounds, Protection from good, Sanctuary, Bane*

2nd level spells: *Blindness, Hold person x2*

Sha'Xala

LE half-dragon/hobgoblin Wizard 12 (Criminal)

Sha'Xala is blue scaled, winged Hobgoblin. He prefers blue and black clothes. He has a black steel staff topped with a fist sized bloodstone.

Background: Sha'Xala has spent his whole life with the Blood of Morueme. He has fought hard to become Second Sorcerer in the tribe and waits for a chance to become Sorcerer Supreme. He felt the change in the aranea slaves and after an investigation he found out that the Egg had been discovered. Through use of magic he learned that the PCs have it.

Personality: Sha'Xala is very intelligent, dominant and despises dwarves and humans. He firmly believes in his own superiority.

Combat: Sha'Xala uses the hogoblin warlord stat block (see MM p. 187) with the following changes:

Abilities: Int 16

Blindsight 60 feet, Damage resistance (Lightning), Languages: +Draconic

Action: Lightning breath (recharge 5-6). The half-dragon hobgoblin exhales lightning in a 30 feet line that is 5 feet wide, Each creature in that line must make a successful DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 22 (4d10) lightning damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

Sha'Xala's spell list, spell save DC 16, Arcane tradition: Transmutation. Transmutation savant, Minor alchemy, Transmuter's stone (Resistance to fire), Shapechanger.

Cantrips: *Shocking grasp, True strike, Prestidigitation, Mending, Light*

1st level spells: *Disguise self, Feather fall, Mage armor, Magic missile*

2nd level spells: *Enlarge, Levitate, Misty step*

3rd level spells: *Slow, Gaseous form, Lightning bolt*

4th level spells: *Stoneskin, Polymorph*

5th level spells: *Hold monster, Wall of stone*

6th level spells: *Disintegrate*

XE'KALA

LE Half-Dragon Hobgoblin Wizard 18

Combat: Xe'Kala uses the Archmage stat block (see MM p. 342) with the following changes:

Blindsight 60 feet, Damage resistance (Lightning), Languages: +Draconic

Action: Lightning breath (recharge 5-6). The half-dragon hobgoblin exhales lightning in a 30 feet line that is 5 feet wide, Each creature in that line must make a successful DC 12 Dexterity saving throw, taking 22 (4d10) lightning damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

BALUGAR

CE Half-ogre Warlord

Combat: Balugar uses the Hobgoblin Warlord stat block (see MM. p. 187) with the following changes:

Abilities: Str 19 (+4).

Action: Melee weapon attack: +11 to hit.

ARUMA

NE Half-Medusa Warlord

Combat: Aruma uses the Hobgoblin Warlord stat block (see MM p. 187) with the following changes:

Action: Petrifying gaze. As per medusa ability (see MM p. 214), only one creature per round.

GORAN STEELSHIELD

CE Were-wolf Hobgoblin Warlord

Combat: Goran uses the Hobgoblin Warlord stat block (see MM p. 187) with the following changes:

When Goran is under 30% health, he involuntarily changes into hybrid werewolf form. Use werewolf stat block (see MM p. 211).

Ruthless Roudy

LE Hobgoblin Warlord

Combat: Routhless Roudy uses the Hobgoblin Warlord stat block (see MM. p. 187).

Ramal Wyrystone

N Gnome Druid Circle of the Land 10 (Hermit)



Ramal is old and his curly hair white. His eyes are grey as a stormy sky. He always carries a gnarly wooden staff and wears a brown cloak. His cat, Shadow, is usually not far behind Ramal.

Background: Ramal has been druid in Arn Forest for many years. He has fought both monsters and men, eager to defend the woods from all threats. He joined the Emerald Enclave many years ago and has for some time now hoped to gain the status of arch-druid, though he hasn't been able to convince his fellow circle members yet.

Personality: Ramal is sly as a fox, patient like a stone and focused like an eagle. He is revered in Graevelwood, just as he is feared, and many children in the village are raised fearing the old druid. The people in the clanhold seek his wisdom, though his gruff manner and brutal honesty has often left people really wondering whether the old man really means to help.

Connections: Ramal is in good connection with the Emereald Enclave, should any of the PCs be part of that political faction.

Secret: If Ramal finds out about the Aranea Egg he will see that as an opportunity to improve his standing in the druid circle, even be what he needs to elevate to arch-druid status.

Combat: Ramal is a 10th level druid (see MM p. 346), except as follows:

His Wisdom is 17 and Intelligence is 13. See chapter 2 for his spells. He can shapechange into a bird and usually favors an owl. His attacks bonus is +4, +6 to hit with spell attacks. Ramal speaks fluent dwarven, elven and giant, as long with druidic, gnomish and common, due to Linguistic feat.

Ramal's spell list, spell save DC 15

Cantrips: *Druidcraft, Shillelagh, Thorn whip, Guidance*

1st level spells: *Entangle, Cure wounds, Faerie fire*

2nd level spells: *Spike growth, Gust of wind, Barkskin*

3rd level spells: *Conjure animals, Sleet storm, Wind wall*

4th level spells: *Conjure minor elemental, Ice storm*

5th level spells: *Conjure elemental, Insect plague*

Ri'Uala

CN Aranea ex-Cleric 5 (Acolyte)

Ri'Uala in human form is usually an elderly Imaskari woman, with flowing black hair and grey eyes. Her body is ovarian and feminine, yet her hands are long and wiry.

Background: Before the Blood of Morueme attacked Laz'Shadamar Ri'Uala was an acolyte in the Hidden Temple. She studied the Lady of the mists and worked hard to become a Worshiper of the Mistshadow. After being enslaved, Ri'Uala gained trust among the Aranea and became one of their leaders.

Personality: Ri'Uala is charismatic and charming in human form. She listens intently and nods her head when other people speak to her. She still teaches the tenets of Leira to the Aranea and prays that the Dark Mother will save them. She has used the time as slave to master her art of telling lies, especially to her hobgoblin masters (she has +10 to Charisma (Deception) checks). She will do anything to help the PCs, as long as it furthers their cause of freeing the Aranea slaves.

Secret: Ri'Uala and Di'ana were lovers before the attack on Laz'Shadamar. They haven't met since then and Ri'Uala believes Di'Ana to be dead.

Gar'Relatha

N Aranea (Courtier)

Gar'Relatha in human form resembles a Tethyrian noble woman. She holds her head up high and her green eyes are vivid and full of life, almost like dancing auroras.

Background: Gar'Relatha spend her days in the royal court in Laz'Shadamar before the hobgoblin attack. She loved the little lies and all the secrets surrounding the palace and the court. She flourished, going from one lover to the next, whispering innocent lies in their ears. And she excelled in it. After the attack her health has been deteriorating and when the PCs arrive in Doomspire she has quite ill. The only thing that seems to make her better is being close to the Aranea Queen Egg.



Personality: Gar'Relatha is lovely, beautiful and sensual. She could charm any man and woman. However, speaking the truth isn't her strongest suit and she loves to play little games and see how people react. She smart enough to make sure that no one ever suspect her.

Secret: Gar'Relatha holds a divine spark of the goddess Leira in her body, and that is the cause of her worsening health. As much as Ri'Uala tries to convince the other Aranea that the Dark Mother will save them, their faith is diminishing and so is Leira's divine spark. It is vital that the PCs save Gar'Relatha from Doomspire, if Leira is to rise again.

Di'Ana

LN Aranea Wizard 3 (Charlatan)

Di'Ana in human form is usually a Calimshite girl, with an hourglass body shape and rich dark hair. Her ears are slightly pointed and her eyes have the color of gold.

Background: Di'Ana was a top student to the Aranea master illusionist, Kir-Alu. Her affinity for the phantasmal forces were great and many believed that she would assume the role of a master illusionist. After the attack on Laz'Shadamar however, she lost all her spellbooks and she hasn't been able to study magic for years, making her depressed.

Personality: Di'Ana is sweet and homely, almost motherly, yet her eyes display much sadness. She misses her spellbooks and her connection with the Art.

Secret: Di'Ana and Ri'Uala were lovers, but Di'Ana never took it seriously, her focus was on her studies. She longs more for her spellbooks than for Ri'Uala.

Gor-Ali

CG Aranea Fighter 2 (Soldier)

Gor-Ali in human form resembles a burly Illuskan, almost like the barbarians in the North. He seems fit and strong, though years of malnourishment and torture has left its mark on him.

Background: Gor-Ali lived a good life in Laz'Shadamar, he had a female partner, Is'aBel and they enjoyed everything that the city had to offer. In

the attack he lost Is'aBel and has for years fostered the hope that she died in the attack, instead of being one of slaves in the brothels. After coming to Doomspire Gor-Ali has become one of the most trusted Aranea, since he strives to make their life not as miserable. Ever since the Aranea Queen Egg was taken from the stasis chamber in the Ironboot Mine (see Part 1: Trouble under Ironboot Mine) he has been more prone to losing his temper, just as the other male Aranea.

Personality: Gor-Ali is kind hearted, but firm. His sole goal is to make sure that he and the Aranea survive. And he feels that survival is the objective, not dying fighting for freedom.

Secret: Gor-Ali fears nothing more than seeing Is'aBel again. They had a huge fight just before the attack and he feels responsible for whatever her fate was. Feel free to use Is'aBel as you see fit.

Paren Ousstyl

CE Drow Necromancer 10 (Noble)

Paren is a gaunt looking, balding drow. His skin is dry and his fingers are long, almost clawlike. He has purple eyes and large eagle nose.

Background: Paren was in Maermydra when Lolth fell silent. His house, Ousstyl, tried to seize initiative and become a major player in the city. It didn't go as planned and Paren was forced to flee. After roaming the Underdark for years he stumbled upon Laz'Shadamar and decided that it suited perfectly as a home for him and his loyal undead servants.

Personality: Paren is about as likable as a dead spider. He is cruel, selfish, completely absorbed in his necromantic studies. He has no respect for anyone non-drow and his only fear is that his rivals from Maermydra will find out where he is.

Combat: Paren uses the Drow Mage statblock (see MM p. 128), with the following exceptions:

Summon Demon becomes Summon Shadow. Paron can summon a undead shadow 1/day.

Paron has following spells:

Cantrips: Chill touch, Mage hand, Acid splash,



Poison spray

1st level (4 slots): False life, Ray of Sickness, Mage Armor, Expeditious retreat

2nd level (3 slots): Ray of Enfeeblement, Web, Crown of Madness

3rd level (3 slots): Animate dead, Vampiric touch, Lightning bolt

4th level (2 slots): Blight, Dimension door

5th level (2 slots): Bigby's hand

Helga from Daggerdale

CG Human ex-Cleric 5 (Acolyte)

Helga, even in her sixties, is stunning. She is graceful and lovely, her golden hair flowing and it's easy to imagine the awe she must've inspired in the Dalelands before being captured. Unfortunately she has a massive scar in her face, something she tries to hide.

Background: Helga comes from Daggerdale and used to be a cleric of Sune. She was a part of troupe travelling from Cormyr to Everlund. The troupe was attacked by the Skinners, and that attack left a terrible scar in Helga's face, making her lose her faith in Sune, the goddess of beauty. After coming to Doomspire she has made it her objective to help the other slaves as much as she can.

Personality: Helga is bitter and lonely, she misses her friends and family in the Dales, but mostly she mourns her good looks.

The Ironboot clan

The clan came to the Nether Mountains a couple of years ago, in hope to carve out an existence for themselves. They found promising veins of iron and copper and their mine has grown larger and larger.

The dwarves of the Clan look to Moradin as their patron deity. Their mine contains a large temple devoted to him, though it also contains shrines dedicated to other dwarven deities. The clan is mostly lawful good though chaotic individuals are found amongst them. The clan is in good relations with the people of Deadsnows and the other two

dwarven clans.

The clan's leaders are concerned about the rising frequency of kobold raids and the fact that lately the non-civilised races have been on the rise in the mountains.

Dorna

LG Dwarf Cleric 5 (Folk hero)

Dorna is loud, rowdy and strong. She wears her decorated breast plate with pride, the armor sporting the golden holy symbol of Moradin. She is stocky and muscular, her golden hair flowing freely down her shoulders. Her eyes are blue and portray Dorna's wisdom.

Personality: Dorna is sure of herself, wise and just. She follows the tenets of Moradin to the extreme and feels that he is her guide in life. She is headstrong and stubborn and angers easily, but if she has done wrong unto someone she quickly sees her error and apologizes.

Isarn

CG Dwarf fighter 2 (Noble)

Isarn is simple and an easy-going dwarf. He cares deeply for the prosperity of the clan and will stop at nothing in building the riches of the clan. He usually wears his chain mail though he inherited and owns a magical plate mail (one that the kobolds steal and store in the dragon's hoard) he rarely wears it. He usually wears a rune encrusted battleaxe that's called Flamebitter, due to its flaming ability.

Personality: Isarn is charismatic and likeable fellow. He treats his clan members well and they would follow him almost anywhere. Isarn isn't necessarily the wisest dwarf around and he looks to both Thorbin and Dorna for advice.



Appendix B: Handouts

Handout #3

The Aranea are a strange and secretive lot. This is an arachnid race, created by sorcerer of olden time, my studies are misleading, some sources point to the evil Fey'ri wizards in Hellgate Keep, while other seem to point even further back in time, to Netheril. Whether either of these is true, the Aranea themselves have no legends of their origin.

There are three great clans of aranea, each with their own great city. There are a few smaller communities and there are probably more aranea around us today than we realise.

Each city is led by a queen. From my travels I have learned that each of them has a similar looking scepter, crowned with a white stone, one radiating strong magic, an item I figure that my mentor would love to get a chance to investigate further.

The Aranea are a remarkable race. They are extraordinarily good shapeshifters and are able to mimic the humanoid races in almost all manner. The only way I have found to discover if a human, elf or dwarf is in fact an aranea, is to look at their hands. We have five fingers on each hand, while they, in their natural form have only four. They seem to have a problem understanding how to use their little finger.

- Excerpt from Laerel's treatise on shapeshifters.

Handout #2

After we left the Citadel, we spent some days hunting for displacer beasts in Vordrorn forest, with no luck. These critters are damn hard to find! I got took ill and we needed to rush to Ascore to find a priest. Fortunately there was an Elmaterian in town, who took care of the old bastard.

Rowena suggested we try our luck in Arn forest, so we travelled south. The air was dry, the eastborn wind carried sand from arid Anauroch and we had to cover our faces. When we finally reached the forest, it was infected with goblins and owlbears.

We found a small settlement, it seems that a rock gnome family has established a clanhold there, one they call Graevelwood. We stopped there and once the gnomes found out we were mercenaries they wanted us to root out the evil creatures in the woods. Antoine bargained with the clanhold leader, in hope of getting paid more than Lord Argosa paid for the blood of a displacer beast.

While we were there, I heard about strange creatures living somewhere under the forest, spidery beings that seemingly can change their shape. While we fought the goblins, I tried to find some evidence of this rumour, to no avail.

- Memoirs of a Mercenary



Handout #1

18TH OF TARSAXH

GOOD DAY. TEAM 2 FOUND A STRONG VEIN, MORADIN BE PRAISED. DORNA BLESSED THE MINE. TEAM 1 WORKED THE VEIN AND IT'S PURE. VILMA AND NORBERT ANNOUNCED ISARN THAT THEY ARE EXPECTING. THEIRS WILL BE THE FIRST IRONBOOT BORN IN THE NETHERS. MORADIN SURELY HAS BLESSED OUR CLAN.

A PART OF DELZOUN OF OLD. WE NEED TO GO DEEPER. I ONLY FEAR THAT THE MASSIVE CAVE WILL OPEN UP TO THE UNDERDARK. I'VE PROPOSED TO ISARN THAT WE STATION GUARDS AT THE OPENING.

30TH OF TARSAXH

22ND OF TARSAXH

THE MINERS OPENED A NEW BRANCH, FOLLOWING THE NEW VEIN. IT HAS ALREADY PRODUCED OVER FOUR UNITS OF PURE IRON.

DORNA HELD A SERVICE IN HONOR OF VILMA'S PREGNANCY, ALL THE WOMEN ATTENDED AND GRATULATED HER.

THE FENABARS CAME AROUND COLLECTING THEIR LOAD, ISARN FINALLY MUSTERED THE COURAGE TO TELL THEM THAT THEY'VE HAD ENOUGH AND THAT THEY HAVE NO CLAIM ON US. THEY LEFT EMPTY HANDED, WHICH IS GOOD THOUGH I FEAR THAT THE HARSH WORDS THE FENABARS AND ISARN EXCHANGED WILL NOT BE FORGOTTEN ANY TIME SOON.

STRANGE DAYS! THERE'S A STRANGE ROOM IN THE CAVERN, COVERED WITH GLYPHS AND WAR-DENS AND STRANGE WRITING. DORNA WARNED ISARN AGAINST OPENING IT, BUT CURIOSITY GOT THE BETTER OF HIM.

THE ROOM IS FULL OF LEATHER BAGS AND SACKS FULL OF TRINCKETS, CRUDE JEWELRY AND GEMS. IT LOOKED LIKE SACRIFICES OF SOME SORT TO ME. A HUGE OVALSHAPED WHITE GEM LAY ON A PEDESTAL. DORNA ADVISED AGAINST TAKING THE GEM, BUT ISARN INSISTED.

ONCE HE REMOVED THE GEM FROM THE ROOM THE GLYPHS STARTED GLOWING. I HAVE A BAD FEELING ABOUT THIS.

1ST OF MIRTUL

28TH OF TARSAXH

THE NEW BRANCH OPENED INTO A LARGE CAVERN. TEAM 2 INVESTIGATED IT AND MAYHAPS IT WAS

THE HORROR! I TRIED TO WARN HIM. I TRIED TO TELL HIM TO NOT TAKE THE STRANGE GEM. HE DIDN'T LISTEN AND NOW THE CURSE IS UPON US...

